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BY PHYSICS WALLAH

PRAHAAR

MAINS WALLAH (STATIC + CURRENT)

Final Hit To CSE Mains 2024

INTERNATIONAL RELATIONS



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Features

- Comprehensive and Concise Notes
- Inter-linking of Current and Static Topics
- Updated Data and Facts
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INDIA AND ITS NEIGHBORHOOD RELATIONS

External Affairs Minister S Jaishankar in April 2024 said that India's ties with all neighbour's, except China and Pakistan, have improved significantly compared to previous times.

With respect to China, he said India's relationship with China was "challenging," but the country was "confident" and capable of protecting its interests.

HISTORICAL OVERVIEW OF INDIA'S NEIGHBORHOOD

- **British Policy:** British policy towards the neighborhood was dictated by its need to secure its Indian Colony. The British used Nepal, and Afghanistan as buffer states against Chinese and Russian states respectively. Even in the Indian Ocean region and in West Asia, British control was aimed to ensure the security of Indian borders.
- **Nehru's Policy (1954):**
 - **Nehruvian 'family approach':** The 'family approach' propagated the idea of the 'part of one theory. Because of the British legacy, the focus during the Nehruvian era was primarily on security aspects and not much on economic dimensions such as building developmental projects etc.
- **Gujral Doctrine (1996):**

India and It's Neighbours



Four Pillars of Gujral Doctrine:

- **Non-Reciprocity:** India provides assistance and concessions to smaller neighbors without expecting immediate returns, building trust and goodwill.
 - **No Interference:** India respects the sovereignty of neighboring countries, refraining from interference in their internal affairs, and fostering peaceful relations.
 - **Resolve Disputes Amicably:** Disputes with neighbors are resolved through peaceful means like negotiations and diplomacy, avoiding escalations.
 - **Comprehensive Regional Cooperation:** India actively engages in regional initiatives to promote economic integration and collaboration, aiming for shared prosperity.
- **Manmohan Doctrine:** It was focused on creating Economic Interdependence through enhanced trade relations and regional integration. However, due to coalition politics, India's relations with Bangladesh and Sri Lanka deteriorated.
 - **After 2014: "Neighborhood First" Policy,** proactively focuses on establishing links with India's Relations with Its Neighbors. The policy is designed to improve connections with neighbors while promoting global cooperation and peace.

Neighborhood First Policy

The "Neighbourhood First" policy aims to foster stability and prosperity through mutually beneficial, people-oriented regional frameworks. It prioritizes engagement with neighboring countries using a consultative, non-reciprocal, and outcome-oriented approach.

4 PILLARS OF POLICY

1. Diplomatic and political priority to neighborhood.
2. Active support for the development of these countries.
3. Greater connectivity and integration in the region.
4. Promote India-led regionalism where neighbors are comfortable.

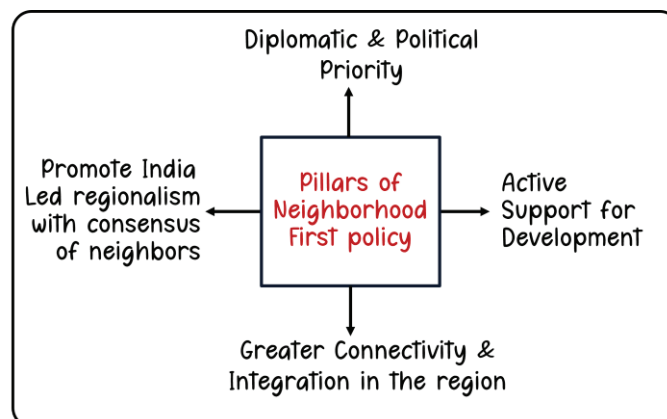
DETERMINANTS OF NEIGHBOURHOOD FIRST POLICY

- **Strategic Location Advantage:** Leveraging India's central position in South Asia and the Western Indian Ocean.
Example: India's geographical location provides it with influence and control in the region.
- **Regional Diplomacy and Discourse:** Energizing regional diplomacy by connecting with nearby countries.
Example: India's efforts to make the functioning of SAARC viable.

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- **Economic Cooperation:** Engaging in the BBIN energy development grouping, including motor vehicles, waterpower management, and inter-grid connection. **Example:** Bangladesh-Bhutan-India-Nepal (BBIN) initiative for regional energy cooperation.
- **Bilateral Issue Resolution:** Emphasizing mutual agreements to resolve bilateral concerns. **Example:** India and Bangladesh signed an agreement to implement the Land Boundary Agreement (LBA).
- **Connectivity and Cooperation:** Sign MOUs with SAARC members to enhance regional connectivity. **Example:** India's MOUs with South Asian countries to foster cooperation and connectivity.
- **Military and Defence Cooperation:** Strengthening regional security through military cooperation. **Examples:** Joint exercises like Surya Kiran with Nepal and Sampriti with Bangladesh, along with India's commitment to supporting Afghan National Army's capacity building.
- **Disaster Management and Humanitarian Aid:** Providing disaster response cooperation, resource management, and aid. **Examples:** India's significant aid to neighboring Nepal after the 2016 earthquake and providing relief measures to Afghanistan after the Taliban takeover in 2022.
- **Capacity Building and Training:** Supporting the capacity building of the Afghan National Army through training. **Example:** India's commitment to enhance the capabilities of the Afghan National Army.



POSITIVE ASPECTS	CHALLENGES
• India's Monroe Doctrine: Changing the "Big Brother" Image. The "Neighbourhood First" policy aims for non-reciprocal, consultative, and cooperative development assistance to neighbors. • Sub-Regional Cooperation: BBIN and BIMSTEC ◦ Initiatives like BBIN and BIMSTEC promote sub-regional cooperation. ◦ Former Sri Lankan PM Ranil Wickremesinghe suggests an Economic Integration Roadmap for sub-regional collaboration. • Emergency Response: SAARC Assistance and Operations. SAARC assistance fund and operations like Sanjeevani and Neer provide support during emergencies. Medical assistance is offered to countries, such as aiding the Maldives during a water crisis. • Enhancing Connectivity: Infrastructure Projects. Projects like Sagarmala, the greater male connectivity project in Maldives, BBIN, and Kaladan project enhance connectivity. • Maritime Security: India as a Net Security Provider. India assumes the role of a Net Security Provider in the Indian Ocean region. PM Modi's vision of SAGAR promotes security and growth for all. • Developmental Assistance: Community and Quick Impact Projects. High Impact Community Development Projects and Quick Impact projects facilitate developmental assistance.	• Rising Chinese footprint: For example, China's Belt and road initiative (BRI) projects in countries like Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives have raised concerns about debt sustainability and potential implications for regional security. • Domestic politics: Examples, the Tamil issue in Sri Lanka, the Teesta water-sharing issue with Bangladesh, the Rohingya issue and internal coup in Myanmar, and Taliban-led Afghanistan have all had an impact on India's relations with these countries, making it difficult to maintain a seamless implementation of the neighborhood first policy. • Border and river water disputes: For example, the border conflict between India and Nepal in 2020 over the Kalapani-Lipulekh area strained bilateral ties, leading to a deterioration in cooperation and trust between the two countries. The recent standoff between India and China in Doklam and Galwan Valley has resulted in a trust deficit. • Extreme trust deficit and rise of territorial nationalism: For example, recent border conflict between India-Nepal, India and China border issue in Galwan and Doklam • Failure of SAARC: For instance, the postponement and rescheduling due to strained relations between India and Pakistan have stalled regional cooperation initiatives and hindered the potential for collective development.

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- **COVID-19 Assistance:** Providing assistance to neighboring countries during the COVID-19 pandemic. The establishment of the SAARC COVID-19 Emergency Fund and operations like Sanjeevani and Neer have facilitated medical assistance, sharing of expertise, and supply of vaccines, highlighting India's commitment to regional solidarity.

WAY FORWARD

- **Enhanced Diplomacy and Engagement:** Increase high-level visits and regular dialogue with neighboring countries, addressing key issues and concerns.
 - **For instance,** India can engage in bilateral talks with Pakistan to address security challenges and build trust.
- **People-to-People Exchange and Cultural Ties:** Encourage cultural exchanges and tourism between India and its neighbors, fostering better understanding.
 - **For instance,** facilitating easier visa procedures for tourists from Nepal to visit Indian pilgrimage sites like Kedarnath and Pashupatinath.
- **Addressing Security Concerns:** Strengthen intelligence-sharing mechanisms and coordinated actions to combat terrorism and cross-border crimes.
- An **example** is India's collaboration with Myanmar to address insurgent groups operating along the shared border.
- **Economic Cooperation and Development:** Promote trade and investment initiatives with neighboring countries, focusing on mutually beneficial projects.
 - An **example** is India's collaboration with Bangladesh in the energy sector, such as the construction of cross-border power transmission lines.
- **Sub-regional and Regional Cooperation:** Deepen sub-regional initiatives like BBIN and BIMSTEC to enhance integration and cooperation.
 - **For instance,** India can collaborate with Bhutan and Bangladesh to promote the seamless movement of goods and people through the development of transit routes and infrastructure.

India's Neighbourhood Policy has had mixed results. While it has achieved success in areas such as economic cooperation and regional integration, challenges remain in resolving long standing bilateral disputes and countering China's growing influence in the region. Sustained efforts, proactive diplomacy, and addressing the concerns of neighboring countries will be crucial for the policy's effectiveness in the future.

MAJOR CHALLENGES IN INDIA'S NEIGHBORHOOD RELATIONS

BORDER DISPUTE

- **Civilizational State:** India, historically, identifies more as a civilizational state than a territorial state, which hampers the resolution of boundary disputes due to colonization, difficult terrain, and domestic politics.
- **Boundary Disputes:** India faces disputes with Pakistan (Kashmir), China (Ladakh, Arunachal Pradesh, Aksai Chin), Sri Lanka (Kachchatheevu island), and Nepal (Kalapani Area). Example: Recent map issue with Nepal and China, where they were claiming Indian land.
- **Limited Resolution Success:** India has only successfully resolved boundary issues with Bangladesh and Sri Lanka, resorting to wars with Pakistan and China to address disputes. Example: More than 20 rounds of talks between India and China's military (Corps commander level).
- **Security Threats:** Muchkund Dubey, the former foreign secretary, highlights that India faces security threats from its neighbors, including the spillover of ethnic conflicts, large-scale illegal migration, and the use of neighboring countries as bases for terrorism directed against India.

Why are Border Disputes not getting solved?

- **Historical Legacy:** The complex historical legacy, including the impact of colonization and the drawing of arbitrary borders, has contributed to the persistence of Indian border disputes. For example, the Kashmir dispute between India and Pakistan stems from the partition of British India in 1947.
- **Domestic Politics:** Domestic political considerations and public sentiment play a significant role in the resolution of border disputes. Political parties and nationalist sentiments often influence the stance taken by the Indian government. For instance, the border dispute with China has become a sensitive issue for Indian domestic politics.

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- **Lack of Trust and Communication:** Trust deficit and limited channels of communication between India and its neighboring countries hinder the resolution of border disputes. The lack of open dialogue and diplomatic channels can lead to misunderstandings and escalation. The border disputes with Nepal over the Kalapani area exemplify the challenges arising from trust deficits and communication gaps.
- **Geopolitical Rivalries:** Geopolitical rivalries and strategic interests of other countries in the region can impede the resolution of Indian border disputes. For example, China's close ties with Pakistan have complicated efforts to resolve the Kashmir dispute.

Way Forward:

- **Regional Cooperation:** Enhance regional cooperation frameworks like SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) to provide a platform for dialogue and conflict resolution among member countries.
- **Legal Framework:** Strengthen the legal framework for resolving border disputes through international arbitration or legal mechanisms to ensure a fair and impartial process.
- **Diplomatic Engagement:** Increase diplomatic efforts to engage in sustained dialogue with neighboring countries, fostering an atmosphere of trust and cooperation.
- **Confidence-Building Measures:** Implement confidence-building measures such as joint border patrols, cultural exchanges, and people-to-people interactions to promote mutual understanding and reduce tensions.
- **Track II Diplomacy:** Encourage Track II diplomacy initiatives involving non-governmental organizations, think tanks, and academics to facilitate informal dialogues and generate alternative solutions to border disputes.

RIVER DISPUTES

- According to UNEP, by 2030, nearly "almost half of the world's population will suffer from severe water stress." River disputes will determine India's riparian relations with its neighbors, including Pakistan, China, Bangladesh, Nepal, and Bhutan.

Brahmaputra River and India-China-Bangladesh Relations:

- **Chinese dams on the Brahmaputra:** China's upstream dams on the Brahmaputra intentionally restrict downstream water flow.
- **Concerns over China's dams:** India and Bangladesh fear that China's dams on the Brahmaputra could allow water diversion during political crises.
- **Indian dams on Teesta:** India's dams on the Teesta River, a Brahmaputra tributary, raise concerns for Bangladesh's water supply during the dry season.
- **Failed agreement on Teesta:** India and Bangladesh couldn't sign a water-sharing agreement for the Teesta River due to opposition from the West Bengal government.
- **India- Nepal:** The Kosi River dispute has strained relations between India and Nepal. Despite the signing of the Kosi Agreement in 1954, talks between the two governments have stagnated, leading to unresolved water rights issues. This has resulted in neglect of the first dam and the failure to establish a partnership for a second dam.

Way Forward:

- **Enhanced dialogue and cooperation:** Promote regular and meaningful dialogue among India and its neighbors for resolving river disputes and collaborating on joint river management projects. **Example:** The Indus Waters Treaty between India and Pakistan, facilitating cooperation on the sharing of Indus River waters.
- **Implementing sustainable water-sharing agreements:** Establish fair and scientific water-sharing agreements to ensure sustainable utilization of shared river resources. **Example:** The Ganges Water Sharing Treaty between India and Bangladesh, ensuring the fair distribution of Ganges River waters.
- **Investing in water management infrastructure:** Develop robust infrastructure for efficient water utilization and minimize conflicts through dams, reservoirs, and irrigation systems. **Example:** Construction of the Farakka Barrage by India to manage the flow of the Ganges River.
- **Environmental conservation and cooperation:** Foster joint efforts for conservation and sustainable management of water resources to reduce conflicts and promote goodwill. **Example:** Nepal, India, and Bangladesh collaborating on the sustainable management of the Mahakali River Basin through the Mahakali Treaty.

TRADE BARRIERS

- South Asia remains one of the least economically integrated regions globally, with protectionist policies, high logistics costs, a lack of political will, and a trust deficit hindering trade growth. While India's trade volume with its neighbors has increased, it has remained relatively low, accounting for only 1.7%-3.8% of the global total.

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Reasons For Low Trade:

- **Historical factors:** India's adoption of a socialist economic model and policy of import substitution, along with domestic instability in neighboring countries, have contributed to trade barriers in the region.
- **Bilateral conflicts:** Border disputes, river water disputes, and past conflicts between India and Pakistan have negatively impacted regional integration and trade.
- **Ineffective regional organizations:** SAARC's failure due to the India-Pakistan conflict and the limited effectiveness of SAPTA and SAFTA have impeded regional trade cooperation.
- **Connectivity challenges:** Difficult terrain, underdeveloped inland waterways, and inadequate border infrastructure have hindered trade and economic integration among India and its neighbors.
- **Lack of political will:** The primary focus on nation-building, security, and defense has led to a lack of prioritization and commitment to regional trade integration.
- **Economic non-complementarity:** Limited diversification and overlap in export markets, particularly in textile and apparel exports, have hindered mutual trade benefits among South Asian countries.

Way Forward:

- **Re-evaluating FTAs:** Strengthen regional agreements, like BIMSTEC and India-Sri Lanka FTA.
- **Eliminating NTBs:** Remove import barriers, and subsidies, and implement online mechanisms for resolving trade barriers.
- **Enhancing Cross-border Infrastructure:** Improve roads, air, rail links, and Integrated Check-Posts (ICPs).
- **Adopting Global Best Practices:** Learn from successful models, like Sub-Saharan Africa's online mechanism.
- **Political Will:** Overcome protectionism, and prioritize long-term trade interests.

RISING CHINESE FOOTPRINT

India's unique geographic position in South Asia and China's growing interest in the region, particularly in Afghanistan, raise geopolitical concerns. China aims to integrate Afghanistan into its Belt and Road Initiative but faces complexities due to its connections with different factions and the Uighur issue. The stability of the region and China's economic investments will impact India and other regional players.

Implications For India:

- **Economic competition:** China's investments in infrastructure projects in countries like Pakistan, Sri Lanka, and Bangladesh can create economic competition for India.
 - For instance, the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) has the potential to divert trade and investment away from India and give China greater economic leverage in the region.
- **Strategic competition:** An example of strategic competition between India and China is the border dispute in the Himalayan region of Ladakh. China's assertive actions, such as the 2020 border clash in the Galwan Valley, highlight the ongoing tensions and competition for control over disputed territories.
- **Regional dynamics:** China's influence in countries like Nepal and the Maldives has been growing, leading to a shift in regional dynamics.
 - For example, China's increasing economic and political ties with Nepal have strained India-Nepal relations, impacting India's influence in its neighboring country.
- **Security concerns:** China's military presence in the Indian Ocean, including naval deployments and the establishment of military bases in countries like Djibouti, raises security concerns for India. It increases the scope of China's power projection capabilities and potentially encroaches on India's traditional sphere of influence.
- **Balancing act:** India has sought to strengthen partnerships with countries like the United States, Japan, and Australia as a means to balance China's influence. The formation of the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) between these countries is an example of India's efforts to forge strategic alliances to counterbalance China's rise in the region.
- **China-Pakistan Alliance:** The China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) project and its deepening alliance hinder India's efforts to list Masood Azhar as a terrorist in the United Nations Security Council (UNSC) and raise concerns about the Kashmir issue.
- **Debt Trap Diplomacy:** China's use of debt trap diplomacy is evident in its acquisition of the Hambantota port in Sri Lanka on a 99-year lease, posing economic and strategic challenges for India.

Way Forward:

- **Neighborhood First:** Embracing the Gujral Doctrine of non-reciprocity, India focuses on strengthening diplomatic and political ties with its neighboring countries, emphasizing mutual benefits without expecting equivalent returns.

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- **Revitalizing SAARC:** Reviving the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) as a platform for cooperation, dialogue, and regional integration, facilitating collaboration and addressing everyday challenges.
- **Accelerating Project Completion:** Ensuring the swift completion of key projects, such as hydropower projects in Nepal and Bhutan, as well as the Kaladan Multimodal project, to enhance regional connectivity and foster economic development.
- **Leveraging Quad and Minilaterals:** Collaborating with Quad countries and other mini laterals, India seeks joint implementation of projects to improve connectivity within the region, promoting economic growth and cooperation.
- **Resolving Boundary and Water Disputes:** Actively engaging in the resolution of boundary and river water disputes to address trust deficits and strengthen relationships with neighboring countries, fostering stability and cooperation.

TERRORISM

India ranks 13th on The Global Terrorism Index (GTI) 2023,

State-Sponsored Terrorism By Pakistan:

- **Cross-Border Attacks:** Pakistan-based militant groups have been implicated in multiple cross-border attacks against India.
 - In 2020, there were several incidents along the Line of Control (LoC) in Kashmir, including the Handwara and Poonch attacks, where Indian security forces thwarted infiltration attempts by militants allegedly supported by Pakistan.
- **Proxy Warfare:** Pakistan has been accused of supporting and using terrorist groups as proxies, such as Jaish-e-Mohammed (JeM) and Lashkar-e-Taiba (LeT), to carry out attacks in the region. A recent example is militants who killed seven civilians of the minority community in twin attacks in Rajouri's Dangri village.
- **Safe Havens:** Pakistan has been accused of providing safe havens to terrorist groups within its borders. One prominent example is the presence of the Afghan Taliban and its leadership in Pakistan, which has been a source of concern for Afghanistan and the international community in efforts to achieve peace and stability in the region.
- **Low Levels of Trade:** Terrorism limits economic ties, as seen in India-Pakistan trade restrictions due to security concerns.
- **Impact on India's Image:** Terrorism affects India's global standing, hindering its rise as a stable and secure power.

Way Forward:

- **Strengthen Economic Integration:** Encourage trade liberalization and economic interdependence through regional initiatives, such as the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA), to boost economic ties and reduce dependency on volatile bilateral relations.
- **Promote Regional Initiatives:** Actively participate in regional forums like SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation) and BIMSTEC (Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation) to foster dialogue, cooperation, and regional integration.
- **Counterterrorism Cooperation:** Enhance intelligence sharing, joint counterterrorism operations, and cooperation in tackling extremist ideologies to mitigate the impact of terrorism on regional stability.
- **Nuclear Risk Reduction:** Engage in confidence-building measures and dialogue between India and Pakistan to reduce the risk of nuclear confrontation, including discussions on nuclear doctrine, communication channels, and crisis management mechanisms.
- **Enhance Cooperation:** Promote dialogue and diplomatic efforts to address boundary disputes and conflicts, fostering trust-building measures among countries in the region.

SOFT LOAN DIPLOMACY

India's soft loans to neighbors up to \$15 billion: **Former Ambassador, H.V Shringla**

A soft loan is basically a loan on easy terms and conditions as compared to other conventional loans available in the market. It means low interest rates loans, it can also include long repayment periods.

Significance:

It acts as a diplomatic tool for cordial relationships, improves economic ties and plays a role in development and also improves relationships between countries, trust building.

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**ONLYIAS**
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Sustainable development, Cultural exchange and social cohesion, Collective security, Economic integration, Counterterrorism Cooperation, Regional dynamics, Geopolitical Rivalries.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	"Increasing cross-border terrorist attacks in India and growing interference in the internal affairs of several member- states by Pakistan are not conducive for the future of SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation)." Explain with suitable examples.	2016
2.	Project 'Mausam' is considered a unique foreign policy initiative of the Indian Government to improve relationships with its neighbors. Does the project have a strategic dimension? Discuss.	2015
3.	'China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia', In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbour.	2013
4.	What do you understand by 'The String of Pearls'? How does it impact India? Briefly outline the steps taken by India to counter this.	2013
5.	What is meant by the Gujral doctrine? Does it have any relevance today? Discuss.	2013

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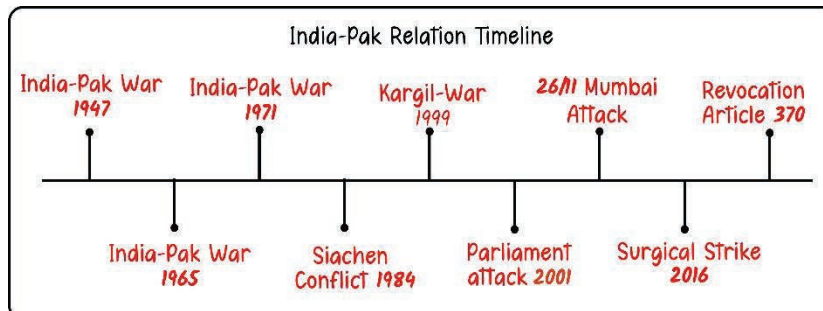
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INDIA-PAKISTAN

INTRODUCTION

- The India-Pakistan relationship is one of the most complicated among India's neighbors, but has made significant progress in lowering the "trust deficit". India seeks peaceful, amicable, and cooperative relations with Pakistan, which requires the absence of violence and terror. The two countries have linguistic, cultural, geographical, and economic ties, but their relationship is complicated due to political and historical factors.



KEY ISSUES IN INDIA-PAKISTAN RELATION

Border Issue:

- Kashmir:**
 - Wars:** Both countries have fought 3 wars on the Kashmir issue.
 - Internationalization of issue:** Pakistan aims to internationalize the Kashmir issue whereas India considers it a Bilateral issue as per the Shimla Agreement of 1972.
 - Kashmir center point:** According to scholars it is believed that till the Kashmir issue is solved, relations between India and Pakistan will not normalize.
- Siachen:**
 - Operation Meghdoot:** LoC could not be demarcated beyond NJ9842 due to bad weather.
 - Casualty:** As many as 167 Army personnel lost their lives in Siachen Glacier in the last 10 years due to weather-related incidents.
 - Agreement could not be reached:** Both countries came close to an agreement on Siachen Glacier thrice - in 1989, in 1992 and then in 2006.
- CPEC:** China's BRI project passes through POK, and it impacts India's sovereignty. The China Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC) is part of this particular initiative. CPEC violates Indian sovereignty because it runs through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK)."
- Sir Creek:**
 - Geographical location:** It is a 92 kilometers of marshy land separating Gujarat from Sindh.
 - Interpretation of Boundary:** The disagreement centers around the interpretation of the maritime boundary line between Kutch and Sindh.
 - Indian claim:** India claims that the boundary lies mid-channel as depicted in another map drawn in 1925, and that the installation of mid-channel pillars back in 1924..
- Gilgit Baltistan issue:** Recently Pakistan has given 'Provincial status' to Gilgit Baltistan making it 5th province of Pakistan. It was part of the erstwhile J&K state.

Other issues:

- Asymmetric Balancing:** Pakistan uses terrorism as a means to destabilize Kashmir. Many terrorist launch pads have been established in PoK along the Kashmir border to infiltrate terrorists into India.
- China Pakistan All Weather Friendship:**
 - Prospect of a two-front conflict:** The recent India-China border impasse in Ladakh has raised the prospect of a two-front conflict on the north-western and north-eastern borders.
 - Strategic encirclement:** China is also utilizing Pakistan to encircle India via CPEC and the Gwadar port.
 - The rising China-Pakistan-Iran-Russia axis:** This threatens India's security on its northern frontiers as well as in the Indian Ocean.

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• Trade:

- In 2022, India exported \$653M to Pakistan.
- The main products exported from India to Pakistan were Raw Sugar (\$219M), Vaccines, blood, antisera, toxins and cultures (\$79.4M), and Nitrogen Heterocyclic Compounds (\$47.1M).
- India is ranked 40 in the Economic Complexity Index (ECI 0.64) in 2022.
- In 2022, Pakistan exported \$18.1M to India.
- The main products exported from Pakistan to India were Passenger and Cargo Ships (\$17.1M), Tropical Fruits (\$233k), and Other Oily Seeds (\$227k).
- Pakistan is ranked 99 in the Economic complexity index (0.45).

WAY FORWARD

- **Talk based on UFA agreement:** The start of bilateral talks between India and Pakistan based on the "UFA" agreement will add new dimensions to diplomatic contacts by battling terrorism, liberating fishermen, meeting military personnel, and increasing religious tourism.
- **Mix of soft and hard power:** To increase bilateral interactions between India and Pakistan, a perfect mix of soft and hard power diplomacy, together with international diplomacy, is required.
- **International Pressure:** International organizations can be used to exert pressure on Pakistan to carry out anti-terrorist activities, such as the inclusion of Pakistan on the FATF Grey list, which makes it more difficult for its government to access international markets at a time when its economy is faltering.
- **Tackling Jaish-e-Mohammed:** The classification of Masood Azhar as a global terrorist by the United Nations will increase pressure on Pakistan to freeze its assets and weaken the existence of the Jaish-e-Mohammed-based organization, which is responsible for several attacks on Indian army bases.

PAKISTAN'S CRUMBLING ECONOMY AND ITS IMPACT ON INDIA

- **Growing Chinese influence in Pakistan:** According to the Indian Council for Research on International Economic Relations (ICRIER), Pakistan's profound economic problems signal that India may have to accept growing Chinese influence in Pakistan, and South Asia in general.
- **Unfriendly activities against India:** When the United States (US) enlisted Pakistan in its proxy war against the then- Union of Soviet Socialist Republics (USSR), factions of Pakistan's ruling establishment felt emboldened to take unfriendly activities against India.
- **Vested interest in stability:** However, not everyone believes Pakistan would follow an adventurous policy against India with Chinese support. "China, through its investments in Pakistan, would have a vested interest in stability, if not peace."
 - Furthermore, China has previously proved that it can exert restraint on Pakistan.
- **Anti-India activity:** It is too early to tell whether a China-Pakistan alliance will result in increased or decreased anti- India activity.
- **Require a new approach:** However, in order to offset the risks posed by a volatile scenario in our neighborhood, India may require a new approach for engaging with Pakistan's external donors.
- **Effect of jingoistic majoritarianism:** Pakistan's tragic fate today teaches the region a lesson about how jingoistic majoritarianism can wreak havoc on a nation's social and economic fabric.
- **Assessing the consequences:** As a result, India must continue to assess the short, medium, and long-term consequences of Pakistan's failure to maintain economic stability.

THE INDUS WATERS TREATY

- **Background:** Pakistan has repeatedly objected to the development of hydroelectric projects on the Indian side, demonstrating its "intransigence" in enforcing the treaty.
- **IWT and its dispute resolution process:** The IWT is an agreement between India and Pakistan for the use of water from the Indus River and its tributaries that was mediated by the World Bank (WB), signed in Karachi in 1960.

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WHY HAS INDIA ISSUED NOTICE TO PAKISTAN SEEKING CHANGES?

- India has expressed its disappointment with Pakistan's push for simultaneous dispute resolution mechanisms, through a World Bank-appointed neutral expert and arbitration by a court, also constituted by the World Bank.
- The Kishanganga project, across the Kishanganga river, which is a tributary of the Jhelum river, was inaugurated in 2018. The Ratle hydroelectric project, over the Chenab river, is currently under construction.
- Pakistan has raised concerns about the design of the Indian dams. An interim order by a court of arbitration in 2013 had allowed India to resume construction of the Kishanganga dam. The order noted that preventing the diversion of water would have to be based on Pakistan's demonstrated utilization, which it did not have when the dispute began.
- But according to Pakistan: Its concerns are important because water from the tributaries, which is used for irrigation, is necessary for food security, and the country's economic and social stability.
- Article 9 of the treaty outlines a dispute resolution process,
- Under the treaty, the two countries have agreed to first attempt to resolve disputes through the permanent commission and seek the World Bank's assistance in appointing a neutral expert or set up an arbitration at the Permanent Court of Arbitration in The Hague, Netherlands, if required.
- However, Pakistan first asked the World Bank to appoint a neutral expert as it was a "difference" and later sought an arbitration in 2016 as if the matter was a "dispute", even though India had agreed to having a neutral expert.
- In 2016, the World Bank had suspended the parallel processes saying there was the risk of contradictory outcomes that could potentially endanger the treaty itself.
- "The World Bank considers that the lack of success in finding an acceptable solution, despite the best of efforts by all parties involved over the past years, is a risk to the treaty itself. "It has therefore decided to resume the two separate processes requested by India and Pakistan."
- India has argued that having two parallel dispute resolution processes is not in line with the treaty, and that the World Bank is not in a position to interpret the pact.

CHANGE OF GOVERNMENT IN PAKISTAN AND ITS IMPACT ON INDIA

- Shehbaz Sharif was sworn in as Pakistan's 24th Prime Minister, after the recently concluded elections.
- India policy should not be viewed in isolation but in the context of the three tenures of Nawaz Sharif's "soft approach" toward India, including meeting with former Indian Prime Minister Atal Bihari Vajpayee for peace talks in 1999 as well as sharing a good relationship with Modi.
- Shehbaz Sharif too has been often touted as less hawkish toward India, unlike his predecessor. A businessman himself, he has favored trade ties between the two countries
- However, it is important to note that relations with India are not purely defined by the civilian leadership of the country but also by the military leadership. Perhaps the tone toward India may be softer in comparison to the Imran Khan government.

However, a major shift in policy is highly unlikely for two reasons.

- The **first reason** is Pakistan's current domestic turmoil. There has been substantial polarization in the Pakistani public after the no-confidence vote, including protests against the current government, and any reconciliatory move toward India could lead to major backlash from the public.
- **Second**, in recent years, competition between the **United States and China** has intensified, which has the potential to impact India-Pakistan ties. Pakistan and China ties are marked by a history of cordial relations and strong strategic partnership, while the India-U.S. bilateral relationship has grown tremendously in recent years, especially after the signing of the Basic Exchange and Cooperation Agreement during the 2020 2+2 dialogue and the establishing of the Quadrilateral Security Dialogue.
- Perhaps the most promising sign of improving ties is the ongoing ceasefire along the Line of Control, which has sustained since March 2021. The ceasefire came at a crucial time for India, which was worried about a two-front war amidst clashes with China in Galwan.

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CONCLUSION

Despite having the potential for rapid economic growth and development, South Asia has been unable to make headway. This is due primarily to disputes and tensions between India and Pakistan. Improved India-Pakistan ties can ensure that any potential threat to the subcontinent is addressed. Cooperation and cooperation based on trust can enable the building of a successful and peaceful South Asia.

Keywords:

Redressal mechanism, Anti-India activity, Strategic encirclement, Vested interest in stability, Two-front conflict, Asymmetric Balancing.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	"Increasing cross-border terrorist attacks in India and growing interference in the internal affairs of member-states by Pakistan are not conducive for the future of SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation)." Explain with suitable examples.	2016
2.	Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchanges could help generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples.	2015

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3**INDIA-BANGLADESH****INTRODUCTION**

Highlighting the importance of the relationship, Foreign Minister **Subrahmanyam Jaishankar** stated that India and Bangladesh have the potential to change “the whole geo-economics of the region.”

Prime Minister Narendra Modi also said this as the golden phase ('Sonali Adhyay') of the bilateral relationship between the two countries.

SIGNIFICANCE OF INDIA BANGLADESH RELATIONS

- **Geostrategic Significance:** Connectivity and security to North-East- As the region is landlocked and has better connectivity through Bangladesh.
- **Maritime security:** As it is strategically located in the Bay of Bengal, it is essential for securing important sea lines of communication.
- **Act East policy:** Bangladesh is India's bridge to Southeast Asia and an important partner in BBIN and BIMSTEC initiatives.
- **Trade Relations:** Bangladesh is India's largest trading partner in South Asia. India-Bangladesh bilateral trade was valued at US\$18.2 billion in 2022.
 - Being part of the South Asian Free Trade Area (SAFTA), both India and Bangladesh get preferential treatment in terms of tariff concession in each other's market.
 - Proposed Bangladesh-India Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement will cover trade in goods, services and investments.
- **Connectivity:**
 - **India-Bangladesh inland waterway route:** The route connects Tripura with the National Waterways of India through Bangladesh.
 - **Rail Connectivity:** Presently, there are Five rail links between Bangladesh and India that are operational.
 - Under the transit agreement between India and Bangladesh signed in 2010, Bangladesh **provides transit facilities to India on three modes of transport:** Inland water, rail, and coastal shipping.
 - **Coastal Shipping:** In 2018, Bangladesh and India signed a coastal shipping agreement that allows India to use the Chattogram and Mongla ports to transport goods to Tripura, Assam, and Meghalaya. There are no transit fees or customs duties for India under the agreement. This would boost India's North East connectivity and development policies.
 - In 2023 inaugurated the **Akhaura-Agartala Rail Link** that connects Bangladesh and the northeast through Tripura.
- **Blue Economy:** India and Bangladesh are cooperating in the exploration of hydrocarbons, marine resources, deep-sea fishing, marine ecology preservation, and management.
- **Rohingya issue:** In 2018 India sent supplies to help 300,000 Rohingyas as part of 'Operation Insaniyat' to support Bangladesh in its humanitarian efforts.

ISSUES IN RELATIONSHIP

- **Teesta River Dispute:** The Teesta River is a major source of irrigation for India and Bangladesh's paddy-growing regions.
 - Countries were aiming for a fair distribution of Teesta waters along the lines of the 1996 Ganga Water Treaty.
 - To keep the river's water flow to a minimum, an agreement was reached in 2011 that gave India 42.5% of the water, Bangladesh 37.5%, and the remaining 20% free rein.
- **Illegal Migration:** The flow of migrants across the Bangladeshi border as a result of the country's unrest has further caused tensions between the two nations.
- **Countering China's Influence:** Strengthening India's ties with Bangladesh by assisting the country with nuclear technology, artificial intelligence, modern farming methods, and the exchange of flood data aids in countering China's influence in the country.

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- **Farakka Barrage:** Although the two countries reached an agreement on the sharing of Ganga waters in 1996, there is still a long-standing disagreement regarding India's construction and operation of the Farakka Barrage, which was built to supplement the river Hooghly's water supply.
 - Bangladesh complains that it does not get its fair share of water during the dry season and that some of its areas are inundated when India releases extra water during the monsoon season.
- **Insurgency:** One of the main points of disagreement between the two countries is insurgency.
- **Sharing River Water:** One of the main issues between the two countries is the disagreement over water.
 - There are 54 rivers shared by India and Bangladesh.
 - To maximize the benefits of their shared river systems, the two countries established a bilateral Joint Rivers Commission (JRC) in June 1972.

GOVERNMENT STEPS

- **Border security:** land boundary agreement of 2015. Establishment of border protection grid (BPG) and creation of crime-free stretch.
- **Connectivity:** Agreement on the standard operating procedure on the use of Chattogram and Mongla ports for the movement of goods to and from India.
- **Vaccine Maitri:** India gifted 109 ambulances and also donated 1.2 million doses of covid-19 vaccines as a grant.
- **Developmental support:** Since 2010 India has approved 3 lines of credit to Bangladesh amounting to \$ 7.4 billion.
- **Youth:** India announced special 'swarna jayanti scholarships' for the youth of Bangladesh for receiving education in various fields of study in India.
- **Cooperation in S&T:** Such as artificial intelligence, peaceful uses of nuclear technology, big data, and technology-enabled services in health and education.

INDIA-BANGLADESH RELATIONS DURING THE COVID-19 PANDEMIC

- Bangladesh worked with India's Serum Institute in February 2021 to extend Covid-19 immunisations, i.e. Covishield vaccines. During the epidemic, India donated approximately 3.3 million doses to Bangladesh.
- However, because of worsening conditions in India during the second wave of Covid-19, India stopped selling vaccines to Bangladesh, affecting vaccination activities.
- On the relief aid box that was transported to India, there were around 10,000 vials of Remdesivir produced by Bangladesh by Beximco, as well as zinc calcium, antiviral injections, oral antiviral, 30,000 PPE kits, and other pills.

Elections in Bangladesh and its impact on India

- Prime Minister Sheikh Hasina returned to power in Bangladesh for a historic fourth straight term, after her party, the Awami League, secured two-thirds of the seats in national elections. Bangladesh's new foreign minister Hasan Mahmud on Monday appreciated India's stance over its election.
- India shares good relations with Bangladesh under the current dispensation. This win has potential for greater cooperation in the longer run between two nations.

INDIA OUT CAMPAIGN

- The "India Out" campaign in Bangladesh following the recent general election seems to be an attempt by the Opposition to further their political prospects in the nation
- The BNP has had a rocky relationship with India. It has, in the past, used anti-India rhetoric and policies to harm Indian interests and further its domestic political goals.
- However, its current avatar—the "India Out" campaign seems to have been inspired by a similar movement in the Maldives, led by the then-Opposition and now ruling coalition, the Progressive Alliance.
- Similar to the Maldives', the Opposition in Bangladesh is criticizing the government for damaging the country's democracy and having close relations with India. They are also denouncing India for alleged electoral fraud, interfering in the country's domestic politics and institutions, and not resolving bilateral irritants between both countries. Religion is also being used as a pretext to criticize India and Indian policies

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WAY FORWARD

- **Countering China's Influence:** Assisting Bangladesh with nuclear technology, artificial intelligence, modern farming practices, and flood data exchange will strengthen India's relationship with Bangladesh and enable India more effectively resist China's influence.
- **Combating the Refugee Crisis:** India and Bangladesh might take the lead in persuading other South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) countries to draft a SAARC declaration on refugees, outlining detailed procedures for determining refugee and economic migrants' status.
- **Addressing the Teesta River Water Dispute:** In order to obtain a mutual agreement on the scope of teesta river water sharing, both the Bengal and central governments must work together with mutual understanding and indicate cooperative federalism.
- **Energy Security:** As the global energy crisis worsens, it is critical that India and Bangladesh work together to use clean and green energy to help South Asia.

CONCLUSION

- India and Bangladesh have a lot of space to strengthen their bilateral relations. The basis of the link should be cooperation, collaboration, and consolidation. The most important condition for progress is peace. As a result, effective border management is essential to ensure a secure, tranquil, and crime-free border.

Keywords:

Teesta River Water Dispute, Energy Security, Countering China, Refugee Crisis, Vaccine Maitri, Blue Economy, Geostrategic Significance, Act East Policy.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	The protests in Shahbag Square in Dhaka in Bangladesh reveal a fundamental split in society between the nationalists and Islamic forces. What is its significance for India?	2013
2.	Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchanges could help generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples.	2015



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4**INDIA- NEPAL****INTRODUCTION**

India and Nepal have a unique friendship and cooperation relationship characterized by open borders and deep-rooted people-to-people contacts of kinship and culture. The India–Nepal Treaty of Peace and Friendship of 1950 forms the bedrock of the special relations that exist between India and Nepal.

INDIA NEPAL TIES

- **Economic:** India is Nepal's largest trade partner, accounting for over two-thirds of merchandise trade, significant investments, and petroleum supplies. India has had a trade surplus with Nepal since 2002-2003, which has been growing over the years, with the average trade balance ratio increasing from 40% in 2002-2003 to 80% in 2018-2019.
- **Political:** India and Nepal share strong bilateral ties rooted in history, culture, and religion, but face persistent border disputes. The open border enables free movement, and both countries are members of SAARC and BIMSTEC.
- **Social:** The two countries have close bonds through marriages and familial ties, popularly known as Roti-Beti ka Rishta.
- **Cultural Ties:** India and Nepal share a rich Hindu and Buddhist heritage. Both governments have also attempted to capitalize on this common cultural heritage. In addition, India and Nepal have signed sister-city agreements for the twinning of Janakpur and Ajodhya, Kathmandu and Varanasi, and Lumbini and Bodhgaya.
 - **India is also funding two heritage projects in Patan Durbar:** The Pashupatinath Riverfront Development and the Bhandarkhal Garden Restoration.
- **Water Resources:** Nepal's rivers are vital to the Ganges river basin, and a bilateral mechanism established in 2008 addresses water resources and hydropower cooperation between India and Nepal.
- **Investment:** Indian firms dominate foreign direct investment in Nepal, representing 40% of total approved investments, with around 150 operating Indian ventures.
- **Defense Cooperation:** Indian and Nepalese military undertake the annual joint military exercise 'Surya Kiran'. The Gorkhas, who make up a significant portion of the Indian Army, have a strong connection with Nepal's army that goes back over 200 years. India also provides equipment and training to the Nepalese army to assist in its modernisation.
- **Disaster Management:** Both nations are participating in BIMSTEC for collective disaster response. India's assistance during 2015 is also well appreciated by Nepal.
- **Connectivity:** As Nepal is a landlocked country, it is dependent on India for access to the sea.
 - Both nations have agreed to offer rail connectivity and are also working to develop inland waterways in Nepal to connect Nepal with the Indian Ocean.
 - Establishment of Integrated Check Ports along the borders, recent ones being Birgunj and Biratnagar, have also eased trade and transit.

ISSUES IN INDIA-NEPAL RELATIONS

- **Stronger border controls and strictness:** They are hindering the movement of cash and making payments across the borders.
- **Delay In Project Completion:** The trust deficit between Nepal and India largely affected the implementation of various Indian-aided projects in Nepal.
- **Domestic Politics:** Recent sensationalist reporting about Nepal in the Indian media, irresponsible statements by Nepali Prime Minister KP Oli, including unsubstantiated allegations of India plotting to depose him, and Nepal border police fatally shooting an Indian man have heightened tensions and created a hostile environment for meaningful engagement.
- **A growing trust deficit:** Between the two neighbors—especially since the 2015 unofficial Indian blockade that ravaged Nepal's economy and the rise of territorial nationalism in both countries.
- **New Geopolitical Great Game:**
 - **Elevated Partnership:** During the visit of Xi Jinping, Nepal and China elevated their ties from "Comprehensive Partnership of Cooperation Featuring Ever-lasting Friendship" to "Strategic Partnership of Cooperation Featuring Ever-lasting Friendship for Development and Prosperity".

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- **Treaty on Extradition:** China also signed a Treaty on Mutual Legal Assistance in Criminal Matters (MLACM) and expressed hope for an early conclusion of the Treaty on Extradition.
- **Himalayan 'Quadrilateral':** The recent Himalayan 'Quadrilateral' meeting between China, Pakistan, Afghanistan and Nepal also highlights the Chinese attempt to contain India in South Asia.
- **Defense Cooperation:** For the first time, the People's Liberation Army (PLA) and the Nepali Army held two joint- military exercises in 2017 and 2018.

WAY FORWARD

- **Revision of Friendship Treaty:** Kathmandu seeks to regulate traffic along the border as part of an overall revision of the 1950 India-Nepal Friendship Treaty.
- **Big brother image:** India has to be mindful of its "big brother" image in a country where the domestic political power play produces a new surprise every few months.
- **Projects on time:** India has to step up to the challenge of delivering projects on time.
- **A transit agreement:** To help Nepal trade via India's inland waterways, and other connectivity agreements were also signed during the visit.
- **Avoiding micromanagement:** While the open border with Nepal has helped to keep up ties between people on both sides, India's perceived "micro-management" in Nepal, as Prachanda once called it, does not go down well.

INDIA-NEPAL TERRITORIAL DISPUTE

HISTORY AND PRESENT

- **Open borders:** The two countries share an approximately 1800-kilometer international open border, which is managed under the bilateral Treaty of Peace and Friendship (1950).
 - The border was formally demarcated for the first time with the **Treaty of Sugauli (1816)**.
 - Under **section 5 of the treaty** Nepal renounced its claims on the region west of river Kali. Thus, river Kali became the boundary between India and Nepal.
- **Nepal's position:** Nepal claims to have conducted a census there in the early 1950s and cites the 1815 Sugauli Treaty to support its claims.
- **India's stance-** Though the areas of Kalapani, Limpiyadhura and Lipulekh lie west of river Kali, India has historically controlled the region. And claims that the border begins at Kalapani where the river begins.
- Both governments agreed in 1981 to form the India-Nepal Border Joint Technical Committee to redraw the boundary pillars.
- They also established The Nepal-India **Joint Border Inspection Mechanism** in 1981 and the Nepal-India Joint Border Management Committee in 1997 to manage borders.
- **No-man's land:** However, The Kalapani border has yet to be properly demarcated, especially the so-called 'no-man's land' in the area.
- **C. Raja Mohan** identifies the India-Nepal territorial dispute as "merely a symptom of the structural changes unfolding in the external and internal context of the bilateral relationship".

INDIA-NEPAL BORDER CONFLICTS

- **Sino-Indian War and Kalapani:** Since the 1962 Sino-Indian War, Kalapani has been administered by India.
- **The claims to Kalapani:** By Nepal date back to a century prior to the Treaty of Sugauli 1816 signed between the then Kingdom of Nepal and British India.
 - The Kali River has been designated as the border between India and Nepal in this region by this treaty.
- **Lack of clarity and consensus:** There has been a dispute between the two countries over whether the land consisting of Kalapani, Limpiyadhura, and Lipulekh is a part of Nepal or India due to a lack of clarity and consensus on the precise location of the river.
- **Susta Region:** The Susta region is located on the bank of the Gandak River (also known as the Narayani River in Nepal). The main source of contention in the Susta region is the changing course of the Gandak River.

RECENT ISSUES IN NEWS:

MAP BY NEPAL

- NEPAL has issued a new national map incorporating areas also claimed by neighboring India, prompting fierce criticism from New Delhi.

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- It incorporates Lipulekh, Limpiyadhura and Kalapani. Nepal's new map locates the small stretch of disputed land within its northwest border, between China and India.
- Nepal map on currency note to have Indian areas.

RECENT DEALS:

- India had announced that it would buy 10,000 megawatts of electricity from Nepal over 10 years with the endorsement of a long-term inter-government power trade agreement.
- India has also agreed on a Rs10 billion financial aid to Nepal for reconstruction of Jajarkot and Rukum West which were worst hit by the earthquake last November.
- An agreement was also reached for the launch of Nepali satellites between the Nepal Academy of Science and Technology and NewSpace India Limited under the Indian Space Research Organisation.
- Agreement between India and Nepal for the implementation of High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDPs) in Nepal signed

WAY FORWARD

- **Taking Immediate action:** Given the importance of ties with Nepal, which are often romanticized as "roti-beti" (food and marriage), India must not put off dealing with the issue, especially at a time when it is already at odds with China in Ladakh and Sikkim.
- **Closing a loophole in the border:** Since the unrestricted movement of persons is permitted across the border, Nepal has enormous strategic significance in terms of India's national security, as terrorists frequently use Nepal to infiltrate India.
- **Cannot overlook stable and good relations:** As a result, one of the conditions that India cannot afford to overlook is stable and good relations with Nepal.
- **Careless deterioration of this centuries-old:** India should also endeavor to explain to Nepal's leadership the pleasant and welcoming environment that 6 to 8 million Nepali citizens enjoy in India. As a result, any careless deterioration of this centuries-old bond may be challenging for both countries.

CONCLUSION

The present bilateral treaties between India and Nepal do not account for the movement of the Himalayan rivers. One major cause for this is a lack of a strategy in which ecological considerations and river demands are frequently considered. As a result, India and Nepal should endeavor to resolve their boundary issue by considering all shared environmental qualities.

Keywords:

Careless deterioration, Sugauli Treaty, Avoiding micromanagement, Big Brother, No-man's land.

5**INDIA-AFGHANISTAN****INTRODUCTION**

Afghanistan has been the center of 'Great Games' and 'Graveyard of Empires'. The **Gandhar-Bharat Sambandha**, often known as Afghanistan-India connections, refers to India's diplomatic ties with Afghanistan. The unique aspect of India's Afghan relationship has been **economic cooperation rather than military participation**.

SIGNIFICANCE OF AFGHANISTAN FOR INDIA

- **Geo-Strategic:**
 - **Location:** Connecting East, West, Central and North East Asia.
 - Proximity to important countries like Iran, India, China, and Russia.
 - Since the Cold War, the heart of the great game between the USA and Russia.
 - **Regional balance of power:** Peace and stability in Afghanistan is linked to India's vision of regional leadership and global power.
 - **Friendship Treaty:** In 1949 India and Afghanistan signed a friendship treaty.
 - **Countering Chinese Influence:** China through OBOR and other development initiatives increasing its presence in the region.
 - **Internal Security:** Afghanistan is the center of radical ideology, drug trafficking and smuggling. Thus peaceful Afghanistan is necessary for regional security.
 - **Fourth Regional Security Dialogue on Afghanistan:** The Indian National Security Advisor (NSA) called for strengthening Afghanistan's capacity to combat terrorism during the in Dushanbe (Tajikistan).
- **Geopolitical:**
 - **Neighbourhood First Policy:** By putting an emphasis on developing regional frameworks for security and prosperity that are people-centered, mutually beneficial, and inclusive.
 - **Countering OBOR (One Belt One Road) Initiative:** Afghanistan can be a strong partner for India through Chabahar port.
 - **Strengthening Claim for UNSC:** In a situation where even the United Nations mission in Afghanistan has relocated to Kazakhstan, India is giving humanitarian aid.
 - **Political Stability:** Stability in Afghanistan is in India's interest. The Delhi Declaration also underlined the necessity for Afghanistan to have an "inclusive government" that included members from all facets of society.
- **Geo-Economic:**
 - **Connectivity:** Important crossroads for commerce and trade as well as a gateway to landlocked Central Asia.
 - In 2017, the India-Afghanistan Air Freight Corridor opened for business.
 - **Mineral Wealth:** The US Geological Survey estimates that Afghanistan has mineral resources worth \$1 trillion, including those for copper, iron, and other metals.
 - **Energy Security:** Afghanistan has enormous undeveloped hydrocarbon reserves, including gas and oil. Additionally, it is a crucial part of the TAPI pipeline.
 - **Trade:** A Preferential Trade Agreement between India and Afghanistan allowed for certain categories (38 products) of Afghan dry fruits to obtain substantial tariff concessions, ranging from 50% to 100%.
 - **Aid:** India provided Afghanistan with \$4 billion in development aid between 2002 and 2021.

INDIA-AFGHANISTAN DEVELOPMENT PARTNERSHIP**POLITICAL**

- **Operation Enduring Freedom:** In 2001, India provided information and logistical support to the Allied soldiers.
- **Admitting to SAARC:** India promoted Afghanistan's inclusion in SAARC, the South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation, in 2005.
- **Strategic Partnership Agreement:** It was signed between India and Afghanistan in 2011 to improve relations between the two nations.

ECONOMIC

- **Trade & Commerce:**

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- **Preferential Trade Agreement (2003):** As a result of which India granted significant duty cuts to a specific category (38 products) of Afghan dry fruits, ranging from 50% to 100%.
- **Initiatives in 2016:** The prime minister proposed using mutually agreed-upon means to supply India with high- quality, easily affordable pharmaceuticals and to cooperate in the development of solar energy. There is now a second aviation route between India with Afghanistan.
- **Developmental Aid:**
 - **Zaranj to Delaram:** To make it easier to transport goods and services from Afghanistan to the Iranian border and then on to the Chabahar Port, a 218 km road was built from Zaranj to Delaram (finished).
 - **Transmission line:** Kabul to Pul-e-Khumri 220 kV DC transmission line construction.
 - **Salma Dam power:** Salma Dam power project's construction and commissioning (42 MW) in Herat province.
 - **Afghan Parliament:** Constructing the Afghan Parliament.
 - **Other Assistance:** India has promised to build the Shahtoot Dam and other drinking water projects for Kabul, and to improve road connectivity to Band-e Amir in Bamyar to boost tourism.
 - **Post-Taliban:** The Taliban regime's foreign ministry spokesman requested India to complete the development projects in August 2022. After being closed for a year, the Indian embassy in Kabul has finally reopened.
- **Humanitarian Assistance:**
 - **School Feeding Programme:** Nearly 2 million kids receive a daily supply of 100 grams of fortified, high-protein biscuits through the World Food Programme.
 - **Free Healthcare:** Over 30,000 Afghans receive free medical advice and medication each month from five Indian Medical Missions. Reconstructing the Indira Gandhi Institute of Child Health in Kabul.
 - **Military Aid:** The Afghan National Army will need 285 military vehicles, while five cities' public hospitals will need 10 ambulances.
 - **Post-COVID:** India had sent 75,000 MT of wheat to Afghanistan in 2020 in order to fight the global COVID-19 outbreak and associated food security challenges.
 - **Vaccine:** India gave 500,000 doses of the Covid-19 vaccine to Afghanistan in January 2022 as humanitarian help and to improve ties between the two countries.
 - **Post-Taliban:** In February 2022, the Indian Foreign Secretary dispatched a convoy of 50 trucks carrying 2500 MT of wheat as humanitarian aid for Afghanistan.

CULTURAL

- **Amir Amanullah Khan Award:** Narendra Modi received the highest civilian distinction bestowed by Afghanistan.
- **ICCR (Indian Council of Cultural Relations) fellowship:** It was extended by India till 2020.
- **Sports:** Cricket has played a significant role in fostering intercultural relations between the two nations.

EDUCATION AND CAPACITY BUILDING

- **Studies for Afghan students:** The Indian Council for Cultural Relations sponsors 500 Afghan students studying in long-term universities in India for their undergraduate and graduate degrees each year.
- **Training program:** 500 Afghan public workers participate in annual short-term ITEC training workshops.
- **Women's Vocational Training:** A facility in BagheZanana where the renowned Indian NGO SEWA (Self-Employed Women's Association) trains Afghan women.
- **Capacity building programmes:** The sectors of municipal government, public administration, electoral management and administration, media and information, civil aviation, agricultural research and education, health care, and pharmaceutical science are also undergoing development.

The overriding goal is to make sure that our partners in the region profit from India's progress, development, and ascension. Based on this, all of the nations in our region strive to build mutually beneficial partnerships.

DIALOGUE FOR PEACE IN AFGHANISTAN

Delhi Declaration	The Delhi Declaration reflects the long-standing, consistent approach India has taken to bringing stability and peace to Afghanistan. The Delhi Declaration on Afghanistan "emphasized that Afghanistan's territory should not be used for sheltering, training, planning, or financing any terrorist acts," which is another crucial part of the document.
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Moscow Format	Featuring the special envoys of Russia, Afghanistan, India, Iran, China, and Pakistan, the regional platform on Afghanistan was established in 2017.
Heart of Asia Conference (HOAC)	On November 2, 2011, it was established in Istanbul, Turkey. The Heart of Asia recognises the importance of an Afghanistan that is secure and stable for the development of the region as a whole by placing Afghanistan at its hub. This creates a framework for genuine and results-driven regional collaboration. It consists of 13 supporting regional and international organizations, 14 participating nations, and 17 supporting nations.

TALIBAN TAKEOVER OF AFGHANISTAN

After actively intervening in Afghan affairs for two decades and spending more than a trillion dollars to combat terrorism and al Qaeda, the United States has left Afghanistan in a worse state than when it arrived.

CHALLENGES

- **Security:** Transnational terrorism and radicalization are centered on Afghanistan. Kashmir may be affected as a result. The opium trade and organized crime are also centered there.
- **Trade:** Under a Taliban government, trade through Afghanistan would go through Karachi and Gwadar, making the Indian investment in the Chabahar port—which was intended to bypass Pakistan—possibly unprofitable.
- **Connectivity:** Afghanistan and India don't have any direct connections. A new path that uses Chabahar port to avoid Pakistan is in danger due to escalating US-Iran tensions and Iran's expanding ties to China.
- **Pakistan:** Pakistan looks at its relations with Afghanistan through the lens of its interactions with India. It desires Strategic Depth in Afghanistan as a result. Pakistan is the 'patron saint' of the new government, said M. K. Narayanan.
- **Russia and China:** Increasing Chinese influence in Afghanistan via Pakistan, which serves as a proxy. China-Pakistan- Iran-Russia axis's emergence. For China's BRI initiative and the security of its Xinjiang province, Afghanistan is crucial.
- **Institutional weakness:** Due to a risk-averse mindset and an inability to match Afghanistan's increasing expectations, foreign policy is made with caution.
- **New Great game:** Between Pakistan, China, and Russia on one side and the US, India, and Afghanistan on the other.
- **Human Rights:** Given the Taliban's history of rule, India is concerned about the effects on Afghanistan itself, including the degradation of women's and minority rights, the dismantling of a democratic system, and the implementation of the Taliban's harsh brand of justice.

How does the current great-power competition help the Taliban in Afghanistan?

- The Taliban's rule in Afghanistan is a new geopolitical reality that the world is still grappling with. Over the past year, the Taliban has continued its quest for diplomatic recognition with varying degrees of success.
- However, the conflict in Europe arguably came as a boon for the Taliban which was staring down on becoming a global pariah once again.
- Russia's actions against Kiev caused tectonic shifts, setting off Cold War-era-like boundaries across the international arena. A conflict in Europe was not something the West was expecting, and in an era where the largest worry was an incoming great power competition between the US and China, Washington's renewal of old rivalries with Moscow added to these complications significantly.
- Nonetheless, for the Taliban, this fracture bodes well as it can mobilize to cement itself more firmly as a legitimate political entity. The Taliban has over the past year and a half gained control of a few of Afghanistan's embassies in Central Asia, Iran, Qatar, Pakistan, Malaysia, Russia, and China.
- More recently, it has now even appointed a new "caretaker" Consul General in Dubai, highlighting a slow change in approach by the likes of the United Arab Emirates as well.

Recent Developments:

- A **UN-convened meeting** of Special Envoys and Special Representatives on Afghanistan has taken place in **Doha, Qatar**, to discuss the path forward on the independent assessment on Afghanistan mandated by **Resolution 2679**.
- It was aimed at improving dialogue with the country's Taliban rulers but ended after the administration's representatives failed to show up.

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- The Taliban-led foreign office refused to attend the meeting in Doha when the U.N. rejected its demand to act as Afghanistan's sole official representative.

India's Kabul Talks:

- An Indian delegation led by Joint Secretary (Pakistan-Afghanistan-Iran) MEA JP Singh on Thursday met Taliban Foreign Minister Amir Khan Muttaqi in Kabul to discuss several issues including New Delhi's humanitarian assistance in what was the first high level meeting between the Taliban regime and Indian government.

INDIA'S POSITION SHIFT ON TALIBAN

Recent interactions between India and the Taliban and the Taliban's request to New Delhi for the restart of flights to Kabul show a posture shift in favor of the Taliban. India is unlikely to continue its previous strategy of opposing the Northern Alliance and refusing to recognise the Taliban.

WHY CHANGE IN POSITION?

- **Pragmatic shift:** India's earlier position has become untenable because it prevented India from participating in a number of Afghan peace talks.
- **Vacuum to replace US: US Withdrawal** and Taliban coming back to power.
- **Pakistan Factor:** Taliban is also open to establishing ties with India as protection against Pakistan. The Durand Line between Afghanistan and Pakistan has never been acknowledged by any Afghan administration, including the former Taliban rule.
- **Indian Investment:** Additionally, India has made about \$3 billion in Afghanistan. This includes initiatives like the Zaranj-Delaram route, Afghan Parliament, and Salma Dam, among others.
- **Connectivity imperative:** India needs Afghanistan for its energy security and access to Eurasia (Tapi Pipeline). Therefore, it is essential for India to maintain vital ties with the Afghan government's ruling party.
- **Course correction:** India must learn from its prior error of failing to recognise the Taliban government, which resulted in the hijacking of IC-814.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA- AFGHANISTAN RELATION

- **Non-democratic regime:** India, whose relations with the democratic administration have improved, supports the maintenance of a democratically elected administration.
- **Political Instability:** Political unrest in the Afghanistan region will have an effect on India and other adjacent nations.
- **Drug trafficking:** Drug addiction affects the majority of the young population in Punjab and other parts of India.
- **Terrorism:** The terrorism issue has become quite challenging. India must interact with Afghanistan in a sensible way.
- **Proxy war by Pakistan:** As a result, India will find it difficult to maintain cordial relations with Afghanistan under the current conditions

IMPACT OF US WITHDRAWAL FROM AFGHANISTAN

- **Return of the Taliban:** India and other neighboring nations will have to deal with the implications of the Taliban's triumphant return to power in Afghanistan, as well as an increase in violent religious extremism across the region. **Trans-border contacts:** Between the Taliban and other extremist forces in the region are also a concern.
- **Withdrawal of US soldiers:** It could create a breeding ground for numerous anti-India terrorist organizations such as Lashkar-e-Taiba and Jaish-e-Mohammed.
- **Undermining India's Role in Afghanistan:** The withdrawal of the United States from Afghanistan offers significant problems to the Indian Subcontinent.
- **Extremist forces in check:** For India, an American military presence would have held extremist forces in check and established favorable conditions for an Indian participation in Afghanistan.
- **Reduce interest in the region:** Because Afghanistan is the entrance to Central Asia, the US withdrawal may reduce India's interest in the region.

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WAY FORWARD

- **Engaging with Taliban:** It would enable New Delhi to ask the rebels for security guarantees in exchange for continuous development aid.
- **Collaboration at the regional level:** India must cooperate with nations that share its commitment to the region's peace and stability, such as China and Iran. An example is the joint Afghan development initiative between China and India.
- **India needs to closely collaborate with the US' local networks:** By most recently inviting India to the most recent iterations of the Afghan peace negotiations, the US has also demonstrated a desire for India to play a larger role.
- **India should strive to ensure the continuance of the Kabul process:** In order to maintain the importance of counterterrorism, women's rights, and democratic principles (i.e., an Afghan-led, Afghan-controlled, and Afghan-owned process).
- **Role of Mediation:** **M. K. Narayanan** contends that India ought to act as a go-between for the several countries eager to get involved in Afghanistan.

CONCLUSION

- In terms of strategy, there are, in **C. Rajamohan's** opinion, just as many disadvantages as benefits in Afghanistan. India is realistic enough to recognise that it lacks the power to determine the future of Afghanistan on its own. But via proactive diplomacy and focused action on the ground, India needs to gain some sway and shape outcomes in Afghanistan.

Keywords:

Kabul process, Proxy war, Political Instability, Non-democratic regime, Pragmatic shift, 'Great Games' and 'Graveyard of Empires'.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	The proposed withdrawal of the International Security Assistance Force (ISAF) from Afghanistan in 2014 is fraught with major security implications for the countries of the region. Examine in light of the fact that India is faced with a plethora of challenges and needs to safeguard its own strategic interests.	2013
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6**INDIA- MYANMAR****INTRODUCTION**

Myanmar serves as a gateway to South East Asia because it is the only ASEAN nation to border India. According to our "Act East" and "Neighbourhood First" Policies, India wants to increase its collaboration with Myanmar. These five Bs—Buddhism, Business, Bollywood, Bharatnatyam, and Burma teak—frame perceptions of India-Myanmar ties.

OVERVIEW OF RELATIONSHIP

- **Development Cooperation:**
 - **Mainly Grant-based Fund:** India has provided more than \$1.75 billion in development aid to Myanmar as of 2022. Most of this support is funded via grants.
 - **Example:** The Rakhine State Development Programme, the Trilateral Highway Project, the Kaladan Multimodal Transit Transport Project, and the restoration and protection of Bagan's Ananda Temple are among the development initiatives.
- **Institutional Mechanisms:**
 - **National Level Meeting (NLM):** The primary discussion forum for security cooperation, consular matters, drug trafficking, and agency coordination was established by the Home Secretary.
 - **Joint Boundary Working Group (JBWG):** **Boundary matters** are discussed by the Joint Secretary (BM), Ministry of External Affairs.
- **Commercial Cooperation:**
 - **Energy:** Given that future offshore gas discoveries can be routed to India, Myanmar has the potential to be a significant partner in the energy sector. now has a joint working group on cooperation in the oil and gas and power sectors.
 - **Investment:** With an approved investment of US\$ 771.488 million, India is ranked eleventh. among 13 Indian public sector enterprises operating in various industries in Myanmar.
- **Enhancing Connectivity:**
 - **International entry/ exit points:** Two international entry/exit points were officially opened in August 2018 at **Tamu-Moreh and Rih-Zowkhawthar**. There are steps being taken to make these two land border posts completely functioning.
 - **Motor Vehicle Agreement:** Negotiations on it are also ongoing.
 - **Other important connectivity projects includes:**
 - **\$484 million Kaladan Multimodal Transit** Transport Project
 - The **Trilateral Highway Project**, which is an East-West corridor connecting our Northeast with Myanmar and Thailand.
 - **Myanmar/ Malaysia-India Singapore Transit (MIST) Corridor:**
- **Culture:**
 - **Buddhist Heritage:** Given India's Buddhist background, there are strong cultural linkages and a shared sense of deep affinity between India and Myanmar.
 - **Example:** Several important initiatives in the repair and preservation of numerous damaged pagodas as well as the restoration of Bagan's Ananda Temple.
- **Security Cooperation:**
 - **Defense Cooperation Agreement:** India and Myanmar signed a Defence Cooperation Agreement in July 2019 with the intention of increasing military engagement.
 - **Exercises:** The India-Myanmar Joint Army Exercise (IMBAX), the Indian Navy-Myanmar Navy (IN-MN BILAT), and the Joint Naval Exercise (IMCOR) is also carried out by both nations.
 - **Operation Sunrise:** It targeted the camps of insurgent organizations active in the North East, and was carried out by the armies of India and Myanmar along the Myanmar border. Along the Indo-Myanmar border, they also cooperate to obliterate a number of Arakan Army militant camps.
- **Maritime Cooperation And Blue Economy:**

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- **Blue economy:** It is an important pillar of BIMSTEC where both countries are working together. Example: Under India's **SAGAR (Security and growth for all in the region) programme**, India has built Sittwe Port.
- **Disaster Relief:**
 - **Example:** In the wake of natural disasters in Myanmar, such as Cyclone Mora (2017), Komen (2015), the earthquake in Shan State (2010), Cyclone Nargis in 2008, etc., India has responded quickly and successfully by providing aid.

SIGNIFICANCE OF MYANMAR FOR INDIA

- **Geo-Strategic:**
 - **Boundary:** Myanmar and north-eastern India share a 1643 km long land border (including the states of Arunachal Pradesh, Nagaland, Manipur, and Mizoram).
 - **Peace and stability:** Rohingya migration crisis and Coup by Junta create instability in the region.
 - **Geostrategic location:** Myanmar borders China, India and ASEAN and the Bay of Bengal.
 - **Internal Security:** To contain insurgency in North East- Myanmar is of vital importance to India especially with respect to India's northeast.
 - **Containing the rise of China:** Myanmar is an important element for the success of India's 'Neighbourhood First', 'Act East', and 'Indo-Pacific' policies.
- **Geo-Economic:**
 - **Trade:** The amount of trade between the two nations has consistently stayed at or near \$2 billion.
 - **Energy security:** There are significant oil and natural gas reserves in the Rohingya-populated regions of Myanmar, amounting to 11 trillion and 23 trillion cubic feet, respectively.
 - The Indian side has suggested building a \$6 billion oil refinery in the Thanlyn area, close to Yangon.
 - Myanmar also has hydroelectricity potential.
 - **Connectivity:** Examples include Kaladan Multimodal Transit Transport Project, The Trilateral Highway Project, Myanmar/ Malaysia-India Singapore Transit (MIST) Corridor.
 - **Indo-Pacific Trade:** Myanmar is an important partner in our Indo-Pacific Strategy. 65 percent of the world's population, 63 per cent of its gross domestic product, and 46 per cent of its commerce in goods are concentrated in the Indo-Pacific region.

ISSUES IN BILATERAL RELATIONSHIP

- **Insurgency:** Myanmar serves as a base for several of the insurgency organizations in the North East. Their freedom of mobility and connections to organized crime are made easier by this regime
- **Rising Chinese footprint:** Most of Myanmar's foreign investments have been lost since the coup, but Beijing has used this as a chance to increase its investments.
- **Domestic instability in Myanmar and collapse of Democracy:** Dealing with a military rule instead of a democratically elected government makes for more difficult issues for the government.
 - **Example:** India has developed a Twin Track approach to cooperating with the military Junta and re-establishing democracy.
- **Rohingya crisis:** It has led to the rise of serious illegal immigrant issues in India.
 - More than 980,000 people from Myanmar have sought shelter in neighboring nations including Bangladesh and India.
 - **Principle of refoulement:** India also disagrees with a UN stance that says deporting the Rohingya would violate the refoulement principle, which prohibits returning refugees forcibly to a dangerous place.
- **Porous Borders and Organized Crime:** The India-Myanmar border provides the ideal environment for traffickers to transport heroin and psychoactive drugs into India due to its proximity to the "Golden Triangle" and its porous and unguarded nature.

RISING CHINESE FOOTPRINT IN MYANMAR

- **Economic:** Myanmar's top trading partner is China. In 2019, the two countries' commerce was estimated to be worth USD 12 billion, or about one-third of all trade with Myanmar.
- **Connectivity:** Burma is a member of the OBOR project. As part of the BRI initiative, China has also suggested the China-Myanmar Economic Corridor (CMEC).
- **Energy:** At a total cost projected at \$1.5 billion, China built a parallel natural gas and oil pipeline that runs from Kyaukphyu City in Myanmar's Rakhine State to the Yunnan region of China.

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- **Defense:** Since 1988, China has been one of Myanmar's primary military suppliers. Myanmar purchased 1.3 billion dollars' worth of guns from the Chinese between 2010 and 2019, according to the SIPRI database.
- **Investment:** One of the major sources of Myanmar's FDI (Foreign Direct Investment), which as of March 2020 totalled USD 21 billion, has been China. China and Myanmar signed numerous Belt and Road Initiative projects in 2020. The construction of a deep sea port at Kyaukphyu, costing USD 1.3 billion, was one of the primary initiatives.

CONCERNS FOR INDIA

- **Debt trap diplomacy:** This strategy by China can force Myanmar to surrender strategic assets like ports to China.
- **Strategic Containment:** China benefits from strategically confining India and obstructing its access to the west and the east thanks to the Kyaukphyu and Gwadar ports.
- **Security of the North East:** The insurgency in India's north-eastern states could be fueled by China's presence in Myanmar. According to intelligence assessments, China provides funding and weapons support to numerous insurgency factions.
- **Connectivity:** India's gateway to ASEAN is Myanmar, and it is actively involved in significant connectivity initiatives like the Mekong Ganga Cooperation, the IMT Trilateral Highway, and the Kaladan Transport Corridor. The growing Chinese influence in Myanmar poses a threat to these initiatives.
- **Domestic Instability in Myanmar:** Some strategic experts believe the Chinese hand behind the recent coup in Myanmar to prevent it from joining the USA.
- **Weakening of ASEAN:** Authoritarian governance in Myanmar has the potential to exacerbate ASEAN's divisions and erode its cohesiveness and ability to confront China.

MILITARY SEIZES POWER IN MYANMAR COUP

The military has seized control of Myanmar for the third time since the country gained independence from British domination in 1948. The democratically elected leader Aung San Suu Kyi has been imprisoned, and a one-year state of emergency has been declared.

IMPACT ON INDIA

- **Growth of North East:** It has hampered growth in the Northeast and badly harmed India's efforts to reach out to the thriving economies of SouthEast Asia.
- **Cross-border movement:** There have also been reports of illegal commodities being transported and of persons moving across borders.
- **Impacting India's Act East Policy:** India's Act East policy, which has since 2014 grown more dynamic and outcome-oriented, has suffered as a result.
- **Chinese Threat:** In addition, concerns about Chinese intelligence's interference in assisting these terrorist groups call for prompt action.
- **Security in India:** Security considerations for the indigenous players in the NER are sacrificed in favor of India's approach towards the military takeover in Myanmar.

BROADER GEOPOLITICAL CONSEQUENCES

- **Strategic Recalibration:** India's policy adjustments reflect an effort to address both immediate security concerns and long-term regional stability, requiring diplomatic finesse and collaboration with Myanmar and other regional stakeholders.
- **Impact on Border Communities:** The proposed termination and border fortification have raised concerns among the border communities, who fear the loss of their socio-economic and cultural exchanges. Opposition from states like Mizoram, Nagaland, and Manipur highlights the deep-seated ethnic connections and the potential socio-economic disruptions caused by such measures.
- **Influence on Act East Policy:** The suspension of the FMR could affect India's strategic initiatives in Southeast Asia, potentially impacting projects like the Kaladan Multi-Modal Transit Transport Project and altering India-Myanmar diplomatic relations.
- **Regional Security and Humanitarian Concerns:** The military coup in Myanmar and the ensuing humanitarian crisis underscore the complexity of the border situation, challenging India to navigate between securing its borders and supporting the affected communities.
- **Government Responses and Implementation Challenges:** The Indian government's plans to introduce advanced fencing technologies face opposition from local communities and political entities, emphasizing the need for a balanced approach that considers both security needs and cultural ties.

7

INDIA AND BHUTAN

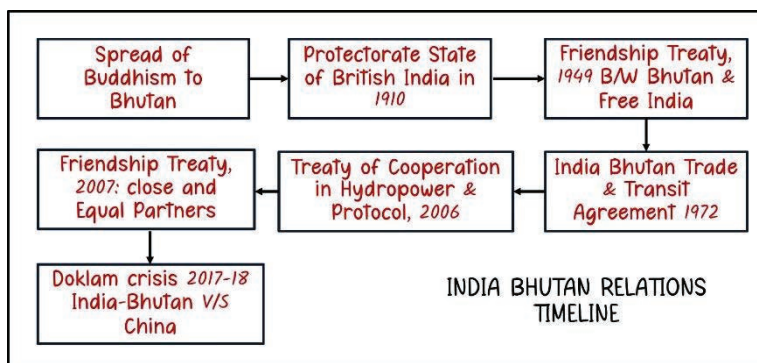
INTRODUCTION

"India is fortunate to be the land where Prince Siddhartha became Gautam Buddha. And from where the light of his spiritual message, the light of Buddhism, spread all over the world. Generations of monks, spiritual leaders, scholars and seekers have burnt that flame bright in Bhutan," Prime Minister Modi.

Because of their shared location and cultural characteristics, India and Bhutan are known as **all-weather friends**. The excellent connection between India and Bhutan has played a **significant role in maintaining the peace and security of the area**.

HISTORICAL TIES

- **8th Century AD:** Historically both nations share strong cultural ties which flourished mainly during Tibetan Guru Padmasambhava who introduced Tantric Buddhism to Tibet in the 8th century.
- **1947:** Bhutan was among the first countries who recognized India's independence.
- India has supported Bhutan's entry in the United Nations.
- **1972:** India and Bhutan trade and commerce agreement established free trade and commerce between them.
- **Post-independence:** Although both countries opened embassies in 1978, the relationship between these neighbors is based on the 1949 India-Bhutan Treaty of Friendship and Cooperation. This treaty was revised in 2007 which shows continuous evolution of relations between them.



REVISED PROVISIONS OF THE 2007 FRIENDSHIP TREATY

- It adopted an element of equality doing away from India's big brother approach.
- Independent Foreign Policy: Articles 2 and 4 of the revised treaty enabled Bhutan to conduct its foreign policy more independently at the same time keeping India's security interests in mind.
- Procurement of weapons: Article 4 would allow Bhutan to import military equipment from other countries without India's consent.
- Security concern: Both countries have a duty to stop unlawful acts that endanger public safety and other interests within their borders.

COOPERATION AND SIGNIFICANCE OF BHUTAN

POLITICAL

- **Democratic Principles:** Through the support of India, Bhutan has been a successful **democracy since 2007** believing in common democratic principles.
- **International Support:** Bhutan was among the first nations who **supported India's Nuclear Test**.
 - India has always got its support from the United Nations platform.
- **Multilateral Partnerships:** Both countries share multilateral organizations like;
 - **SAARC** (South Asian Association For Regional Cooperation).
 - **BIMSTEC** (The Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation).
 - **BBIN** (Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Nepal Initiative)

ECONOMIC

- **Trade:** Bhutan's main source of imports and largest export market is India. Bhutan's hydroelectric potential is a significant source of revenue for the country.

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- **Investment:** Bhutan's ascent to middle-income status offers India the chance to make investments there.
- **Financial Aid:** India has been funding its five-year plans and has also given its current five-year plan 4500 crores in aid.
- **Hydropower:** India has been **developing infrastructure Border roads and hydropower projects** in Bhutan. **Example:** Recently inaugurated Mangdechhu Hydroelectric Plant.
- **Free Trade Regime and Duty-Free Transit:** It has boosted trade relations, having India as the largest trading partner of Bhutan.

CULTURAL AND EDUCATION

- **Impact of Hinduism and Buddhism:** Their way of living makes it very obvious. This has promoted strong interpersonal relationships and cultural fusion.
- **Students in India:** The number of Bhutanese students pursuing higher education in India has decreased, from 2,468 in 2012–13 to 1,827 in 2020–21, according to the All India Surveys of Higher Education (AISHE).

GEOGRAPHIC AND STRATEGIC

- **Buffer State:** Bhutan and the Indian subcontinent share a strategic location. It serves as a stopgap between China and India.
- **Trijunction:** The Chumbi Valley is only 500 km from the Chicken Neck Corridor of India and is located at the trijunction of Bhutan, India, and China. Bhutan's Doklam Plateau provides a tactical military edge over China close to Chumby Valley.
- **Data sharing:** Since many rivers in India originate in Bhutan, data cooperation regarding flood predictions is crucial.

INTERNAL SECURITY

- **Separatist Group:** Both nations have previously worked successfully together to deal with the Bhutan-based United Liberation Front of Assam (ULFA) and National Democratic Front of Bodoland (NDFB).
- **Revised Friendship Treaty:** Provisions in the 2007 Friendship Treaty Revision have improved this front's collaboration even more.

FLOOD MANAGEMENT

- **Joint Group Of Experts on Flood Management:** It was established to talk about the causes of the recurrent flooding and degradation of the foothills bordering India.
- **Data Sharing:** Additionally, data on water levels and information needed for flood forecasting would be shared.

ISSUES IN COOPERATION

- **External debt:** India is a major trading partner of Bhutan and has a positive balance of payments, which has caused issues for Bhutan. The ratio of its GDP to its external debt has risen to almost 100%.
- **Delays in hydropower projects:** Both nations have decided to work together to enhance Bhutan's hydropower potential by 10,000 MW. India is not completing projects in the anticipated amount of time.
- **Internal Security:** They are now concerned about insurgent groups operating in Bhutan's south-eastern jungle.
- **Chinese Concern:** **Chinese attempts to establish diplomatic ties** with Bhutan and extend its BRI project to Bhutan have become a cause for concern for India. Bhutan's pro-China statement recently has sparked a new debate about Bhutan's approach to balancing India and China.
- **Electricity Tariff:** Bhutan faces a problem in maintaining a profitable hydropower business given India's power surplus position and the growth of alternative energies like wind and solar electricity.
- **BBIN:** Bhutan **did not join the BBIN Motor Vehicle Agreement** considering its adverse impact on the environment and climate.

FUTURE SCOPE OF COOPERATION (WAY AHEAD)

POLITICAL

- **Respecting Autonomy:** India must avoid interfering in its domestic affairs and should convey a message of non-interference in order to win the support of the general populace given the autonomous democracy of India.
- **Cooperation:** To promote Bhutanese democracy, there should be **inter-parliamentary cooperation and institutional cooperation like the Election Commission.**
- **Foreign Policy Role:** Bhutan has played a crucial role in two of India's main foreign policies, the "Act-East Policy" and the "Neighbourhood First Policy."

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DEFENCE

- To get ready for circumstances like the Doklam Standoff, more military and air force training exercises can be conducted.
- Additionally, dealing with anti-national elements who endanger internal security will be made easier.

ECONOMY

- **Trade relations:** Trade diversification and enhancing the export basket of Bhutan are required to decrease its external debt.
- **Tourism:** Exploiting opportunities in **tourism**, especially in the cultural sphere.
- **Currency Swap:** India is taking steps in **increasing the currency swap** limit under the SAARC currency swap framework.
- **Balance of Payment:** Steps should be taken in **decreasing the negative balance of payment for Bhutan** by diversifying its export basket by helping them in the manufacturing and service sectors.

FOREIGN AID

- The majority of India's aid goes to Bhutan, but it has fallen over the past two years.
- Given the expanding influence of China, it is prudent for India to continue its assistance.

HYDROPOWER

- The promise made by India to develop 10,000 MW of hydropower and purchase extra power from Bhutan must be kept.

EDUCATIONAL AND INDUSTRIAL SECTOR

- **Knowledge sharing:** The National Knowledge Network of India and the Research and Education Network of Bhutan are integrated. This would make it easier for students and universities to share knowledge.
- **India Bhutan Foundation:** It was founded in 2003 with the goal of strengthening inter-human connections and fostering the exchange of ideas in the fields of science, education, and culture.

SPACE & ENVIRONMENT COOPERATION

- MoU on peaceful uses of outer space and an MoU on the environment, and natural resources was signed between the countries.
- With a ground Earth station for the **South Asia Satellite (SAS)**, India and Bhutan have been cooperating in space activities.
- Four Bhutanese engineers who are being taught by ISRO are working on the **INS-2B satellite** of Bhutan.

COUNTERING CHINA

- **Boundary disputes:** Bhutan knows the importance of India and Chinese aggressive policy over land disputes.
- **Engaging in border management and defense cooperation:** It can create strong resistance against Chinese aggression.

IS BHUTAN DRIFTING AWAY FROM INDIA?

- **Enhanced engagement with China:** Above issues have helped Bhutan to leverage its position to enhance its engagement with China.
- **Ties with Bhutan:** China is in the process to create diplomatic ties with Bhutan which Bhutan has not yet accepted.
- **Bhutan's balancing act:** Bhutan has adopted the balancing act when it comes to India-China matters. Even during the 2017 **Doklam crisis**, Bhutan adopted a balancing approach.
- **Dissatisfaction from India:** Anticipating backlash from China for siding with India on the current border conflict, Bhutan is delicately drifting from India.

HOW IS INDIA REVAMPING ITS RELATIONS WITH BHUTAN NOW?

- India is likely to approve Bhutan's request for a new land custom station and open another **Integrated Check Post (ICP)**.
- India has expedited its efforts to build railway connectivity with Bhutan to increase connectivity and hence, promote trade.

NEW BHUTANESE TERRITORY CLAIMED BY CHINA

- In **June 2020** China attempted to stop UNDP-GEF funding for **Sakteng Sanctuary** situated on the eastern border of Bhutan.

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• Indian Interest:

- **China's new claim:** The eastern part of Bhutan is guided by its '**subdued Neighborhood**' policy.
- **Pressurising Neighbours:** Hence pressurizing those countries who are distant from China and have cordial relations with India.
- **Location: Eastern Sakteng is situated along the boundary of Arunachal Pradesh** which China claims to be part of its Tibet region hence such a claim could further complicate the boundary dispute issues.

Recent Meeting Between India and Bhutan:

- PM Modi's recent visit intends to build on this special relationship, especially as Bhutan confronts its internal and external challenges.
- India also signed eight MoUs to ease economic pressure and promote trade, connectivity, space cooperation, and people-to-people relations.
- During the visit, India assured assistance of Rs 100 billion— Rs 85 billion for the 13th FYP and Rs 15 billion for the economic package.
- These agreements facilitate the trade of petroleum products, food products, and medicines. An MoU was signed to establish two railway lines—Kokrajhar-Gelephu and Banarhat-Samtse—between India and Bhutan to increase connectivity and trade. India also agreed to strengthen trade and investment linkages and infrastructure, especially in the Gelephu SAR.
- On border negotiations, India expressed satisfaction with Bhutan's cooperation on mutual security and agreed to continue close coordination on issues of national interests. This indicates that India understands Bhutan's urgency and compulsions to demarcate borders
- The highlight of the visit, of Bhutan's King conferring Bhutan's highest civilian award on PM Modi. Agreement for recognition of official control exercised by Bhutan Food And Drug Authority (BFDA) by the Food Safety and Standards Authority Of India (FSSAI) will facilitate the trade between India and Bhutan by promoting ease of doing business and reducing compliance costs on both sides.

CHINA-BHUTAN BORDER DELIMITATION MEET

They discussed the 3-step roadmap for the resolution of border issues. The 3-Step roadmap MoU was signed in 2021. The three steps are:

- Agreeing to the border on the table.
- Formally demarcating the boundary.
- Visiting the sites on the ground.

Looking west, the United States and India are actively deepening their ties; it appears inevitable that the Quad will have to bring military cooperation within its framework. With such high stakes, New Delhi should urge Thimphu to maintain the status quo in Doklam in the face of continued pressure from Beijing.

Keywords:

Subdued Neighborhood, Integrated Check Post, South Asia Satellite (SAS), Trijunction, Buffer State, Free Trade Regime and Duty-Free Transit.

8

INDIA AND SRI LANKA

INTRODUCTION

- According to Mahinda Rajapaksha, a former prime minister of Sri Lanka, "India is a relative of Sri Lanka while all other countries are friends."
- There has been extensive intellectual, cultural, religious, and linguistic exchange between India and Sri Lanka during the course of their more than 2500-year relationship.

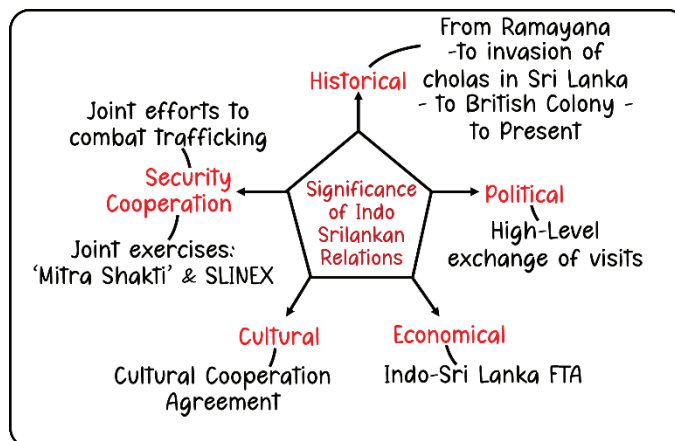
OVERVIEW OF RELATIONS

GEOSTRATEGIC SIGNIFICANCE OF SRI LANKA

- **Trade:** It is situated on crucial water routes that connect to the Indian Ocean, where 90% of India's trade takes place.
- **Indo Pacific Strategy:** In reaction to Chinese aggression in the South China Sea, an effort was made to ensure free and open access for navigation.

ECONOMIC

- **Largest trading partner:** With a total bilateral merchandise trade of US\$5.45 billion in 2021—a significant rise (about 48%) over 2020—India was Sri Lanka's largest trading partner.]
- **Currency swap:** Recently, in order to increase Sri Lanka's foreign reserves and guarantee financial stability following COVID-19, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) struck an agreement to grant a \$400 million currency exchange facility to Sri Lanka.
- **Investment:** India has reportedly already made FDI investments of more than US\$ 2.2 billion, according to the Central Bank of Sri Lanka. In 2021, India attracted the greatest amount of FDI (\$142 million).



POLITICAL

- **High-level exchanges:** High-level exchanges of visits at regular intervals have been a defining feature of the political relations between the two nations.
- **Neighbourhood First Policy of India:** It is an extension of Sabka Saath Sabka Vikaas in the realm of foreign policy.
- **'India first' policy:** Although on his maiden foreign trip, Sri Lanka's president emphasized his country's "India first" strategy and declared that "while China is a friend, India is relative."

DEFENSE AND SECURITY COOPERATION

- **Military Exercise:** India and Sri Lanka conduct annual joint Military exercise '**Mitra Shakti**' and Naval exercise.
- **SLINEX.** It is a annual, Bilateral Naval exercise between India and Sri Lanka.
- **Maritime security:** A trilateral maritime security cooperation agreement has been struck by India, Sri Lanka, and the Maldives to enhance surveillance, anti-piracy operations, and reduce maritime pollution in the Indian Ocean region.
 - India and Sri Lanka also reached an agreement in 2019 to combat human and drug trafficking.
- **Trilateral security meeting:** Terrorism and radicalization, marine safety and security, human trafficking and organized crime, and cyber security were acknowledged as the "four pillars" of collaboration.

CULTURAL AND EDUCATIONAL COOPERATION

- **Agreement:** India and Sri Lanka signed a **cultural cooperation agreement back in 1977.**
 - **Scholarship:** India provides scholarships to qualified Sri Lankan students in Undergraduate and research studies. Sri Lanka is also a partner in the Nalanda **university** project of India.
- **Training:** Through the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) Programme, India offers representatives from several Sri Lankan government ministries 402 fully compensated positions each year.
- **People to people ties:** Through cultural connectedness like Buddhism. Tamil decency, etc.

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- In order to deepen these ties, the **Swami Vivekananda Cultural Centre (SVCC)**, the cultural branch of the Indian High Commission in Colombo, has been instrumental

DEVELOPMENTAL ASSISTANCE

- **Community Development:** India and Sri Lanka reached a bilateral agreement to increase the cap on High Impact Community Development Projects (HICDP)
- **Rehabilitation and relief: Assistance** for internally displaced Tamils. India has constructed 30000 houses and other medical facility infrastructure.
- **Swap Agreement:** Under the SAARC currency exchange framework, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) and the Central Bank of Sri Lanka (CBSL) have finalized a USD 400 million currency swap arrangement.
- **LoC:** Exim Bank has so far extended nine LOC to Sri Lanka including the latest one taking the total value to \$1.68 billion. LoC of \$4 billion in emergency assistance extended by India during the peak of Sri Lanka's financial crisis early last year.

ISSUES IN RELATION

ISSUES	ABOUT
Tamil Issue	• The Buddhist majority in Sinhala discriminates against people of different religions and languages. The official status of Tamil is lacking, and Buddhism is given priority in both employment and education. • Denied Citizenship: The bulk of Tamils were refused citizenship. Thus, the majority of Tamils in Sri Lanka's tea estates continued to live in poverty. • Civil war and human rights abuses: The UN estimates that 40,000 civilians alone died in the five months before to the end of the conflict between the • 20th Amendment: which weakens the 13th Amendment, was introduced by Sri Lanka's new government. Other requirements of the Indo-Sri Lanka Accord of 1987, such provincial Autonomy and Tamil language recognition, are also not followed. LTTE and Sri Lankan government in May 2009.
China Factor	• Concerns have been raised regarding China's 99-year lease of Sri Lanka's vital Hambantota Port. Observations of Chinese submarines at the port have raised more questions about security. • The joint venture between India and Sri Lanka for managing the Mattala Rajapaksa International Airport has not progressed as intended and the problems have been • exacerbated by the project's proximity to the airport and the China-run Hambantota port.
Fisherman Issue (Katchatheevu Island)	• Katchatheevu island is where the main conflict is. In 1974, the island was given to Sri Lanka. • Although the agreement grants Indian fishermen access to Katchatheevu for rest and nest drying, it does not guarantee the rights to engage in traditional fishing. • When Indian fishermen invade Sri Lankan waterways, arrests and attacks have escalated since the civil war's end in 2009. Sri Lanka also objects to Indian fishermen using large trawlers. • To find a long-term solution, both nations have established the Joint Working Group framework. A MoU was also signed between India and Sri Lanka to give fishermen nets and other tools they need.
India's Financing Assurance	• India became the first bilateral creditor of the island nation to formally back its critical debt restructure programme following last year's economic catastrophe when it issued written financial assurances to the International Monetary Fund (IMF). • Only until China, Japan, and India, Sri Lanka's official creditors, have given sufficient finance assurances, will the IMF's interim USD 2.9 billion package to Sri Lanka be approved. • Asserting India's commitment to the idea of "neighborhood first" and not allowing a partner to fend for themselves, the choice to Finance assurance was also a statement of India's belief in the ideal.
Trade Balance in favor of India	• In 2018, India exported \$4.16 billion to Sri Lanka, while Sri Lanka exported \$767 million to India. • Sri Lanka desires improved access to Indian markets as well as a reduction in this disparity.

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Recent Developments:

- India's relations with Sri Lanka are entering a distinct phase following the 2022 economic crisis in the island state. In a recent statement, India's Minister of External Affairs S Jaishankar said that during the crisis, India provided Sri Lanka with economic and humanitarian assistance of over US\$4.5 billion and supported Sri Lanka's debt restructuring efforts.
- Responding to Jaishankar's call to Indians to visit Sri Lanka, Sri Lanka's Minister of Tourism Harin Fernando reinforced the invitation, stating that "Sri Lanka is a part of India". This triggered domestic criticism of the minister's statement and a protest staged in front of the Ministry of Tourism, calling for his resignation. The minister subsequently clarified that such attacks were politically motivated and that he had attempted to say that the two countries were similar to one another and that he was not attempting to "sell Sri Lanka to India".
- In February 2024, Phase-IV of the Indian Housing Project, 'Bharat-Lanka', was launched by Sri Lanka's President Ranil Wickremesinghe. The project is aimed at constructing 10,000 houses with Indian grant assistance for plantation sector workers in Sri Lanka. In the same month, India introduced its Unified Payment Interface in Sri Lanka. This is yet another step-in attempt to deepen financial connectivity between the two countries, with the authorisation of the Indian Rupee as a designated currency in 2023.

COLOMBO SECURITY CONCLAVE: 6th Colombo Security Conclave (CSC) meeting in Mauritius

It came in 2011, with Sri Lanka joining India and the Maldives for a trilateral maritime security grouping but came to a standstill after 2014 due to rising tensions between India and the Maldives.

In 2020, India pushed Colombo Security Conclave for the revival, institutionalization and expansion to Mauritius, the Seychelles, and Bangladesh.

Significance of the Colombo Security Conclave for India

- For Leadership: An opportunity to strengthen its leadership and security architecture.
- To Counter Threats: An opportunity to institutionalize its role, shape the regional security architecture, and better address the existing and emerging threats.
- To Counter China Factor: Since the early 2000s, China has invested substantively in the Indian Ocean with its Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) projects, helping it access the Indian Ocean.
 - China's outreach is to control the crucial sea lines of communication and trade and to limit India's influence and presence.
 - China is strengthening its naval capabilities and also maintains strong defense relationships with countries in the Indian Ocean region.
 - It has established a base in Djibouti and controls Sri Lanka's Hambantota port.
 - It continues to use scientific ships to map the Indian Ocean bed.
 - China also wants to counter the prevailing security architecture in the Indian Ocean by institutionalizing its presence through platforms such as the Indian Ocean Region Forum on Development Cooperation.

WAY FORWARD

- Connectivity:** Economic integration through development of connectivity via **Palk strait bridge**.
- Economic Integration Roadmap (EIRM):** It is based on Sub Regionalism and aims to connect 5 southern states of India with Sri Lanka to tap a total of 300 million population and \$500 billion GDP.
- Private Investment:** Need to deepen private investment from India in SL in the infrastructure, energy and connectivity in a time bound manner.
- Leveraging Blue Economy:** India may also collaborate with nations like Japan and Australia to strengthen Sri Lanka's infrastructure and connections while utilizing the Blue Economy.
- Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA):** To enhance the economic cooperation between the two nations, it must be inked.
- Aiding Fishermen:** States must get assistance from the department of ocean development and the ministry of agriculture so that fishermen in Palk Bay can find alternate means of income.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	India is an age-old friend of Sri Lanka'. Discuss India's role in the recent crisis in Sri Lanka in light of the preceding statement.	2022
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9

INDIA- MALDIVES

INTRODUCTION

India was one of the earliest countries to acknowledge the independence of Maldives in 1965 and establish diplomatic ties with the nation. The prompt aid provided by India during the 1988 coup plot, known as 'Operation Cactus,' played a crucial role in fostering trust and cultivating enduring and amicable bilateral relations with the Maldives.

OVERVIEW OF THE RELATIONSHIP

- **Economic:** A trade agreement was signed between India and Maldives in 1981. India is Maldives' 4th largest trade partner.
 - India climbed from the fourth position in 2018 to become Maldives' second-largest trading partner, with bilateral trade in 2021 experiencing a 31% growth despite pandemic obstacles.
 - India-Maldives bilateral trade in 2021 stands at US\$ 323.9 million with the trade balance in favor of India.
- **Defense:** India offers the highest number of training opportunities for the Maldivian National Defence Force (MNDF), fulfilling approximately 70% of their defense training needs.
 - In April 2016, a comprehensive Action Plan for Defence was signed to strengthen the defense partnership.
 - The establishment of the Composite Training Centre for MNDF, the implementation of the Coastal Radar Surveillance System, and the construction of the new Ministry of Defence Headquarters.
- **Disaster management:** India provided substantial aid to the Maldives after the 2004 tsunami and the 2014 Male water crisis. Customized training programs for the MNDF Fire and Rescue Service were also offered in India.
- **Developmental Cooperation:** India has implemented notable development projects in the Maldives, such as the Indira Gandhi Memorial Hospital, Maldives Institute of Technical Education, and the National College for Policing and Law Enforcement (NCPLE).
 - **Connectivity project:** India has also provided US \$500 million in assistance for the **Greater Male Connectivity Project (GMCP)**, the largest civilian infrastructure project in Maldives, to connect Male to three neighboring islands.
- **Covid related assistance:** A 14-member Rapid Response Medical team was deployed in the Maldives in March 2020 to guide and train the Maldivian authorities and personnel in tackling the Corona threat.
- **Operation Sanjeevani:** As part of GoI's efforts to help friendly countries in tackling the Covid-19 threat, a special IAF plane airlifted 6.2 tonnes of essential medical supplies from India to Maldives on 2 April 2020.

SIGNIFICANCE	ISSUES
• Countering Radicalization: More than 200 Maldivian youths have joined ISIS. Growing radicalization due to political instability and socio-economic uncertainty can give the opportunity for Pakistan to establish terror launch pads in Maldives. • Rising Chinese footprint: Maldives is an important part of China's string of pearls strategy of Containing India. China's policy of Debt Trap Diplomacy can give it access to strategic real estate in Maldives. ◦ China-Maldives Friendship Bridge, funded by Beijing with \$200 million, is one of several projects of China in the tropical South Asian nation	• Domestic political grievances: Democratic institutions have experienced a decline in strength, leaving them vulnerable. Furthermore, if not governed effectively, fragile democracies may become susceptible to radical ideologies. • Hub of terrorism: The rise of Islamist radicalism in the island nation of Maldives is primarily fueled by political instability and socio-economic challenges. • Additionally, there is concern that Saudi Arabia has played a role in the radicalization of Maldives. In fact, Maldives has recorded one of the highest per capita numbers of ISIS terrorists. China's influence in the Maldives: India is growing increasingly concerned about China's expanding influence in the Maldives, largely driven by numerous investment projects led by Beijing. ◦ The Maldives has now become a significant component of China's strategic "String of Pearls" initiative in South Asia.

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renowned for its beautiful beaches and lagoons.	• Economical: The bilateral trade between Maldives and India is currently at a very low level, and the two countries do not have a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) in place.
• Economic: Trade and commercial exchanges between India and Maldives have stagnated and need to match their potential. COVID-19 will hurt Maldives' economy and push it deeper into China's debt trap. • The Yameen camp launched an "India Out" campaign against New Delhi's massive developmental funding and demanded that the Solih administration "stop selling national assets to foreigners, implying India."	• Anti-Indian sentiments: The Maldives National Defence Force received training utilizing two Indian Dhruv Advanced Light Helicopters. ◦ However, due to their military nature, certain individuals critical of India alleged that their provision indicated an establishment of a military presence in the country. • Misunderstanding of India's efforts: There have been speculations suggesting that the UTF Harbour Project agreement between India and the Maldives, which aims to develop a coastguard harbor at Uthuru Thila Falhu, might potentially be converted into an Indian naval base.

Recent Developments and Issues:

- India has begun withdrawing military personnel operating surveillance aircraft in the Maldives after the new pro-China president ordered them to leave.
- The two sides had agreed to complete a withdrawal of 89 Indian soldiers and their support staff from the nation of 1,192 tiny coral islands by May 10.
- Three Indian aircraft – two helicopters and one fixed-wing plane – will be operated by Indian civilian staff.
- Maldives President announced that the country will not renew an agreement with India to conduct hydrographic surveys. Maldives plans to acquire the facilities and machines required to do the exercise by itself.
- Earlier, Chinese marine research vessel Xiang Yang Hong 3 returned to Maldivian waters.
- The vessel was observed docked at the Thilafushi industrial island's harbor, although the specific reason for its return remains undisclosed by the government.
- It is pertinent to know that ties between India and the Maldives have become strained since Maldives President Mohamed Muizzu assumed office in November.

WAY FORWARD

- **'India First Policy':** The present government of Maldives has announced its 'India First Policy'. India should use this opportunity to strengthen bilateral relations..
- **Security Partnership:** Strengthening defense partnership with a focus on maritime security to cement India's position as a "Net Security Provider" in the Indian Ocean.
- **Timely completion:** To counter Chinese gains in India, infrastructure projects must be completed on time. India can collaborate with Japan on connectivity projects.
- **Diaspora:** India should use its Diaspora more and use cultural elements like films, music, and people-to-people contacts to strengthen relations.

CONCLUSION

- The successful bilateral cooperation between India and Maldives can serve as a valuable model for strengthening ties with other neighboring countries, aligning with India's Neighbourhood First policy. India should continue its partnership in development with the Maldives to enhance and solidify the relationship.

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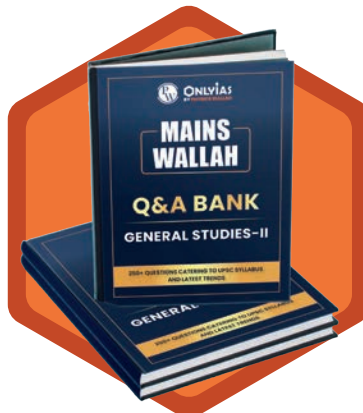
India Out, 'India First Policy', hydrographic surveys, Chinese footprint, Operation Sanjeevani, Currency Swap Agreement.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Discuss the political developments in Maldives in the last two years. Should they be of any cause of concern to India?	2013
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INDIA - USA

INTRODUCTION

- Prime Minister Shri Narendra Modi and President H.E. Mr Joe Biden in a recent meeting affirmed a vision of India and the United States as among the closest partners in the world – a partnership of democracies looking into the 21st century with hope, ambition, and confidence.
- India-US relations have evolved over the last seven decades, from being described as '**estranged democracies**' to '**Natural Allies**'.
- They have evolved into a "comprehensive global strategic partnership" based on common democratic values and growing convergence of interests on bilateral, regional, and global concerns.
- **Harsh Pant**: Reflexive anti-Americanism is no longer evident in Indian foreign policy.
- **Amitabh Mattu**: Indo-US relations are going through a 'wow phase'.
- **Barack Obama**: Overcoming the hesitation of the Past, "Most defining partnership of 21st Century."

DIFFERENT ASPECTS OF INDO-US RELATIONS

DEFENSE

- It is known as the 'Brightest Spot' in Indo-US ties. The India-US defense trade has increased tremendously in a short period of time and presently stands at \$119.42 billion.
- The US is now India's fourth largest arms provider and India conducts most joint exercises with the USA.
 - India has signed four fundamental defense agreements with the United States.
 - **GSOMIA** (General Security of Military Information Agreement): The General Security of Military Information Agreement (GSOMIA) on military information exchange was signed in 2002.
 - **LEMOA**: In 2016, the two countries agreed to use each other's military bases under a Logistics Exchange Memorandum of Agreement (LEMOA).
 - **COMCASA**: In 2018, the two militaries signed the Communications Compatibility and Security Agreement (COMCASA) to facilitate interoperability and the export of advanced technology to India.
 - **BECA**: In 2020, signed to share cutting-edge military technology, logistics, and geospatial mapping.
 - General Electric (GE) and Hindustan Aeronautical Limited (HAL) signed an MoU for co-production of GE 414 Jet Engines for the indigenous Tejas Mk2 light combat aircraft.
 - India's purchase of armed drones and collaboration in defense industrial innovation through the 'INDUS-X' platform were announced.

TRADE RELATIONS

- **Trade surplus**: In 2022-23, India had a trade surplus with the United States of \$28 billion.
- **Bilateral trade**: Provisional data from the commerce ministry shows that bilateral trade between India and the US rose to US\$ 128.55 billion in 2022-23, marking a 7.65% increase from the previous year's US\$ 119.5 billion and a significant rise from the US\$ 80.51 billion in 2020-21.
- **Defense trade**: Apart from Oil, India-US defense trade is also increasing in recent years.
- Indian service sector dependence on US markets: Indian service sector and especially the IT sector is hugely dependent on US markets.
- **MORE ON INDO-US TRADE**:
 - **Investment**: According to a study report provided by the Confederation of Indian Industry (CII), about 163 Indian companies present in the US have created over USD 40 billion in tangible investments in the country.
 - **Job creation**: Furthermore, these companies have created around 425,000 jobs in the United States.
 - **Trade deal**: Both countries have set a target of \$500 billion trade and are also working on securing a 'mini trade deal' as talks on FTA are stalled.
 - **Digital tax**: India and the US Agree on a Transitional Approach on Equalisation Levy (EL) or digital tax.

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ENERGY COOPERATION: US- INDIA STRATEGIC ENERGY PARTNERSHIP

- **Strategic energy partnership:** The India-US energy dialogue has been upgraded to the level of strategic energy partnership (SEP). Both countries launched the US-India Climate and Clean Energy Agenda 2030 Partnership during the Leaders' Summit on Climate in 2021.
 - Partnership for the 2030 Agenda between the United States and India.
 - Strategic Clean Energy Partnership (SCEP) has been redesigned.
 - The India-US Civil Nuclear Energy Cooperation was reviewed.
 - The Gas Task Force has been renamed the India-US Low Emissions Gas Task Force.
- **Civil Nuclear Cooperation (2008):**
 - **AP 1000 reactors:** The two sides have started the preparatory work on site in India for six AP 1000 reactors to be built by Westinghouse. Once completed, the project would be among the largest of its kind.
 - **Cooperation on the Global Centre for Nuclear Energy Partnership (GCNEP):** India and the United States agreed to extend their Memorandum of Understanding for collaboration on the Global Centre for Nuclear Energy Partnership (GCNEP) by ten years in 2020.
- **Strategic Partnership:**
 - **Rise of China:** India-US strategic partnership has been strengthened in the context of the Rise of China and its aggressive behavior in the Indo-Pacific.
 - **QUAD:** Both Countries have institutionalized **2+2 Ministerial Dialogue** and are also working to strengthen **QUAD** with the aim to ensure peaceful, stable and rules-based order in the Indo-Pacific.
- **I2U2:** I2U2 partnership projects and initiatives are not limited in geographic scope – the Group will explore opportunities anywhere it can make a positive impact. I2U2 is a partnership between India, Israel, the UAE, and the U.S. that's working to tackle global challenges and advance economic opportunities.
- **Key agreements in 2+2 ministerial dialogue to strengthen cooperation on:** Global Partnership and Indo- Pacific Cooperation, Mutual Prosperity, Innovation, and Resilient Supply Chains, Climate, Environment, and Clean Energy, Science, Technology, Cybersecurity, and Space, Global Health, Defense and Security, Counterterrorism and Counter Narcotics, Education and People-to-People Ties.
 - **India is emerging as a Net Security Provider:** Due to the arrival of the concept of 'Indo-Pacific'. It can build collective action in humanitarian assistance and disaster relief, monitor shipping, and check the imperialist policies of China in the region.
- **QUAD:**
 - **Indo-Pacific:** USA's **Indo-Pacific Strategy** report categorizes India as a '**vital partner**' in the region.
 - **BLUE DOT NETWORK:** To certify projects that are "open and inclusive, transparent, economically viable, financially, environmentally, and socially sustainable, and in accordance with international standards, laws, and regulations. The Blue Dot network is part of the US's Indo-Pacific strategy, which is aimed at countering Chinese President Xi Jinping's ambitious BRI.
 - **Important pillars of strategic partnership:** Counterterrorism, Maritime security , and cyber security are other important pillars of strategic partnership.

INDIA AS A COUNTERBALANCE TO CHINA

- **China as the greatest strategic threat to the USA:** US's **National Defence Strategy** 2018 and the National Security Strategy 2017 identified revisionist China as the greatest strategic threat to the USA.
 - **US views India as a geopolitical counterbalance to China:** The US views India as a geopolitical counterbalance, an economic alternative and a democratic contrast to China. And for India, the US is crucial to its China policy not just in terms of internal balancing and capacity building, but also external balancing.
 - **India as a net provider of security in the IOR region:** The USA's objective is to accelerate India's rise and capacity to serve as a **net provider of security in the IOR region** and a major defence partner of the USA.
- **Indo-Pacific Strategy Report:** US Department of Defence recently released 'Indo-Pacific Strategy Report.' at the Shangri-La Dialogue. It categorizes India as a vital partner of the USA in the Indian Ocean region and in South Asia due to China's growing assertiveness in IOR.

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INDO- US COOPERATION DURING PANDEMIC

- **Raw material for vaccine:** The US has diverted its pending orders of vaccine filters to India's vaccine manufacturers and has also identified sources of specific raw material urgently required for Indian manufacture of the vaccines. It will help India make more vaccines.
- **COVID-19 test kits:** It had sent C-5M Super Galaxy transport aircraft with oxygen cylinders, medical equipment, and COVID-19 test kits to India.

COOPERATION AT GLOBAL LEVEL

- **US support for India's permanent membership in UNSC:** The U.S. has expressed **support for India's permanent membership** in a reformed U.N. Security Council and for India's early membership in the Nuclear Suppliers Group.
- **Global Development Partnership Deal:** The India-US Global Development Partnership has been extended for another five years. The Global Development Partnership Agreement provides for collaborative support to partner countries.
- **Triangular Cooperation for Global Development:** Statement of Guiding Principles (SGP) on Triangular Cooperation for Global Development, extending the pact's validity up to 2026.
- **FTF ITT:** Feed The Future India Triangular Training Program (FTF ITT) for Africa under GDP.

ISSUES IN INDO-US RELATIONSHIP

- **India-Russia friendship:** Russia is India's biggest arms supplier. This will hinder the increasing interoperability and communications between armed forces of 2 countries as American military hardware is not compatible with the Russian ones.
- **USA's Position on CAATSA:** The USA has threatened to sanction India under the S-400 missile defense system deal with Russia.
- **US-Pakistan Relationship:** Many democrats including President Biden, during his campaign have raised concerns over human rights in Kashmir. This can help Pakistan to internationalize the issue.
- **In WTO issue of North-South divide:** While the US and the other developed countries are trying to side-track the Doha Development Agenda and introduce 'New Issues', India is working with other developing countries to pressurize developed countries to fulfill their commitments under DDA.
- **In Trade:**
 - **Pending Bilateral Investment Treaty:** The Bilateral Investment Treaty between India and USA is pending for a long time.
 - **India's Tariff Regime:** The United States has longstanding concerns over India's tariff regime, which has relatively high average tariff rates, especially in agriculture.
 - **Digital Services Tax (DST):** The United States established a "political agreement" with India on DST treatment in November 2021.
 - **U.S. Generalized System of Preferences (GSP):** In 2019, the United States removed India from GSP, a U.S. trade and development program, due to market access issues.
- **Investment:** India has made some FDI reforms, such as raising foreign equity caps for insurance, and e-commerce platforms and launching a new system to streamline FDI approvals.
- **Defense Trade:** India wants more technology-sharing and co-production projects, while the US wants additional reforms in India's defense offsets policy and higher FDI limitations in the defense sector.
- **In-Services:** The two nations are competitive in some services industries. Limits on foreign ownership and local presence requirements in India are among the obstacles to US corporations' market access.
- **In Agriculture:** In the United States, sanitary and phytosanitary (SPS) obstacles impede India's agricultural exports. Each side perceives the other's agricultural support schemes as distorting the market. The two parties decided to collaborate at the TPF.
- **Intellectual Property (IP):** The United States 2021 "Special 301" report maintained India on its Priority Watch List.
- **"Forced" Localization:** In 2022, India appealed against a ruling of the World Trade Organisation's (WTO) trade dispute settlement panel which ruled that the country's domestic support measures for sugar and sugarcane are inconsistent with global trade norms.

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Geostrategic:

- **In Afghanistan:** USA's announcement to withdraw from Afghanistan can destabilize the country which can have a spillover effect in Kashmir.
- **Indo Pacific:** While India's primary focus is on the Indian Ocean, the USA is more focused on the Pacific Ocean.
- **Middle East:** Trump Administration's Maximum Pressure strategy for **Iran** has impacted India-Iran relations and Iran has moved closer to China.
- **Russia-Ukraine war:** The US imposed sanctions against Russia while India seemed to be non-aligned on the issue.
- **China:** Both countries are sometimes suspicious of each other due to possible future cooperation with China. It limits the deep and long-term deals between the countries.
- **On Data Sovereignty:**
 - **Osaka Track:** India boycotted the Osaka Track on the Digital Economy in 2019. It advocated for the passage of legislation allowing for the free movement of data across countries. However, India opposed the free flow of data since it violated its sovereignty.
 - **The CLOUD Act of the USA** allows security agencies to procure data stored in servers regardless of whether data originates in the US or foreign soil.
 - **Data localisation:** USA govt was of the view that India's proposed law as a significant barrier to digital trade.
- **On Climate Change:**
 - **Failure in meeting financial commitments:** Failure of meeting financial and other commitments by the USA and other developed countries for the developing world.
 - **Differences over Net Zero emission targets:** Differences emerged over 'Net Zero emission' – USA pushes this at the global forum that India views as failing to meet earlier targets. (though India committed to Net Zero).

Recent Developments in India US Relationship:

- The inauguration of the Initiative on Critical and Emerging Technology (iCET) in January 2023 as a major milestone in India-US relations. The leaders recommitted the United States and India to fostering an open, accessible, and secure technology ecosystem, based on mutual confidence and trust that reinforces our shared values and democratic institutions.
- A Joint Quantum Coordination Mechanism was established to facilitate joint research between the public and private sectors across both countries.
- General Electric (GE) and Hindustan Aeronautics Limited (HAL) signed an MoU for co-production of GE 414 Jet Engines for the indigenous Tejas Mk2 light combat aircraft.
- India's purchase of armed drones and collaboration in defense industrial innovation through the 'INDUS-X' platform were announced.
- They welcomed the decision of NASA and ISRO to develop a strategic framework for human spaceflight cooperation by the end of 2023. The leaders hailed the announcement by NASA to provide advanced training to Indian astronauts at the Johnson Space Center in Houston, Texas, with a goal of mounting a joint effort to the International Space Station in 2024.
- INDUS-X, the India-United States Defence Acceleration Ecosystem, was launched to promote collaboration between Indian and U.S. start-ups and tech companies.
- A MoU on Semiconductor Supply Chain and Innovation Partnership was signed between the countries.
- India became the newest partner of the U.S.'s Minerals Security Partnership (MSP) to diversify and secure critical mineral supply chains.
- Micron Technology, Inc. planned to invest in a new chip assembly and test facility in Gujarat, supported by the Indian government and Gujarat State government.

India US 2+2 DIALOGUE:

EAM Jaishankar said "We are exploring cooperation in new domains such as critical technologies, collaboration in civil outer space and in areas of critical minerals"

- U.S. Secretary of State Antony Blinken and U.S. Defense Secretary Lloyd Austin met with Indian Minister of External Affairs S. Jaishankar and Indian Defense Minister Rajnath Singh in New Delhi, November 10th, marking the fifth U.S.-India 2+2 Ministerial Dialogue.

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- The dialogue discussed a broad range of issues, including Indo-Pacific security, the Israel-Hamas conflict, and the conflict in Ukraine, emphasizing the increasing importance of the bilateral partnership for joint defense efforts and global supply chain securitization.
- **Conflicts in Gaza:** During the meeting, India and the United States jointly declared support for a political solution to the conflict between Israel and Hamas. The two countries further called for a humanitarian pause and the continuation of diplomatic coordination with key partners in the region. Both sides pledged humanitarian support for Palestinian civilians in Gaza.
- **War in Ukraine:** Both India and the United States similarly cited mutual concern over the war's emerging humanitarian crisis. Notably, the two countries took similar stances on the conflict, drawing attention to the economic impacts of the war in addition to its social consequences. Both India and the United States also pledged humanitarian assistance to Ukrainian citizens.
- **Afghanistan:** Political developments in Afghanistan and Bangladesh also came up in the meeting. Indian and U.S. ministers jointly urged the Taliban to preserve Afghan human rights and refrain from using Afghan territory for further terrorist activity
- **Technology:** The two sides discussed strengthening the partnership between India and the United States on semiconductors. Blinken emphasized collaboration in the semiconductor production sector, calling for closer educational cooperation between the two countries.

WAY FORWARD

- **Connectivity:** The USA can invest in India, and Japan proposed the Asia African growth corridor. Both countries can also undertake joint infrastructure development programmes in IOR littoral states to counter Chinese projects in the region.
- **TRADE:** Both countries need to finalize the Bilateral Investment Treaty to achieve the target of \$500 billion in trade by 2025.
- **De-risking Supply Chains-** US can work with India, Australia and Japan to diversify and de-risk supply chains through Supply Chain Resilience Initiative.
- **Space Governance:** Due to shared concerns about the Chinese Army's growing space capabilities, space governance will become a focal point of the US-India bilateral relationship.
- **Cooperation for a free & rule-based Indo-Pacific region:** The two countries' cooperation is critical for ensuring a free, open, and rules-based Indo-Pacific region.
- **Technology transfer:** The unmatched Demographic Dividend presents significant opportunities for US and Indian enterprises in technology transfer, manufacturing, trade, and investment.

CONCLUSION

- India is establishing itself as a vital actor in an international system that is undergoing extraordinary transformation. It will study opportunities to further its critical interests based on its current status.

Keywords:

Technology transfer, Duty-free entry, Forced Localization, Regional Integration, BLUE DOT NETWORK, GSOMIA, LEMOA, BECA, COMCASA, estranged democracies, Natural Allies.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	The USA is facing an existential threat in the form of China, that is much more challenging than the erstwhile Soviet Union." Explain.	2021
2.	What is the significance of Indo-US defense deals over Indo-Russian defense deals? Discuss with reference to stability in the Indo-Pacific region.	2020
3.	What introduces friction into the ties between India and the United States is that Washington is still unable to find for India a position in its global strategy, which would satisfy India's national self-esteem and ambitions. Explain with suitable examples.	2019
4.	India and the USA are two large democracies. Examine the basic tenets on which the two political systems are based.	2018

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INDIA - RUSSIA

INTRODUCTION

Recently, India and Russia signed three documents including a Protocol on consultations during the External Affairs Minister's official visit to Russia in December 2023.

- The protocol will foster progress in military and economic cooperation, energy trade, military-technical cooperation, connectivity and people-to people exchanges.
- The longstanding and time-tested partnership between India and Russia is driven by '**deep mutual trust**', shared interests of multilateralism, and global peace and prosperity.
- **At the Sochi Summit, in 2018**, the relationship was elevated to a '**Special and Privileged Partnership**'.

AREAS OF COOPERATION

Defence:

- **Arms import:** Russia continues to be India's largest arms supplier, even though its share of Indian defence imports fell from 62% to 45% between 2017-2022, France came second with 29% of Indian arms imports-SIPRI report
- **Share strategic technology:** The **S-400 defence system** deal also highlights India's desire to maintain strategic autonomy.
- Bilateral projects licensed production of T-90 tanks and Su-30 MKI, production of Ak-203 rifles in India and BrahMos missiles among others.
- **INDRA as a tri-service bilateral military exercise.**

Trade:

- **Bilateral trade:** During FY 2021-22 amounted to \$13.2 billion. (\$30 billion set for 2025)
- Bilateral investments between the two countries crossed the US\$30 billion target set in 2018. (\$50 billion target set for 2025)
- **India's participation in the Eastern Economic Forum:** India also participated in the Eastern Economic Forum and extended a \$ 1 billion line of credit for the development of the far-right region of Russia.

Energy:

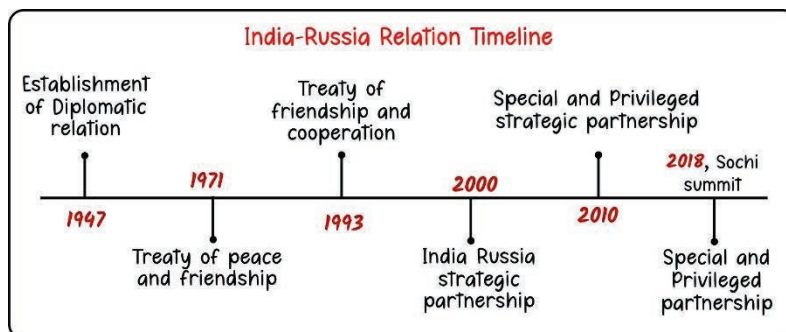
- **Natural gas:** Russia -largest reserves of Natural Gas in the world. India's ONGC Videsh has acquired 20% stakes in Sakhalin oil and gas plant.
- **In St. Petersburg Declaration:** Both countries agreed to joint exploration of hydrocarbons in the Arctic region. Russia's '**Pivot to Asia**' strategy and India's **Draft Arctic Policy** both highlight convergence between the 2 countries.
- **Nuclear Energy Production:** Kudankulam Nuclear Power Plant (KKNPP) is being built in India with Russian cooperation.

Geopolitical convergence:

- **The goal of Multipolar World Order:** Both countries are cooperating through BIMSTEC, and SCO to realize this objective.
- **Both see China as a strategic adversary:** Russia continues to see China as a potential strategic adversary in the future. Hence it is deepening cooperation with countries like India, Vietnam, Indonesia etc..
- **Support for UNSC seat to India:** Russia has also supported India's claim for a permanent seat in UNSC .
- India and Russia have called for the Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism to be finalized as soon as possible.

Cultural Relations:

- **Russian students learning Hindi:** About 20 Russian Institutions, including leading universities and schools, regularly teach Hindi to about 1500 Russian students.
- Programmes like 'Namaste Russia' and "Festival of India in Russia" celebrated in India.



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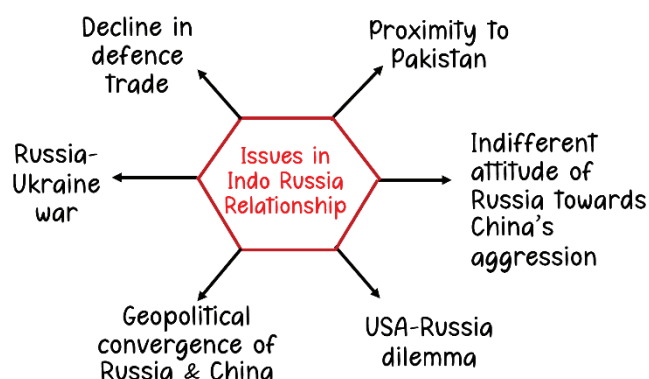
Space technology:

- **Aryabhata and Bhaskar:** The former Soviet Union launched India's first two satellites, Aryabhata and Bhaskar.
- **Russia provided India with cryogenic technology:** Russia has also provided India with **Cryogenic technology** to build heavy rockets.
- **Cooperate in outer space:** Both parties collaborate on peaceful uses of space, such as satellite launches, the GLONASS navigation system, remote sensing, and other societal applications of space.
- **Cooperation in the Gaganyaan mission:** The four cosmonauts chosen for India's first manned space mission, Gaganyaan, have completed their training in Russia.

ISSUES IN RELATIONSHIP

- **Defence:** Though Russia still commands 45 % of total arms imports by India, this figure is a step down from 2010-14 when Russia's share was 70%.
 - India needs to reduce its defence supplies from Russia as part of defence modernization, and diversification and to avoid USA sanctions under CAATSA.
- **Limited areas of cooperation:** Post-cold War, India-Russia relations have become more transactional. It is centered on military cooperation and spares whereas there is little progress in other aspects of the relationship.
- **USA-Russia dilemma:** The deteriorating Russia-US relations have introduced a new element of discomfort as India seeks to maintain its longstanding connection with Russia without jeopardizing its expanding ties with the United States.
- **Trade:**
 - Poor connectivity- stalling of the International North-South Transport corridor.
 - High trade deficit between two nations. The regulatory impediments and the use of phytosanitary standards and non-tariff barriers by Russia add to it..
 - **Indo-Pacific:** As India grows beyond a regional power; its geo-strategic interests are expanding. The Indo-Pacific Region and the Eurasian Region where India is partnering with countries having stressed relations with Russia.

CAATSA Act, also known as Countering America's Adversaries Through Sanctions Act, was enacted by the USA in 2017 to impose sanctions on three nations, i.e., Russia, Iran, and North Korea.



RUSSIA-CHINA-PAKISTAN AXIS

- **The sanctions on Russia post-Ukraine crisis:** The West has pushed Russia closer to China. Both countries are working against the US and the West in Asia, the Middle East and in the Indo-Pacific.
- **Russia-China trade:** Russia-China trade stands at \$110 billion in 2019.
- **Defence and technology:** Russia also shares cutting-edge technologies in defence production with China. China has also received an S-400 missile defence system from Russia.
- **Russia has also removed the Arms embargo on Pakistan:** Both countries have also undertaken cooperative military exercises since 2014. Pakistan has already granted Russia permission to utilize its Gwadar port as part of the CPEC. Pakistan and Russia both intend to take their bilateral ties to a strategic level.

RUSSIA- UKRAINE WAR

Started on 24th February, after Russia started to invade Ukraine. Russian troops captured many cities of Ukraine including Mariupol, Kherson, Kharkiv, Sumy etc.

CAUSE OF CONFLICT

- **Shared history:** Ukraine and Russia have had cultural, linguistic, and familial ties for hundreds of years.
- **Emotional Exploitation of People:** For many Russians and ethnic Russians in Ukraine, the countries' shared heritage is an emotional issue that has been exploited for electoral and military purposes.

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- **Balance of Power:** Since Ukraine's independence from the Soviet Union, both Russia and the West have sought greater influence in the country in order to maintain the regional balance of power in their favour.
- **Ukraine wants to join NATO:** Ukraine wants to join the Association Agreement (AA) with the European Union (EU) and also NATO. While Russia considers NATO'S expansion as a major threat in its neighbourhood.

INDIA'S STAND

- **Followed strategic autonomy:** Followed strategic autonomy without being aligned with Western countries even under pressure.
- **India abstained from the resolution targeting Russia:** Refused to support a resolution targeting Russia and instead provided humanitarian aid to Ukraine. India was also among the first to announce the reopening of its embassy in Kyiv.

WAY FORWARD

- Protect Multilateralism/Multipolarity at UN and other forums such as BRICS, SCO etc. for more rules-based international order.
 - Both can work on global platforms to avoid the new cold war between the US and China with the help of like-minded countries.
- Diversification of Trade to overcome the issues of limited economic relationship with high trade deficit.
- Increasing private sector participation in the economic relationship with removal of barriers to trade and investment
- **Arctic Politics:** India can work with countries like Japan and South Korea in the Far East region of Russia and contain Chinese influence in Arctic politics which Russia also desires.
- **Connectivity:** Operationalising Eastern Maritime Corridor - The proposed sea route that connects Chennai and Vladivostok (Russia's Far East) will improve logistical connectivity.
- **Mediator to reduce US-Russia tensions:** India can leverage its warm relations with both the US and Russia to help ensure "Cold Peace" between the 2 countries. India can also help in establishing detente on critical issues like Iran's nuclear crisis, Indo-Pacific geopolitics, the Ukrainian fiasco or the Afghan impasse.

CONCLUSION

Russia maintains its position as one of the world's great powers, with abundant natural resources and a history of scientific and technological dominance. To moderate Russia's tilt toward China, India should prioritize steps to improve the economic partnership and develop a clear future plan of action. Russia would benefit from keeping Indian concerns in mind as well, in order to avoid jeopardizing a long-standing partnership with an emerging power.

Keywords: Deep mutual trust, S-400 defence system, Eastern Economic Forum, Pivot to Asia, Comprehensive Convention on International Terrorism, CAATSA Act, strategic autonomy, Eastern Maritime Corridor, Cold Peace.

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INDIA-CHINA

INTRODUCTION

China is India's largest neighbour and is a major trade partner, supplier of critical ingredients in strategic industries, and a partner in climate change. However, it is also a formidable competitor to India's global aspirations.

VIEWS AND OPINIONS

- *"India Conquered and dominated China culturally for 20 centuries without ever having to send a single soldier across her border."* - **Hu Shih**
- *India-China relations are a journey from 'Inch towards Miles'. INCH is 'India-China', while MILES is 'Millennium of Exceptional Synergy'.* - **PM Modi**

INDIA-CHINA TIES: COOPERATION AND CHALLENGES

COOPERATION

- **Political:** On 1 April, 1950, India became the first non-socialist bloc country to establish diplomatic relations with the People's Republic of China.
- **Economic Ties:** Bilateral trade has grown significantly, reaching US\$**136.26** by 2022, with India becoming a large market for project exports from China.
 - In 2022, India's the **trade deficit came at \$101.28 billion**, in China's favour, as India's imports from China witnessed an increase by 118.77% to reach \$118.77 billion.
 - Meanwhile, **India's exports to China decreased by 37.59% year on year to reach \$17.49 billion.**
- **Cultural:** India and China have a history of cultural exchanges and have established institutions like the Yoga College in China.
- **Multilateral cooperation:** India and China continue high-level engagement at regional fora such as the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) and BRICS groupings reflecting common agenda for growth and development.
- **Informal Summits:** Both countries have jointly advocated the Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence.
 - Both countries have initiated the "hometown diplomacy", held two informal summits in Wuhan and Chennai respectively.
- **Financial Mechanisms:** India and China are prominent stakeholders in AIIB and NDB
- **Cooperation in fighting terrorism:** As both countries face threats from extremist outfits. SCO, RATS is a prime example.

CHALLENGES

- **Five Finger Policy:** Both countries share around 3,488 km-long Line of Actual Control (LAC) that runs along the Himalayan region, much of it poorly demarcated.
 - China considers Tibet to be the right hand's palm of China with Ladakh, Nepal, Sikkim, Bhutan and NEFA (Arunachal Pradesh) as its five fingers.
 - An estimated 50,000-60,000 troops have been posted on either side of the India-China border in eastern Ladakh.
- **Salami Slicing Strategy:** Sino-Indian border skirmishes are a part of China's larger "Salami Slicing Strategy", wherein China is undertaking small geopolitically unlawful steps to achieve a larger gain which would have been otherwise impossible to carry out all at once.
 - China has been consistently building infrastructure in border areas including roads, bridges and model villages etc. For instance, China has constructed around 628 well-off villages along India's borders in the Tibet Autonomous Region.
- **Belt and Road Initiative (BRI):** India opposes China's BRI, as it violates India's sovereignty and territorial integrity, as the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor passes through parts of the Pakistan occupied Indian state of Jammu & Kashmir.
- **Aggressive Policies in the Neighbourhood:** Building ports and naval facilities under String of Pearls would encircle India which would allow China to influence and control key maritime routes in the Indian Ocean.

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- String of Pearls is a geopolitical and geostrategic initiative which includes a network of Chinese military and commercial facilities which extend from the Chinese mainland to Port Sudan in the Horn of Africa. Ex-Hambantota port.
- **Debt Trap Diplomacy:** China's "Debt Trap Diplomacy" influences India's relations with other countries like Maldives, Sri Lanka, Myanmar and Nepal, thereby hindering India's neighbourhood first policy.
 - Recent change in Maldives' stance towards India, setting a deadline for withdrawal of Indian troops from Maldives, is a consequence of its growing proximity to China.
- **India's Import Dependency:** India has a trade deficit of USD 83.2 billion with China in 2022-23.
 - Further, India's dependency on Key Starting Materials (KSM) from China exceeds 50% for its Pharmaceutical industry.
- **South China Sea and India:** China claims sovereignty over part of the SCS, via the 9 dash line and its illegal creation/militarisation of artificial islands in the SCS.
 - China's "Nine-Dash Line" refers to a demarcation line used by the People's Republic of China to assert its territorial claims in the South China Sea.
 - China recently voiced objection to Vietnam's invitation for India to invest in the oil and natural gas sector in the contested SCS.

INDIA-CHINA BORDER DISPUTES

- Context: China has lodged a diplomatic protest with India over the Prime Minister's (PM's) visit to Arunachal Pradesh, where he dedicated the newly-built Sela Tunnel to the nation.
- **Inauguration of Sela Tunnel:** The PM inaugurated the Sela tunnel, constructed at an altitude of 13,000 ft in Arunachal Pradesh.
- **Chinese Objections:** China claims Arunachal Pradesh as South Tibet routinely objects to Indian leaders' visits to the state to highlight its claims. China has also named the area as Zangnan.
- **Rejection of Chinese Territorial Claims:** India has repeatedly rejected China's territorial claims over Arunachal Pradesh, asserting that the state is an integral part of the country.

Background of India- China Border Disputes:

- **Proposal for MacMohan Line (1913-14):**
 - Simla Conference aimed to establish a boundary between British India and Tibet.
 - McMahon Line was proposed, which was an 890-km boundary extending from Bhutan to Burma but was not accepted by China.
- **Annexation of Tibet (1950):** China's annexation of Tibet created one of the longest undemarcated borders of the world.
- **Introduction of Line of Actual Control (LAC) (1959):** China proposed LAC as a boundary between the two nations. India rejected this proposal.
- **Sino-Indian War (1962):** on November 21, 1962, China declared a ceasefire in its war with India, with China seizing territory in Aksai Chin.
- **Ceasefire and Aftermath:** China declared a ceasefire, withdrawing from most invaded areas but retaining control over Aksai Chin.
- **Establishment of LAC:** The LAC became an informal ceasefire line, but disputes persisted as both countries interpreted it differently.
- **Ongoing Disputes:** The McMahon Line is India's interpretation of the LAC while China claims Aksai Chin and Arunachal Pradesh, which it refers to as 'South Tibet', as its territory.

POSSIBLE FACTORS FOR CHINESE AGGRESSION IN RECENT PAST (GALWAN VALLEY AND DOKLAM)

- **India's border infrastructure:**
 - **Border infrastructure along LAC:** The Darbuk-Shyok-Daulat Beg Oldi road strengthening may have enraged the Chinese.
- **Change in the status of J&K:**
 - **Removal of article 370:** India's status change of Jammu and Kashmir and Ladakh may have prompted China's move.
- **Bilateral tensions:**
 - **BRI and CPEC concerns:** China views India's Gilgit-Baltistan claims as a threat to the CPEC.

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- **China's internal dynamics:**
 - **Internal pressures due to COVID-19 pandemic:** The Chinese leadership may have planned aggression (The LAC and South China Sea) to deflect attention from domestic issues.
- **India's alignment with the U.S.:**
 - Geopolitical convergence between the U.S. and India in the Indo-Pacific is also directed against China.
 - **India's membership of QUAD:** India is a member of the Quad (the U.S., Japan, Australia and India) which has a definite anti-China connotation.

Border agreements:

- 1993 Border Peace and Tranquility Agreement.
- 1996 Agreement on Military Confidence-Building Measures Along the LAC.
- Modalities for Implementing Confidence-Building Measures in the Military Field Along the LAC, 2005.
- Agreement in 2012 to Establish a Working Mechanism for Consultation and Coordination on India-China Border Affairs.
- 2013 Border Defense Cooperation Agreement.

WAY FORWARD

- **Military preparation:** India must build roads and improve infrastructure along the border and strengthen the Andaman and Nicobar Command, which guards Asia's maritime strategic lifeline and the world's most important sea lane.
- **Pressure points:** China's sensitivity to the one-China policy and other weaknesses could be used by India to change its approach.
- **India must look beyond the LAC to fight China.** India's best option is the South China Sea/Indian Ocean Region, where it can affect East Asia's maritime balance.
- **Building alliances:** To counter China's growing influence, India must form power-balancing agreements with other nations.
- **Aligning with the US:** To confront China, build regional ties, and rebalance the Indo-Pacific region, India should align with the US as a primary strategic partner.

INDIA-CHINA WATER RELATIONS

- China plans on building a super dam in Medog County (near Arunachal Pradesh) on a tributary of Brahmaputra called Yarlung Zangbo. It originates in the Tibetan Plateau.
- Yarlung Zangbo flows into Arunachal Pradesh (as Siang) and Assam (as Brahmaputra) before entering Bangladesh (as Jamuna).
- India and China have no institutional agreement on water sharing.

Hydrological Status:

- **Five major rivers** flowing through India find their origins in China.
 - **Brahmaputra River System:** Siang (Brahmaputra), Lohit and Subansiri
 - **Indus River System:** Indus and Satluj
- **China is the upper riparian controller on 7 of South Asia's largest rivers:** Including the Indus, Ganga, Brahmaputra, Irrawaddy, Salween, Yangtze and Mekong.

Concerns:

- **China's capability to weaponise the upper riparian status:** China has the capability to weaponise the upper riparian status, limiting India's ability to plan hydro-power projects downstream.
- Alteration of water levels in ecologically sensitive regions eg. Kaziranga National Park.
- The dam is located in the seismically sensitive Himalayan region which may pose a hazard of dam bursts.

Way Forward

- **Finalizing a water cooperation agreement:** A water cooperation agreement between the two nations is needed to address data sharing, dam building, and minimum water flow.
- **IWT as a guide:** The renowned Indus Water Treaty should serve as a valuable guide to water cooperation between two rival nations.
- **Politicization of water issues must be avoided:** Politicization of water must be avoided at any cost.

CHINA'S RISING INFLUENCE IN SOUTH ASIA

Once considered the strategic backyard of India, South Asia has recently been a theatre of rising Chinese influence.

- **Pakistan:**
 - China-Pakistan relationship is considered to be an **all-weather alliance**.

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- China has heavily invested in Pakistan via the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC)
- China also has a substantial stake in the strategic **Gwadar port**.
- China provides **diplomatic support to Pakistan** in the UN and FATF.
- **Bangladesh:**
 - China is the largest source of defence imports for Bangladesh.
 - China is also its largest trade partner. It also grants Bangladesh duty-free access to over 97% of traded goods.
 - It is financing 25 energy projects along with Bangladesh's second Nuclear Power plant.
 - China has also extended technical support for Bangabandhu-1, Bangladesh's 1st communication satellite.
- **Sri Lanka:**
 - Sri Lanka forms a major leg of the maritime component of BRI. Hambantota Port is one of the biggest projects under BRI.
 - Due to debt-trap diplomacy, China has also gained control of strategic assets such as the Hambantota Port. China is one of the largest creditors of Sri Lanka.
 - China has provided crucial diplomatic support to Sri Lanka in the UN Human Rights Commission after the Civil War between LTTE and the Sri Lankan Government.
- **Nepal:**
 - Nepal is the host for the Himalayan leg of the BRI in three corridors – Kosi, Gandak and Karnali.
 - China has granted access to 7 land ports to Nepal for it to escape its excessive dependence on India for connectivity to the outside world.
 - Major investments in projects such as Pokhara airport, Kathmandu-Lumbini rail link, and Lhasa Shigatse Rail Link.
 - China is second largest trade partner and largest source of FDI.
- **Maldives:**
 - China owns over 70% of Maldives's debt and has heavily invested in infrastructure such as Male Airport and Sinamale Bridge.
 - A Chinese company has received a 50-year lease to the Feydhoo Finolhu Island.
 - With the return of the civilian democratic government to the Maldives, many grand infrastructure projects have been stalled or cancelled due to concerns over Debt-trap and unviability of the projects.

SOUTH CHINA SEA DISPUTE

Context: The External Affairs Minister (EAM) of India is on an official visit to the Philippines in the background of heightened tensions between the Philippines and Chinese naval forces in the South China Sea (SCS). Both countries claim ownership of the shoal.

ABOUT SOUTH CHINA SEA DISPUTE

- The dispute involves island and maritime claims of several sovereign states of the region who contest China's claim over such territory.

Importance of the South China Sea:

- **Strategic Location:** It is strategically located at the crossroads of major maritime trade routes, connecting the Pacific Ocean to the Indian Ocean.
- **Global Shipping Lane:** More than \$3 trillion in trade passing through its waters annually.
 - 80% of global trade by volume and 70% by value is transported by sea. Of the total volume, 60% passes through Asia, with the SCS carrying an estimated one-third of global shipping.
- **Natural Resources:**
 - **Fishing Ground:** More than half of the world's fishing vessels are in the SCS, and millions of people depend on these waters for their food and livelihoods.
 - **Energy Reserves:** It has proved oil and gas reserves.

Significance of SCS for India:

- **Economic Significance:**
 - **Global Trade:** 55% of India's trade with the Indo-Pacific region passes through the waters of SCS.

ABOUT SOUTH-CHINA SEA

LOCATION
Marginal sea of the Western Pacific Ocean, partially enclosed by land.

CONNECTIVITY
Connected to the East China Sea via the Taiwan Strait and to the Philippine Sea via the Luzon Strait.

BORDERING STATES & TERRITORIES
People's Republic of China, Taiwan, Philippines, Malaysia, Brunei, Indonesia, Singapore, Vietnam.

ADDITIONAL GULFS
Gulf of Thailand and Gulf of Tonkin are part of the South China Sea.

TOPOGRAPHY

- Islands generally not arable, lacking permanent crops or forests.
- Surrounding waters rich in oil, natural gas, minerals, and seafood.

FEATURES

Paracels: Islands and reefs.

Spratlys: Mostly reefs and rocks, some submerged at high tide.

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- **Energy Resources:** India seeks to explore the vast reserves of oil and natural gas.
- **Security Significance:**
 - **Strategic Waterway:** The SCS is a strategic waterway that connects the Indian Ocean to the Pacific Ocean.
 - **Countering China's Expansionism:** India seeks to balance it by strengthening its own maritime capabilities and deepening its ties with regional partners.

CONCERNS WITH CHINA'S EXPANSION/CHALLENGES IN THE SOUTH CHINA SEA REGION

- **Fishing Ban:** It has been arbitrarily imposed by China since 1999 under the pretext of promoting sustainable fishing and improving marine ecology.
- **Legal Actions:** Article 22 of the Coast Guard Law enable the China Coast Guard (CCG) to use weapons against foreign organizations and individuals that infringe on China's sovereign rights and jurisdiction at sea.
- **Proxy Warfare:** Actions conducted by Chinese maritime militia with support from the CCG aimed at swarming, ramming foreign vessels, and blocking their access to disputed areas.
- **Raising Questions on Maritime Diplomacy:** The publication of China's '10-dash line' map has raised questions about China's adherence to international law and diplomacy.
- **Managing China-US military and Paramilitary Competition:** With China's expansion in the region, US military involvement in the area has largely increased leading to the militarisation of the region.
 - The US has expanded the scale of military exercises with allies in Southeast Asia, and increased the frequency and intensity of its 'freedom of navigation operations' (FONOPs).

Way Forward:

- **Diplomacy and Engagement:** Multilateral Negotiations: Encourage all parties involved in the dispute to engage in peaceful, open, and multilateral negotiations to find mutually acceptable solutions and fostering understanding among the nations.
- **Code of Conduct (COC):** Actively promote the finalization and adherence to a robust and legally binding Code of Conduct for the SCS.
- **Conflict Prevention and Management:**
 - **Confidence-Building Measures:** Establishing hotlines between military and government officials to facilitate immediate communication in case of maritime incidents.
 - **Maritime Cooperation:** Encourage joint efforts in areas such as marine scientific research, environmental protection, and fisheries management to foster cooperation and mutual benefit.
- **International Arbitration and Legal Mechanisms:** Uphold and respect international rulings, such as the Permanent Court of Arbitration's ruling in the Philippines vs. China case, as a basis for resolving disputes peacefully.
- **Promotion of Common Interests:** Encourage joint initiatives for sustainable development, disaster management, and protection of marine resources, highlighting the benefits of cooperation.

Disputed claims in the South China Sea

Claims

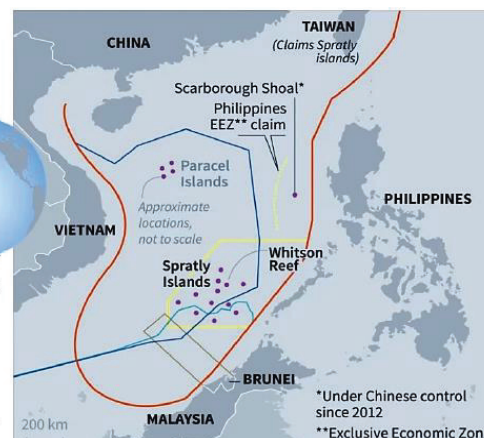
- China
- Philippines
- Malaysia
- Brunei
- Vietnam



Area: South China Sea covers more than 3 million sq km

Trade: Over \$5 trillion in ship-borne trade passes through the sea annually

Oil and gas: Major unexploited oil and gas deposits are believed to lie under the seabed



BRI PROJECT

Recently, the third Belt and Road (BRI) Forum for International Cooperation was convened in Beijing, China.

About Belt and Road Initiative:

- The BRI was launched by Chinese President Xi Jinping in 2013.
- **Objective:** To connect Asia with Europe and Africa, through a network of railways, highways, ports, airports, and other infrastructure projects with the intent to promote trade, investment, and economic growth in participating countries.

CONCERNS OF CHINA'S BELT AND ROAD INITIATIVE (BRI)

- **Debt Trap Diplomacy:** Nations have borrowed heavily from China for BRI projects, and they now face challenges in repaying these loans. This has led to accusations of "debt trap diplomacy," where countries risk losing control of strategic assets if they default on their loans. For example, due to mounting debt, Sri Lanka had to hand over control of the Hambantota port to China.

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- **Risks involved with major infrastructure projects:** Potential environmental, social, and corruption risks are associated with any large infrastructure project.
 - **For Example:** In 2016, China was involved in 240 coal projects in BRI countries, responsible for greenhouse gas emissions.
- **Macro risks:** For some countries, the financing required for BRI projects may expand debt to unsustainable levels.
 - For instance, the construction of the Lao PDR section of the Kunming -Singapore Railway has an estimated cost of US\$ 6 billion – nearly 40 percent of the GDP of Laos in 2016.
- **Slow Pace of Projects:** In Pakistan, BRI projects worth around \$19 billion are either completed or underway but that has not impeded structural economic reforms.
 - As a result, Pakistan's economy is on the brink of a default with high amounts of debt, an ever-growing current account deficit, and very low foreign exchange reserves.
- **Slowdown of the Chinese Economy:** The recent slowing down of the Chinese economy presents another key challenge to the BRI.
 - The Chinese economy grew 5.5% in the first half of 2023, above the official 5% target but below its historical rate. It is also facing deflation and rising youth unemployment.
- **Governance Issue:** In contrast to initiatives such as the Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank (AIIB), the Belt and Road Initiative (BRI) does not possess a centralized governing framework, complicating the collective resolution of issues.

India's Stand:

- India strongly opposes China's Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), particularly the China-Pakistan Economic Corridor (CPEC), because it passes through Pakistan-occupied Kashmir (PoK).
- CPEC (China-Pakistan Economic Corridor) which connects Gwadar Port in Pakistan's Baluchistan with China's Xinjiang province is the flagship project of BRI.
- India's main concern is that this project disregards its sovereignty and

Keywords: Panchsheel (Five Principles of Peaceful Coexistence), Shanghai Cooperation Organisation, Five Finger Policy, Salami Slicing Strategy, Debt Trap Diplomacy, Key Starting Materials, Nine-Dash Line, MacMohan Line, China-Pakistan Economic Corridor, Maritime Diplomacy, freedom of navigation operations, Asian Infrastructure Investment Bank.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	"The USA is facing an existential threat in the form of China, that is much more challenging than the erstwhile Soviet Union." Explain.	2021
2.	The newly tri-nation partnership AUKUS is aimed at countering China's ambitions in the Indo-Pacific region. Is it going to supersede the existing partnerships in the region? Discuss the strength and impact of AUKUS in the present scenario	2021
3.	China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia', In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbor	2017
4.	With respect to the South China Sea, maritime territorial disputes and rising tension affirm the need for safeguarding maritime security to ensure freedom of navigation and overflight throughout the region. In this context, discuss the bilateral issues between India and China.	2014
5.	'China is using its economic relations and positive trade surplus as tools to develop potential military power status in Asia', In the light of this statement, discuss its impact on India as her neighbour.	2013

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INDIA - EU

INTRODUCTION

- Relations between India and the European Union extend back to the early 1960s, with India being one of the first countries to establish diplomatic relations with the European Economic Community. The complementariness shared by India and the EU include a pluralistic society, a market economy, and political democracy.

AREAS OF COOPERATION BETWEEN INDIA AND EUROPE

- Geostrategic:**
 - Both are competitors of China:**
 - Connectivity programme of EU:** European Union has unveiled its connectivity program, known as the **Golden Gateway**, to counter the Chinese Belt Road Initiative.
 - On Indo-Pacific:** The European Union has published its Indo-Pacific policy, which places India at the centre.
- Economic cooperation:**
 - Trade:** India is the EU's 10th largest trading partner, accounting for 2.1% of EU total trade in goods. Trade in services between the EU and India reached €30.4 billion in 2020.
 - launch of **Enhanced Trade Partnership (ETP)** negotiations at **11th Economic and Financial Dialogue (EFD)**: Held in New Delhi in January 2022
 - FDI:** The EU's share in foreign investment stock in India reached €87.3 billion in 2020, up from €63.7 billion in 2017, making the EU a leading foreign investor in India.
 - India and EU launch joint trade and technology council:** India and the European Union finally decided to launch a joint Trade and technology council.
- Developmental partnership:**
 - Sustainable Development:** India and the EU are working together to achieve the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) such as smart cities, clean water and sanitation, and climate action.
 - Health:** The India-UK Partnership on Vaccines, Therapeutics and Diagnostics to ensure equitable global supply.
 - People to people:** Both sides have signed Joint Declaration on Common Agenda on Migration and Mobility (CAMP).
 - Climate change:** The two have become key stakeholders in global efforts to combat climate change through the framework of the Clean Energy and Climate Change Partnership, 2017.
 - EU Welcomed the launch of a global Green Grids Initiative at COP26 and committed to assist India to achieve its goal of One Sun, One World, One Grid.
- Science and Technology cooperation:**
 - India-UK Global Innovation Partnership (GIP)** has been finalised, with India and UK co-financing up to USD 100 million over 14 years.
 - Horizon 2020:** Both have initiated joint research projects- '**Horizon 2020**' related to climate change and polar research.
- Defence and Security cooperation:**
 - launch of Open general export license** to facilitate technology engagement of EU with India.
 - The new Information Fusion Centre:** The Indian Ocean Region in New Delhi (IFC - IOR) has recently joined forces with the EU NAVFOR Atalanta's Maritime Security Centre - Horn of Africa (MSC - HOA).
 - Combating terrorism:** India and the EU adopted a declaration to counter terrorism at the 14th India-EU summit.
 - Counter-piracy operations:** Both sides conducted the maiden Indian Navy and European Union Naval Force (EUNAVFOR) exercise in the Gulf of Aden in **June 2021**.

ISSUES IN INDIA EU RELATION

- Trade:** Currently India accounts for only 1.9% of EU total trade in goods in 2019, well behind China (13.8%).
- India's bilateral relations with EU member states developed, but not intensified:** While India's bilateral relations with EU member states like Germany, France and the UK developed substantially, it did not lead to the expected intensification of ties with the grouping.

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- **EU on CAA and article 370:** The European Parliament was critical of both the Indian government's decision to scrap Jammu and Kashmir's special status in 2019 and the Citizenship (Amendment) Act.
- **Protectionism:** The EU is critical of India's "protectionist" measures on tariffs and the termination of bilateral investment treaties with EU member states.
- **Rise of anti-migration and ultra-nationalist sentiment in Europe:** The refugee crisis and rise in trade protectionism and resentment against globalization have strengthened anti-EU sentiments as manifested in Brexit.

BROAD- BASED TRADE AND INVESTMENT AGREEMENT (BTIA)

- **It is the proposed FTA between India and the EU: Negotiation** began in 2007, with 15 rounds of negotiations held at Brussels and New Delhi.

ROADBLOCKS IN NEGOTIATIONS

Trade in goods:

- The EU has demanded the lowering of tariffs on wines, spirits, dairy and automobiles, but India has raised concerns that this could lead to European imports flooding the market.
- India has also demanded the lowering of non-tariff barriers in the sanitary and phyto-sanitary sectors and technical barriers imposed by the EU.
- **IPR:** The EU expects India to strengthen its IPR regime, which may have a critical impact on India's vast pharmaceutical and generic drug sector.
- The EU's demand of 'data exclusivity' was rejected by India.

Data-secure country:

- **Data secure country status:** EU has not given data secure country status to India. Without this, the flow of sensitive data can be hindered, increasing operating costs for Indian businesses in the EU.

Services sector:

- **Greater access to market:** While India has demanded greater access to the European market under Modes 1 and 4, the EU has demanded increased access to the Indian economy under Mode 3.
- **Investor-State Dispute Settlement mechanism:** EU wants detailed provisions while India is reluctant to accept this provision.

WAY FORWARD

- **Negotiations from both sides:** Must look beyond the multiple differences to focus on the complementarities.
- **Greater cooperation in areas like green technology and artificial intelligence:** India and the EU could start by negotiating on green technology and artificial intelligence, which might result in a more balanced outcome in the discussions.
- **Cooperate in healthcare:** India's pharmaceutical manufacturing capabilities coupled with access to European healthcare technologies can provide new avenues for enhancing partnerships and promoting innovation between the partners

EU- Connectivity Program:

- **Golden Gateway Program to counter the Chinese Belt Road Initiative:** IT is €300 billion (\$340 billion) Project.
- It is an offshoot of the Build Back Better World (B3W) Initiative, which was announced by the Group of Seven (G-7) richest democracies in June 2021.
- The program aims to create strong and sustainable links between Europe and the world and build a new future.

TRADE AND ECONOMIC PARTNERSHIP AGREEMENT (TEPA) BETWEEN INDIA & EUROPEAN FREE TRADE ASSOCIATION

Recently, India and the four-nation European Free Trade Association (EFTA), an intergovernmental grouping of Iceland, Liechtenstein, Norway and Switzerland, signed a Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement (TEPA).

- TEPA is the fourth major deal signed by India to promote trade and economic cooperation in the last three years. The others are with Australia, Mauritius and the UAE.

CRUCIAL INSIGHTS OF THE TRADE AND ECONOMIC PARTNERSHIP AGREEMENT (TEPA)

- **Aim:** The TEPA enhances market access and simplifies customs procedures. It also aims to facilitate and promote investment opportunities between the countries.
- **Covered Aspects:** The deal covers various aspects such as trade in goods, rules of origin, intellectual property rights, services, investment promotion, government procurement, technical trade barriers, and trade facilitation.

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- **Investment Fund:** It would primarily come from provident funds in EFTA countries.
- **First Free Trade Agreement (FTA):** For the first time, India is signing the FTA with four developed nations - an important economic bloc in Europe.
- **No to Data Exclusivity:** India earlier rejected the four nations' demand for the pact to include provisions on "data exclusivity" that would make it difficult for its drug companies to produce generic variants of the off-patent drugs.
- **Excludes Provisions:** India and the EFTA also agreed to largely keep "sensitive" farm products and gold imports out of the pact.

SIGNIFICANCE OF TEPA FOR INDIA

- **Boost to Export:** India expects that the pact will boost exports of pharmaceuticals, garments, chemicals and machinery.
- **To Attract Investment:** India expects that the pact will help in attracting investments in automobiles, food processing, railways and the financial sector.
- **To Diversify Import Sources:** India is looking at the EFTA deal to help diversify imports away from China. India currently depends on China for key medical imports.
 - EFTA is also looking at striking joint ventures in pharma, (especially medical devices), chemicals, food processing and engineering.
- **Support in UNSC:** The deal will play a significant role by supporting India's permanent membership of UNSC.
 - The EFTA countries recognise India's growth as a world leader.
- **Achievement of Green Energy Target:** EFTA countries can help India to meet its green growth aspirations of 50% renewable energy by 2030, with their cutting-edge technologies.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA-EFTA RELATIONS

- **Data Exclusivity:** Data exclusivity safeguards would promote monopolization for foreign pharmaceutical companies and would be a setback for the Indian generic industry.
- **Differences in Economic Structures:** EFTA countries focus on high-tech industries, while India's industries generally serve lower and middle-tech sectors and bridging the differences in the economic interests would be a formidable challenge.
- **Intellectual Property Rights Protection:** There is a challenge of IPR protection of the EFTA companies engaged in pharmaceuticals, biotechnology, and machinery manufacturing.
- **Challenges for Market Access:** Issues regarding tariffs, quotas, and non-tariff barriers impact free market access between the two parties.
- **Concerning Trade Deficit:** India has a significant trade deficit with EFTA countries, especially driven by imports of gold and precious metals, raising concerns about the imbalance in trade relations.
- **Limited Tariff Benefits:** Existing zero or low tariffs in EFTA countries limit the potential gains for Indian goods exports, particularly in industrial and agricultural sectors.

WAY FORWARD

- **Addressal to Data Exclusivity Issue:** The high-level delegates should work towards resolving outstanding issues such as data exclusivity to smooth future ties.
- **Secure Domestic Manufacturers:** India needs to secure its important domestic sectors, such as pharmaceuticals and machinery manufacturing, where EFTA countries have a competitive edge.
- **Environmental and Social Considerations:** There is a need to include and address more contemporary challenges like promoting sustainable development and gender equality.
- **A Favouring Investment Commitment:** With this deal, India could see higher imports of machinery, pharmaceuticals, medical instruments and machinery as there would be a sharp reduction in Indian tariffs.

Keywords: Golden Gateway, Enhanced Trade Partnership (ETP), trade and technology council, Common Agenda on Migration and Mobility, Clean Energy and Climate Change Partnership, Green Grids Initiative, India-UK Global Innovation Partnership, Horizon 2020, data exclusivity, Investor-State Dispute Settlement mechanism, Trade and Economic Partnership Agreement.

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INDIA - JAPAN

INTRODUCTION

India-Japan relations have traditionally been strong due to cultural exchanges and the same ideals of democracy. India is the largest recipient of Japanese aid and is a big market for Japanese firms. Japan was one of the first country to invest in India.

BACKGROUND

- **Diplomatic ties established in 1952:** The diplomatic ties between India and Japan were established in 1952 with the signing of the Peace Treaty post World War II.
- **Comprehensive Economic Partnership:** In 2011, a Comprehensive Economic Partnership was concluded.
- **Country Assistance Policy of Japan:** In 2016, Japan announced its Country Assistance Policy, Visa on Arrival, Logistics Agreement, and Collaboration in Initiatives.
- **Supply Chain Resilience Initiative (SCRI) to counter China's dominance:** In 2021, India, Japan, and Australia launched the Supply Chain Resilience Initiative (SCRI) to counter China's dominance of the supply chain in the Indo-Pacific region.

AREAS OF COOPERATION

INDO-PACIFIC

- **Geopolitical interests in the Indo-Pacific region:** India and Japan act as an anchor of the Indo-Pacific region, building on past agreements to address China's concerns.
- **Maintaining Rule base order:** The two countries' vision for the Indo-Pacific is based on a rules-based order that respects sovereignty and territorial integrity.
 - **QUAD Grouping:** To provide strategic security architecture by USA, INDIA, JAPAN, and AUSTRALIA in the Indo pacific.
 - **Supply chain resilience initiative:** It will ensure free and equitable economic order in the Indo-Pacific region.
- **Japan's Free and Open Indo-Pacific:** It is a concept given by Japanese PM's during their India Visit.

DEVELOPEMENT

- **The Asia-Africa Growth Corridor (AAGC):** The AAGC is a joint collaboration between India and Japan to develop infrastructure in the Asia-Africa region, with priority given to health, agriculture, disaster management and skill enhancement.
- **Blue Dot Network:** The BDN is a multi-stakeholder program founded by the United States, Japan, and Australia to examine and certify infrastructure development projects worldwide.

PARTNERSHIP AT MULTILATERAL FORUMS

- **United Nations Security Council:** Both countries have resolved to work towards early reform of the United Nations, including both permanent and non-permanent categories.
 - India and Japan are working together to expand the UN security council through G4 GROUP.
- **Quad Grouping:**
 - **India-Japan at QUAD grouping:** India, Australia, Japan, and the US, has established the basis for regular defense cooperation, intelligence-sharing, and logistics support to maintain rule-based order in the Indo-Pacific.
- **G-20 Grouping:**
 - **Collaboration between India's G20 Presidency and Japan's G7 Presidency** provides an opportunity for both countries to shape the world's destiny toward "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam," or "**One Earth, One Family, One Future.**"
 - **Bilateral cooperation on circular economy:** G7/G20 collaboration, LiFE, Marine & Plastic Waste, COP-27 and CBD 15. India acknowledged Japan's efforts in bringing new technologies to India and stressed that India and Japan may explore strengthening bilateral cooperation on circular economy.

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ECONOMIC

- Japan's bilateral trade with India totaled US\$ 21.96 billion during FY 2022-23.
- **India-Japan Comprehensive Economic Partnership (CEPA):** It came into effect in August 2011.
 - It is the most comprehensive and covers trade in goods and services, movement of natural persons, investments, intellectual property rights, customs procedures and other trade-related issues.
 - **India's Primary Exports to Japan:** Petroleum products, organic chemicals; fish and crustaceans, molluscs and other aquatic invertebrates; nuclear reactors, boilers, machinery and mechanical appliances, etc.
 - **India's Primary Imports from Japan:** Machinery, electrical machinery, iron and steel products, plastic materials, non-ferrous metals, parts of motor vehicles etc.
- **Bilateral Swap Arrangement:** Both countries have agreed to a Bilateral Swap Arrangement that would allow their central banks to exchange local currencies for up to \$75 billion.
- Japanese Investment and Official Development Assistance (ODA):
 - **Japanese FDI into India:** It has mainly been in automobile, electrical equipment, telecommunications, chemical, financial (insurance) and pharmaceutical sectors.
 - Japan is fifth among source countries for FDI after Mauritius, Singapore, the US and Netherlands.
- **People-People Ties:** In recent years, there has been a change
- **Development Aid:** Japan gives India 225 bn Yen loan to fund metro expansion, water supply, and crop diversification projects.

DEFENCE

- **Security Cooperation:** India and Japan signed a joint declaration on security cooperation signed in 2008. 'It proposed the establishment of meetings between defence ministers, military-to-military talks, and navy-to-navy.'
- **Technical cooperation:** Both sides worked to build military-technical cooperation (MTC) that increases mutual dependence.
- **Modernising Indian Arm force:** Japan hopes to assist India in modernising military capabilities via its US-2 amphibian aircraft and Soryu submarines.
- Recently with Eye on China: India, Japan signed mutual military logistics pact
 - The agreement establishes a framework for closer cooperation between the Armed Forces of India and Japan in mutually agreed activities.
 - It allow their militaries to access each other's bases for logistics support.
 - It allow the militaries of the two countries to use each other's bases and facilities for repair and replenishment of supplies.
- **Joint military drills:** Exercise Dharma Guardian brought Indian Army and the Japanese Ground Self-Defence Forces (JGSDF) together in 2018.
 - Air forces of both countries engage in Exercise Shinyuu Maitri while coasting guards through Exercise Sahyog-Kaijin.
 - Japan also participated in Malabar naval exercises.

BILATERAL PARTNERSHIP

- **In Post-cold wartime:** In the Cold War time, both countries kept their distance from each other. Reasons were India's distancing from the Japan-US alliance, Policy of non-alignment.
- **After the collapse of the Soviet Union:** Soviet Union's collapse and a severe balance-of-payments crisis, Indian leadership favoured closer ties with Japan.
- **New Policy Initiative:** In 1993 India announced the 'Look East Policy'. India's 'special strategic and global partnership' with Japan is a grand strategy in the post-Cold War era.
 - The 'Act East Policy,' unveiled in November 2014, is an improvement on the previous "Look East Policy."
 - It is a diplomatic initiative to enhance economic, geopolitical, and cultural contacts with the broad Asia-Pacific area at many levels, which adds fuel to the development of improved relationships with Japan.
- **Elevation of ties:** In 2014 both elevated ties to a 'special strategic and global partnership,'
- **2+2 Arrangement:** In 2016, India started a '2 + 2' arrangement for foreign and defence ministries. This was elevated to the ministerial level three years later, signalling its special status.

CHALLENGES TO THE BILATERAL RELATIONS

- **Trade Difference:** The trade ties have remained underdeveloped compared to India's trade ties with China.

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- Both India and Japan have diverging interests concerning economic issues like E-commerce rules (Osaka track) and Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership.
- India is struggling to penetrate the Japanese market due to language barriers, high quality and service standards.
- **China Factor:** Both countries have border issues with China. So, their policy stance hinges generally on China, rather than growing comprehensively.
 - India has been more vocal in criticizing China's actions, while Japan has been more cautious in its approach.
- **Russia Factor:** There is a difference of opinion between India and Japan on the responses to Russia's invasion of Ukraine. Japan is part of the U.S.'s alliance and has also joined sanctions against Russia, while India has refused to do so.
 - Also, there exists a difference of opinion when India participated in the Vostok Exercises, which were held close to South Kuril Island (a disputed territory between Russia and Japan).
- **Balancing between QUAD and BRICS:** India has not joined the China-led Belt and Road Initiative (BRI), while a member of Quad & AIIB. India has long adopted a non-aligned approach as opposed to the stauncher, pro-US foreign policy stances of Japan and Australia.
 - So India has to do a balancing act between Quad and BRICS.
- **Asia-Africa Growth Corridor (AAGC) Project:** There is a scepticism on the feasibility of the AAGC itself as well as the nature of the projects embedded in it.
- **Defence Exports:** India is looking to export defence equipment to other countries, which could potentially compete with Japan's own defence exports.
 - Negotiations to purchase amphibious US-2 planes have dragged on for years.

THE 14TH INDIA-JAPAN ANNUAL SUMMIT WAS HELD IN NEW DELHI

Recently, the Japanese Prime Minister visited India for the 14th India-Japan Annual Summit between the two Countries.

Outcome:

- **Clean Energy Partnership (CEP):** For cooperation towards achieving sustainable economic growth, addressing climate change and ensuring energy security. This is launched under the umbrella 'India-Japan Energy Dialogue' established in 2007.
- **Sustainable development initiative:** It is a scheme for North East region launched.
- **India-Japan digital partnership:** With a view of engaging in the digital economy and cooperation in IoT, AI etc.
- **Joint Crediting Mechanism (JCM):** It will ensure private capital flow to developing countries as per Article 6 of the Paris Agreement.
- **Investment by Japan:**
 - Japan will invest Rs 3.2 lakh crores in India over the next five years.
 - 7 JICA (Japan International Cooperation Agency) grants for projects in various states involving connection, water supply and sewage, horticulture, healthcare, and wildlife conservation.
 - Japanese firms have inked an agreement to introduce Johkasou technology for decentralized wastewater treatment in India. It is utilized in locations where sewage infrastructure has yet to be built.
- Japan would be joining the Indian-Swedish climate initiative LeadIT to promote heavy industry transition.
- Memorandum of cooperation was signed in the field of cyber security.

WAY FORWARD

- **Enhancement in Regional Strength:** Both India and Japan have economic and military strength that could be used for future regional strength and counter the China factor too.
- **To Combat Pollution:** Pollution is a serious issue, and pollution can be tackled using Japanese green technologies.
 - **Example:** Miyawaki Technique: To create dense forests with native plants.
 - Joint crediting mechanism (JCM)- Under JCM, Japanese companies, using their state-of-the-art environmental technologies, will be able to earn carbon credits in return for helping developing countries reduce greenhouse gas emissions.
- **Address the Trade Bottleneck:** To enhance bilateral trade and realise the full potential of economic cooperation.
 - Joint ventures could be created by merging Japanese digital technology with Indian raw materials and labour.

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- India's purchase of Japan's indigenously made amphibious US-2 planes, if successfully executed, could also contribute to India's 'Make in India'.
- **Increase People-to-People Exchange:** By involving Indian IT professionals in Japan to boost digitalization in Japan.
- **Expand Partnerships in Science and Technology:** Such as 5G, Telecom Network Security, submarine cable systems, and Quantum Communications.
 - Both countries are also engaged in technology in producing submarines and in cooperative research in areas like unmanne Ground Vehicle and Robotics.
- **Collaboration on Strategic Connectivity:** By linking South Asia to Southeast Asia by harnessing the synergy between the "Act East" policy and the "Partnership for Quality Infrastructure".
- In order to realize the full potential of their global partnership for peace and prosperity, the Japan and India decided on the following Eight-fold Initiative in April 2005:

**8 Fold
Initiatives to
strengthen
Indo-Japan
Relations**

- Enhanced Dialogue & Exchange
- Comprehensive Economic Engagement
- Security dialogue & Cooperation
- Science & Tech Initiatives
- Cultural & Academic Initiatives
- Cooperation on International Platforms
- Cooperation in Ushering New-Asia
- Collective Response to International Challenges

CONCLUSION

Overall, India-Japan has undertaken a number of significant efforts, demonstrating both countries' strong desire to improve their security and strategic ties. Over the previous decade, the two countries have developed a strong strategic cooperation.

While China may have been a factor, building this relationship was easier because of the absence of any baggage, unlike, for instance, with the United States. But India and Japan also need to build a larger coalition if they are to balance China effectively in the economic and defence sector.

Keywords: Supply Chain Resilience Initiative, QUAD Grouping, Asia-Africa Growth Corridor, Blue Dot Network, G4 GROUP, Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, **circular economy**, Bilateral Swap Arrangement Official Development Assistance, mutual military logistics pact, special strategic and global partnership, Osaka track, Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership, **Clean Energy Partnership**, Joint crediting mechanism, Miyawaki Technique

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	The time has come for India and Japan to build a strong contemporary relationship, one involving global and strategic partnerships that will have great significance for Asia and the world as a whole.' Comment.	2019
2.	Economic ties between India and Japan while growing in the recent years are still far below their potential. Elucidate the policy constraints which are inhibiting this growth.	2013

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INDIA – SOUTH-EAST ASIA

20TH ASEAN-INDIA SUMMIT

Recently, the Prime Minister attended the 20th ASEAN-India Summit in Jakarta, Indonesia. ASEAN and India celebrated the 30th anniversary last year and the relations between them have elevated to the level of **Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP)**.

HIGHLIGHTS OF 20TH ASEAN-INDIA SUMMIT

- **Theme:** 'ASEAN Matters: Epicentrum of Growth'
- **Alignment with Indo-Pacific Initiatives:** PM highlighted the alignment between India's Indo-Pacific Ocean's Initiative (IPOI) and ASEAN's Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP), showcasing the convergence of regional strategies.
- **AITIGA Review Urged:** PM stressed the importance of expeditiously completing the review of the ASEAN-India Free Trade Agreement (AITIGA), underlining its significance for trade and economic cooperation.

INDIA'S RELATIONSHIP WITH ASEAN

- **Geopolitical Relations:**
 - **Central to Act East Policy:** ASEAN holds a central position in India's Act East Policy. Originally conceived as an economic initiative, this policy has expanded to encompass political, strategic, and cultural dimensions.
 - **ASEAN Plus Six:** India is part of the ASEAN Plus Six grouping, which includes ASEAN member states along with China, Japan, South Korea, New Zealand, and Australia.
- **Geo-economics (Trade and investment):**
 - **Free Trade Agreement:** In 2010, India and ASEAN signed a Free Trade Agreement (FTA) that entered into force.
 - The bilateral trade between them was just US\$ 9 billion when they had the 1st summit way back in 2002, and now the trade is likely to cross the US\$ 150 billion mark in 2023.
 - **Economic Significance:** Collectively, they contribute to 7% of the world's GDP and represent 26% of the global population, highlighting their substantial combined strength.
- **Geostrategic Relations (Maritime and Defence):**
 - **Defence Ties:** The 1st ASEAN-India Maritime Exercise took place in May 2023, marking a significant achievement.
 - India and Singapore signed a bilateral agreement that will allow Indian Navy ships logistical support, including refuelling, at Singapore's Changi naval base located near the disputed South China Sea.
- **Key Developments:**
 - **Maiden Defence Meeting:** India and Cambodia co-chaired the inaugural India-ASEAN Defence Ministers' Meeting in November 2022.
 - **Enhancing Partnership:** The ASEAN Post Ministerial Conference with India in July 2023 resulted in the adoption of the Annex to the Plan of Action for ASEAN-India Partnership (2021-2025), further strengthening ties.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA-ASEAN RELATIONS

- **Strategic Competition:** The strategic competition between the United States and China in the Asia-Pacific region poses a significant challenge for ASEAN.
 - The pressure to choose sides in this rivalry can destabilize the region.
- **Absence of a Custodian or Central Authority:** Unlike the European Union (EU), ASEAN lacks a centralized custodian or authority responsible for overseeing and coordinating the affairs of the 10-nation bloc.
- **Connectivity Issues:** Despite initiatives like the India-Myanmar-Thailand Trilateral Highway and the Kaladan Multimodal Transit Transport Project, connectivity challenges in the region persist. Delays in infrastructure development can hinder trade and cooperation.
- **Territorial Disputes:** Territorial disputes in the South China Sea, involving some ASEAN members and China, can complicate regional security and stability.
 - **For Example:** Malaysia, the Philippines and Vietnam have formally disputed a new Chinese map that claims most of the South China Sea as Chinese territory.

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• Economic Challenges:

- **Regional Comprehensive Economic Partnership (RCEP):** India has not join the RCEP, a mega regional trade agreement involving ASEAN and its FTA partners.
- **Fragmented Markets:** ASEAN is not a single market, posing challenges for Indian businesses seeking streamlined trade.
- **Imbalance Trade:** India's exports to ASEAN increased to US\$ 44 billion from US\$ 42.32 billion in 2021-22. However, imports jumped to US\$ 87.57 billion compared to US\$ 68 billion in 2021-22.
- **Reciprocal Trade and Investment Barriers:** ASEAN faces trade and investment barriers in India, such as concerns regarding India's CAROTAR rules imposed in 2020.

WAY FORWARD

- **AITIGA Review:** Efforts to conclude the ASEAN-India Free Trade Agreement (AITIGA) review may intensify, particularly in promising sectors like pharmaceuticals, health, cyber, financial, and maritime security domains.
- **Collaborative Initiatives:** India's International Solar Alliance (ISA) and Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure (CDRI) could provide solutions to ASEAN's challenges.
- **Enhanced Partnership:** Deepen the Comprehensive Strategic Partnership established in 2022, focusing on diverse sectors such as connectivity, maritime cooperation, digital transformation, trade, and the economy.
- **Digital Transformation:** Promote digital transformation, including digital connectivity and technology sharing.
 - India and Singapore, for example, have started deeper collaboration in FinTech including interoperability in payment systems.
- **Revising Funding Policy:** Consider revising the policy on funding, moving towards a model where wealthier nations contribute more substantial funding, akin to the United Nations practice.

INDIA- INDONESIA

- The Indonesian Embassy in New Delhi in association with the Consulate General of Indonesia in Mumbai celebrated the 75th year of diplomatic relations between Indonesia and India this year(2024).
- The diplomatic relations between both countries, however, began in 1949. A year later, Indonesia's first president Soekarno was the first guest to be invited to the India's Republic Day celebration in 1950.

AREAS OF COOPERATION

- **Defence Cooperation:** India and Indonesia strengthen defence cooperation, including discussions on the potential export of BrahMos missiles, conduct joint exercises, and align strategically amid China's unilateralism.
 - India-Indonesia conducted a Bilateral exercise Samudra Shakti-23 from 14-19 May 2023.
- **Strategic Partnership:** During PM Modi's visit to Indonesia in 2018, both nations reached a consensus to enhance cooperation within their comprehensive strategic partnership.
- **Maritime Security:** Indonesia's Global Maritime Fulcrum and India's SAGAR vision align strategically in controlling crucial sea lines of communication from the Bay of Bengal to the Strait of Malacca.
 - Both countries have signed naval logistical agreements with Indian Ocean nations.
- **Trade:** Indonesia is now India's second-largest trading partner in ASEAN, with bilateral trade increasing from US\$ 26.04 billion in 2022-23 to US\$ 21.01 billion in 2021.
 - India's export to Indonesia stood at US\$ 6.7 billion during April-November 2022.
 - India is the second largest buyer of coal and crude palm oil from Indonesia and imports minerals, rubber, pulp and paper and hydrocarbon reserves.
- **Terrorism:** New Delhi and Jakarta have also put in place an arrangement of a Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty and instrument of extradition to deal with terror operatives who are a threat to both countries.
- **Connectivity:** The Sabang port is being developed in partnership with a neighbour and strategic partner Indonesia. It is close to the Malacca Strait.



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- The Andaman-Aceh Link connects Sabang City in Aceh Province, Indonesia, with the Andaman and Nicobar Islands, under the "Shared Vision of Maritime Cooperation in the Indo-Pacific" since 2018.
- **Global forums:** Both countries are members of the G20, the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM), the East Asia Summit, and the United Nations.

SIGNIFICANCE OF INDIA-INDONESIA RELATIONS

- **Strategic Location and Security:** Indonesia's location secures critical sea lanes against piracy, smuggling, illegal fishing, and terrorist movements.
- **Access to Sabang:** Granting Indian investors access to Sabang strengthens India's security role in the Indian Ocean.
- **Membership in International Forums:** Both countries are members of G20, NAM, East Asia Summit, and the UN, fostering collaboration on regional and global issues.
- **Countering Chinese Assertiveness:** Indonesia's support strengthens India's Act East Policy amid growing Chinese Assertiveness.
- **Alignment of Vision:** SAGAR and Global Maritime Fulcrum align, promoting regional security and growth.
- **Addressing Terrorism:** Interfaith dialogues combat religious-based terrorism and promote peace in the region.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA- INDONESIA RELATIONS

- **China's Influence:** Indonesia's close relationship with China since the Cold War may limit its willingness to act against China's interests.
- **Historical Differences:** Diverging alignments during the Cold War and Indonesia's support for Pakistan strained India-Indonesia relations.
- **Unresolved Maritime Borders:** The demarcation of maritime borders in the Andaman Sea is yet to be completed, posing an ongoing challenge to the relationship.
- **Economic Disparities:** Disparities in economic development and trade imbalances pose challenges to bilateral relations.
- **Cultural and Language Barriers:** Differences in culture, language, and societal norms can hinder effective communication and people-to-people exchanges.
- **Competing Regional Interests:** Divergent interests in regional issues may lead to disagreements and challenges in aligning positions.

WAY FORWARD

- **Strengthen Economic Cooperation:** Focus on enhancing trade and investment ties also explore new areas of collaboration to enhance economic cooperation.
- **Resolve Maritime Border Disputes:** Prioritise diplomatic resolution of maritime boundary issues.
- **Deepen Strategic Engagement:** Collaborate on regional security challenges leveraging their shared interests in maintaining a stable Indo-Pacific region.
- **Promote People-Centric partnerships:** Foster collaborations at the grassroots level, such as academic and cultural exchanges, youth programmes, and business interactions.
- **Regular High-Level engagements:** Maintain frequent diplomatic meetings to enhance understanding and trust

CONCLUSION

The regional ambitions and increasing maritime orientations of India and Indonesia, combined with their concerns about China's ascent, indicate that they are in a favourable position to establish a comprehensive partnership encompassing various areas.

Keywords: Reciprocal Trade and Investment Barriers, Coalition for Disaster Resilient Infrastructure, Indo-Pacific Ocean's Initiative (IPOI), Outlook on the Indo-Pacific (AOIP), BrahMos missiles, Samudra Shakti, SAGAR vision, Mutual Legal Assistance Treaty, Global Maritime Fulcrum



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INDIA - WEST ASIA

INTRODUCTION

The India-Middle East-Europe Corridor, announced at the G-20 summit, enhances New Delhi's standing in west Asia.

ABOUT THE INDIA-MIDDLE EAST-EUROPE ECONOMIC CORRIDOR

- The project includes India, the UAE, Saudi Arabia, the European Union, France, Italy, Germany and the US.
- The project will aim to enable greater trade among the involved countries, including energy products.
- The IMEC comprises of an Eastern Corridor connecting India to the Gulf region and a Northern Corridor connecting the Gulf region to Europe.
- It will include a railway and ship-rail transit network and road transport routes.
- The corridor will include a rail link as well as an electricity cable, a hydrogen pipeline and a high-speed data cable.
- In the coming times, it will be a major medium of economic integration between India, West Asia and Europe.
- The rail and shipping corridor is part of the Partnership for Global Infrastructure Investment (PGII)
- Significance
 - It would increase prosperity among the countries involved through an increased flow of energy and digital communications.
 - The project would help deal with the lack of infrastructure needed for growth in lower- and middle-income nations.

Key facts about the PGII

- It is a collaborative effort by G7 nations to fund infrastructure projects in developing nations.
- It is a developmental initiative aimed at narrowing the infrastructure gap in developing countries as well as help towards accelerate progress on SDGs globally.
- The infrastructure plan was first announced in June 2021 during the G7 Summit in the UK.
- Collectively, it aims to mobilise nearly \$600 billion from the G7 by 2027 to invest in critical infrastructure that improves lives and delivers real gains for all of our people."

INDIA'S TIES WITH WEST ASIA

- **Historical Perspective:** India considers West Asia as part of her extended neighbourhood.
 - Further, India's relations with West Asia have historical roots, including partnerships formed within the Non-Aligned Movement (NAM).
- **Regional Connectivity:** India maintains historic ties with Iran and is involved in projects like the development of the Chabahar Port.
 - The port acts as a hub for regional connectivity, connecting Afghanistan and Central Asia.
- **Geopolitical Shift Towards Multipolarity:** India has been strengthening its ties with Middle Eastern countries, especially the UAE and Saudi Arabia.
 - These partnerships have expanded beyond energy considerations to include defense, maritime security, counterterrorism, and cybersecurity.
- **Energy Coopertion:** Out of India's total imports of crude oil, the share of the Gulf countries is about 60%. (Iraq-22%, Saudi Arabia-18% [ORF Study]).
 - A large proportion of India's refineries process the sulphur -heavy sour grades of crude that are produced in the Gulf region.
 - Saudi Aramco signed an MoU with the Indian consortium to acquire a 50 per cent stake in India's largest refinery project Ratnagiri Refinery & Petrochemicals Limited.
- **Diaspora:** West Asia hosts around 8.5 million Indians working in different sectors which is about 65 percent of the total number of Indians working abroad.(MEA)
- **Remittance:** The non-resident Indians (NRIs) annually send home about \$40 billion, and West Asia account for more than 55% of the country's total remittance inflows.
- **Trade and investment:** According to UN Comtrade database, Iran and the GCC member states accounted for a 15.3% share of India's cumulative two-way merchandise trade from 2017 through 2021.

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- **Cultural Connect:** West Asia is India's extended neighbourhood with deep civilisational connect and historic and People to people roots.
 - Every year more than a lakh Indian Muslims go for Hajj in Mecca and Medina located in this region providing a binding force between two regions.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA-WEST ASIA RELATIONS

- **Palestine Issue & India's deepening ties with Israel:** The long-standing and complex conflict between Israelis and Palestinians presents a challenge of balancing human rights violations and strategic interests for India.
- **Organization of the Islamic Cooperation (OIC):** Since the 1990s, OIC issued a customary statement condemning the violence in Kashmir, which India has rejected outright.
- **China's role as peacemaker:** China has emerged as the biggest trading partner and a major investor in the region. It is playing a bigger role as peacemaker, as evident in the Iran -Saudi reconciliation agreement.
 - China's Belt and Road Initiative involves significant infrastructure projects in the Middle East.
- **Religious Extremism and Terrorism:** The rise of religious fundamentalism and its political manifestation in the form of jihadi radicalism and terrorism is a cause of grave concern to India.
 - Pakistan, under the slogan of Pan-Islamism, tries to exploit the situation especially In Kashmir in the form of cross border terrorism.
- **Energy Security:** India continued purchases oil from Russia, even in the face of the severe U.S. and Western sanctions.
- **Weak labour Laws:** The Gulf States have not ratified core International Labour Organisation Conventions protecting freedom of association and right to organise, which includes the right to strike and right to collective bargaining.
 - The Kafala system and Nitaqat law regulates migrant laborers in the Middle East, but growing outrage over human rights abuses, racism, and gender discrimination has fueled calls for reform.



WAY FORWARD

- **Multi-Engagement Approach:** India's overall policy in the region should be rooted in the idea of multifaceted engagement.
 - It should not prioritize appeasing or containing any specific great power.
- **Strategic Independence:** India should aim to maintain a significant geopolitical role in West Asia, regardless of U.S. involvement or China's presence.
 - The safety of trading sea lanes and anti-piracy and counter-terrorism collaboration are absolutely essential for interrupted supplies.
- **Diversification of Economies ties:** Recognize the shift in oil-dependent economies toward renewable energy sources and embrace a green technology-driven development path, aligning with their vision spanning from 2025 to 2040.
- **Protection policies for Indian diaspora:** Sound bilateral labour policies need to be framed to address the issues concerning the Indian labour working in the region.

INDIA AND IRAN

The External Affairs Minister of India visited Iran during the ongoing high-level exchanges between the two sides.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS OF VISIT

- **Maritime Security Concern:** Addressed concern about threats to maritime shipping in the region.
 - **Red Sea Crisis:** Highlighted attacks by Houthi militants targeting merchant vessels in the Red Sea amid the Israel-Hamas war.
- **Chabahar Port Development Plan:** An agreement between India and Iran on further developing the Chabahar Port was signed.

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- The new long-term agreement will replace the original contract which only covered India's operations at the Shahid Beheshti terminal in the Chabahar port and was renewed yearly.
- The new agreement has a validity of ten years and will be automatically extended.
- **Proposal for Joint Transportation Committee:** It will help to expand cooperation between the two countries.
 - The committee will enable the activation of transit capacities and the use of the North-South corridor.
- **Humanitarian Focus on Gaza Situation:** India expressed concern about the deeply concerning situation in Gaza, focusing on the loss of civilian lives, especially women and children.
- **Other Areas of Discussion:** Combating terrorism and organized crime; the need for cooperation to establish stability and security in Afghanistan; strengthening international trade, especially through national currencies;

INDIA-IRAN BILATERAL TIES

- **Historical Relation:** The India Iran ties can be traced back to the ancient times of Indus Valley civilization. There was trade between the coast of southern Iran and India through the Persian Gulf and the Arabian Sea.
- **Political Dimension:** India and Iran signed a friendship treaty on 15 March 1950.
 - The Tehran Declaration signed between the two countries affirms the two countries' shared vision for an "equitable, pluralistic and co-operative international order."
- **Geo Strategic Location:** Iran's unique geographical position provides India access to Central Asia, Afghanistan, and Eurasia markets.
- **Economic Ties:** Bilateral trade between Iran and India was US\$2.5 billion in 2022, reflecting an increase of 48 percent compared to US\$1.693 billion in 2021.
 - In July 2022, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) launched a system for settling, billing, and paying exports and imports in Indian Rupees (INR).
 - Iran recently included India in the list of countries whose citizens will not require a visa to travel to Iran.
- **Energy Security:** Iran ranks second globally in terms of gas reserves presenting opportunities for fuel diversification, decarbonization, and increasing the share of gas in India's energy mix until 2030.
- **Cultural Ties:** Civilizational links between India and Iran are the source of robust people-to-people and cultural ties.
 - The Indian Cultural Centre was established in 2013 and renamed the Swami Vivekananda Cultural Centre (SVCC) in 2018.
 - India recently decided to include Farsi (Persian) as one of the nine classical languages in India under the New Education Policy.

CHALLENGES IN RELATIONS

- **US Sanctions impacting India's Oil Imports and Chabahar Project:** India ceased to import Iranian oil on account of US sanctions on Tehran and its withdrawal from the Iran nuclear deal.
 - This also impacted the Chabahar project although the project was exempt from sanctions.
- **China's Increasing Presence:** China has strengthened its relations with Iran by signing a 25-year comprehensive cooperation agreement.
 - It has been consistently purchasing Iranian oil despite U.S. sanctions. China's plan to expand its maritime trade network and gain access to shipping routes has created a clash with India's aspirations.
- **Israeli Factor:** India has close ties with Israel and it presents a challenge for India to balance its relations with Iran.
 - Israel has strained relations with Iran and due to the existing ties between India and Iran, Israel has raised concerns about the potential transfer of military equipment or technology from India to Tehran.
- **Security Concerns:** Hamas, Hezbollah and Houthis rebel groups are supported by Iran.
 - Recently, Iranian ammunition targeted a tanker called MV Camp Plato off the coast of Dwarka creating challenges for maritime shipping for India.
- **Afghanistan Issue:** The US withdrawal from Afghanistan created challenges for India's Afghan strategy which relied on US-Iran cooperation for its Afghan interests.

WAY FORWARD

- **Ensuring Energy Security:** India should take the lead in establishing an institutional framework and advance the Turkmenistan–Afghanistan–Pakistan–India (TAPI) gas pipeline project to guarantee energy security.
 - A long-term supply agreement on natural gas cooperation out of US unilateral sanctions may be finalized.

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- **Enhancing Trade:** India needs to decrease the tariffs on Iranian agricultural goods through Preferential trade Agreements to enhance bilateral commercial ties through special economic mechanisms like signing preferential trade agreements.
 - An agreement similar to the 25-year investment deal signed between China and Iran may be signed.
- **Infrastructure Cooperation:** India's investment in Iranian oil and petrochemicals, the development of sea lines and the export of technical and engineering services will lead to expanding trade between the two nations.
 - Development of offshore gas fields like Farzad B and the fertilizer industries hold potential for cooperation between India and Iran.
 - Indian small and medium-sized enterprises (SMEs) can invest in Chabahar Economic Free Zone (EFZ) to set up petrochemical and fertilizer plants either independently or through joint ventures with Iranian public-private companies.
- **Curbing Terrorism:** Both nations need to cooperate to fight terrorism and to create peace, stability, and security in the region.
 - This is necessary, especially regarding the Pak-Afghan region as the epicenter of international terrorism.
- **Boosting Connectivity:** India and Iran should promote joint efforts with the Russian Federation and other Central Asia and Caucasus countries to upgrade existing transport corridors, especially the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC).
- **Enhancing Regional Cooperation through Multilateral Forums:** India can utilize BRICS and Shanghai Cooperation Organization (SCO) platforms to discuss important regional issues with the region.
 - The Ex-Chabahar Port project was stalled for years due to US sanctions as well as the Issue of peace and stability in Afghanistan.

India-Iran relations are challenged by external sanctions and divergent geopolitical interests, yet both nations seek to maintain economic and strategic cooperation. Balancing these factors is key to sustaining their bilateral relationship.

IRAN-ISRAEL CONFLICT

Recently, Iran carried out a series of air strikes on Israel using 200-300 drones and ballistic missiles.

IRAN-ISRAEL RELATIONS

- **Pre-1979 Iran-Israel Ties:** In 1948, the opposition of Arab states to Israel led to the first Arab-Israeli war. Iran was not a part of that conflict, and after Israel won, it established ties with the Jewish state. It was the second Muslim-majority country to do so after Turkey.
- **The 1979 Revolution:** A religious state was established in Iran. The regime's view of Israel changed, and it was seen as an occupier of Palestinian land.
- **Post 1979:** While Israel and Iran have never engaged in direct military confrontation, both have attempted to inflict damage on the other through proxies and limited strategic attacks.
 - Israel has attacked Iranian nuclear facilities from time to time. In the early 2010s, it targeted several facilities and nuclear scientists in a bid to prevent it from developing nuclear weapons.
- **Iran's Proxy Support:** Iran is seen as responsible for funding and supporting several militant groups in the region that are anti-Israel and anti-US, such as Hezbollah in Lebanon and Hamas in the Gaza Strip.

CHALLENGES FOR INDIA

- **Remain Unaffected:** India has strategic ties with both Iran and Israel and for decades, it has been able to balance between the two sides. But if the conflict widens, it would be difficult for it to maintain an ambivalent position.
- **A Testing Time:** The emerging Israel-Iran conflict will test the Indian resilience in multiple domains be it political, diplomatic, economic or security.
- **Concerning Consequences:** An escalation between the two countries has direct and tangible consequences for India, mainly on three accounts: its people, its economic interests and strategic needs.
 - **Impact on People:** There are about 18,000 Indians in Israel and about 5,000-10,000 Indians in Iran, about 90 lakh people are living and working in the Gulf and West Asia region. Any conflict that expands will end up posing a risk to the Indian community that is based in the region.
 - **Example:** India asked its citizens not to travel to Israel and Iran.
 - **Impact on Strategic Needs:** India has invested in a strategic relationship with major Arab countries, Iran, and Israel. India has been working in this region to push for the India-Middle-East-Europe Economic corridor, which has strategic as well as economic benefits for India.

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- **Impact on Economic Interests:** Though imports from Russia have increased, Arab states account for two-thirds of India's oil needs. Higher oil prices will push up inflation and delay any interest rate cuts critical to boost GDP growth.
 - Sensex and Nifty fell due to escalating Iran-Israel conflict, making investors risk-averse.

WAY FORWARD

- **A Dialogue-based Diplomatic Solution:** India had always adopted this approach. India needs to engage with Israel more as Iranian actions have been initiated as a consequence of the Israeli attack on an Iranian complex in Damascus, Syria.
- **Proactive Engagement:** It is now the responsibility of Israel to absorb the initial drone attacks launched by Iran and show restraint until Iran escalates it further. India must proactively engage with the USA, Iran, Russia, and Israel to ensure that this conflict is contained.
- **Consideration of Future Challenges:** A dialogue with the USA is required as it is involved in the Russia-Ukraine War, Israel-Hamas War, Houthis interference in the Red Sea, and the potential Iran-Israel conflict.
- **Focus on Development:**
 - India must fast-track the completion of the Chabahar Port in Iran which has been already delayed. Once this is completed, operationalised and put to use, it will give additional leverage with Iran to shape Iran's opinion on its regional and world matters.

ISRAEL-PALESTINE CONFLICT

- Israel declared a state of war after the Palestinian terrorist militant organization Hamas launched an attack on it.

WHAT IS THE CONFLICT BETWEEN ISRAEL AND PALESTINE?

Jerusalem in the Israeli-Palestinian Conflict:

- **UN Partition Plan (1947):** The original UN plan proposed Jerusalem as an international city.
- **First Arab-Israeli War (1948):** Israelis captured the western half of Jerusalem.
 - Jordan took the eastern part, including the Old City and Haram al-Sharif.
 - Six-Day War (1967): Israel defeated a coalition of Arab states, including Jordan.
 - Jordan lost control of the al-Aqsa Mosque.
 - Israel captured and annexed East Jerusalem.
- **Post-Six-Day War:** Israel considers the city its "unified, eternal capital."
- Palestinians insist on East Jerusalem as the capital of any future Palestinian state

INDIA'S STAND OVER CONFLICT

- **Historical Stand:** India has expressed solidarity with the Palestinian cause and supported the establishment of a sovereign Palestinian state.
 - In 1975, India became the first non-Arab country to recognize the PLO as the sole representative of the Palestinian people.
 - In 1988, when the Palestine Liberation Organization (PLO) declared an independent state of Palestine with its capital in East Jerusalem, India granted recognition immediately.
- **Recent Years:** In recent years, India's foreign policy has shifted, with Prime Minister Modi's visit to Israel in 2017, bypassing the traditional Palestine stopover.
 - The current administration aims to balance relations with both Arab states and Israel, navigating new complexities in West Asia.
 - Prime Minister expressed shock at the recent conflict and he called "terrorist attacks" and conveyed "solidarity with Israel".

WAY FORWARD

- **Implementation of Oslo Accords (1993):** The Oslo Accord is an ongoing American -mediated effort to broker a peace treaty between Israelis and Palestinians.
- **Two-State Solution:** The two-state solution has for decades been the primary focus of efforts to achieve peace in the Israeli-Palestinian conflict
 - The two-state solution aims to establish an independent Palestinian state alongside Israel, ensuring two states for two peoples.
- **Policy of De-hyphenation:** India stated about the "de-hyphenated" relationship, means India would deal with each country separately.

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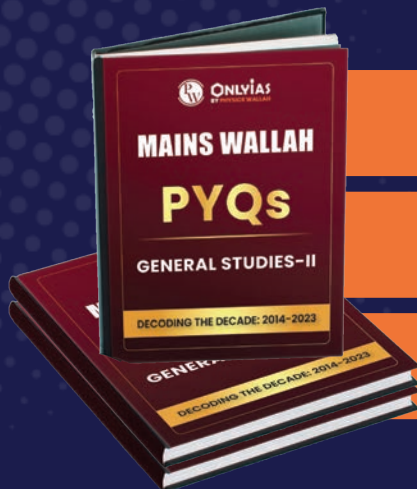
CONCLUSION

India's approach to West Asia is pragmatic, focusing on securing its energy needs, protecting its diaspora, expanding trade and investment opportunities, and maintaining strategic and defence ties, while navigating the complex political dynamics of the region.

Keywords: India-Middle East-Europe Corridor, Non-Aligned Movement, Organization of the Islamic Cooperation, International Labour Organisation, Kafala system, Red Sea Crisis, Tehran Declaration, Indian Cultural Centre, comprehensive cooperation agreement, Chabahar Economic Free Zone, Oslo Accords, Two-State Solution, Policy of De-hyphenation, Palestine Liberation Organization, Six-Day War.

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17**INDIA - UAE**

- The visit of the Indian Prime Minister to the United Arab Emirates, reflects the growing importance of their bilateral relations and significance of UAE in India's engagement in the Gulf region.
- Inauguration of Temple: Bochasanwasi Shri Akshar Purushottam Swaminarayan Sanstha (BAPS) temple, the first Hindu temple of Abu Dhabi.
- **World Government Summit:** PM addressed the World Government Summit on February 14 in Dubai as the 'Guest of Honour'.
- **Addressing the Indian Diaspora:** "Ahlan Modi" (Hello Modi) event at the Zayed Sports City Stadium.

INDIA -UAE RELATION

Beginning of Diplomatic Relations: Formal diplomatic relations were established soon after the UAE's formation in 1971 and the first Prime Ministerial visit was made by Indira Gandhi in 1981.

- **Cultural Cooperation**
 - **Indian Diaspora:** The UAE is home to 3.5 million Indians (30% of the Emirate's population). Indians are the largest expatriate community in the UAE, and their remittances are a significant source of foreign earnings.
 - **Educational Cooperation:** A campus of the Indian Institute of Technology-Delhi is being established in Abu Dhabi, initially offering a Masters program in Energy Transition and Sustainability.
 - **Religious Cooperation:** The BAPS temple initiative strengthens religious diplomacy and is a mark of religious tolerance in a Gulf nation.
- **Defence Cooperation**
 - **I2U2 Framework:** In July 2022, a new quadrilateral forum was established called the I2U2, whose members are India, Israel, UAE, and the US.
 - The forum identifies six areas of cooperation, namely water, food security, health, energy, transportation, and space.
- **Collaborative Global Leadership:** India's G20 presidency and the UAE's COP28 presidency provided additional opportunities for working together on global issues.

PROGRESS IN INDIA-UAE RELATIONS THROUGH DECADES ECONOMIC RELATIONS:

- **India-UAE Trade Relations:** India is UAE's second-largest trading partner accounting for 9% of its total foreign trade and 14% of non-oil exports. Also, the UAE is India's third biggest trade partner.
 - India and UAE bilateral trade worth US\$ 84.84 billion during 2022-23.
 - **India's Exports:** India exported 7,707 commodities to UAE in 2022-23 accounting to US\$ 31.60 billion.
 - **India's Imports:** India imported 4,064 commodities from UAE, accounting to US\$ 53.23 billion, in 2022-23.
- **Comprehensive Economic Partnership Agreement (CEPA):** India and UAE signed CEPA in February 2022 which acted as a catalyst in reducing tariff barriers and increasing trade and investment flows between the nations.
 - Post Signing of CEPA UAE emerged as the fourth largest investor in India. It has committed to invest US\$ 75 billion in India's infrastructure sector.
 - The Abu Dhabi Investment Authority (ADIA) will soon open an office in GIFT City, Gujarat.
- **Bharat Mart:** It is a key initiative of Dubai-based DP World and India's Ministry of Commerce and Industry to boost exports of Indian Micro, Small and Medium Enterprises.
 - The project builds on the momentum of India-UAE CEPA which completed its first year in 2023 and has seen India's trade with the UAE grow by 16% to \$85 billion.

MAJOR CHALLENGES IN INDIA-UAE RELATIONS

- **Geopolitical Concerns**
 - **Relationship with Pakistan:** The financial support from the UAE to Pakistan could be diverted for anti-India activities.
 - **Competition from China:** China's strategic investments and financial engagements in the UAE, surpassing USD 30 billion between 2005 and 2020 presents a competitive challenge for India.

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- **Trade Challenges**
 - **Concentration of Trade in Specific Items:** India-UAE trade relations lack diversity and are mostly concentrated in hydrocarbon and precious metals trade.
 - **Presence of Non-Tariff Barriers:** Non-tariff barriers like Sanitary and Phytosanitary measures along with issue of Halal certification has led to the decline in Indian food item exports to the UAE.
- **Labor Rights Concerns:**
 - The Kafala System proves to be exploitative practice for the Indian diaspora.
- **Investment and Economic Cooperation Delays:**
 - Slow Project Implementation and sluggish pace in executing the \$75 billion UAE investment fund for Indian infrastructure projects underscores inefficiencies and delays in bilateral economic initiatives.
- **Energy and Transportation Disputes:**
 - Oil Pricing Conflicts: Disagreements over oil pricing between India, a major consumer, and the UAE, an OPEC member, have led to tensions, impacting energy cooperation.

WAY FORWARD

- **Transparent Aid Tracking:** Advocate for transparency in financial aid, ensuring UAE's support to other nations does not adversely affect India's security interests.
- **Diplomatic Engagement:** Strengthen diplomatic channels to navigate regional tensions, maintaining a balanced approach in relations with the UAE, Iran, and other Middle Eastern countries.
- **FTA Compliance:** The countries should aim for a clearer and more predictable regulatory regime. Proper compliance within the tariff framework of each country should be adhered to ease trade.
- **Bilateral Agreements:** The countries should work towards bilateral agreements that ensure the protection of labour rights and improve the living conditions of migrant workers under the Kafala systems.
- **Cultural Exchanges and Community Welfare Programs:** The countries should engage in promoting cultural and educational exchanges to bolster people-to-people connections and implement programs aimed at improving the welfare of the Indian diaspora.

CONCLUSION

India-UAE relations are largely positive, driven by robust economic ties and strategic cooperation, but require ongoing dialogue to address labor issues and geopolitical alignment.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	How will I2U2 (India, Israel, UAE and USA) grouping transform India's position in global politics	2022
2.	In what ways would the ongoing US - Iran Nuclear Pact controversy affect the national interest of India? How should India respond to this situation?	2018
3.	"India's relations with Israel have, of late, acquired a depth and diversity, which cannot be roiled back." Discuss	2018

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INDIA AND CENTRAL ASIA

INTRODUCTION

- Central Asia is located in the heart of Eurasia and forms part of India's extended neighbourhood. The beginning of close trade and cultural linkages can be traced to the Indus Valley civilisation.

HISTORICAL AND CULTURAL TIES

- Historical relations:** Since the third century B.C., relations between India and Central Asia have been strong. The present Central Asian region was governed by the **Kushan Empire**.
- Cultural ties:** The Silk Road's trade and the growth of **Buddhism** led to historical economic ties and cultural exchanges.
- Ancient Silk Road:** India and Central Asia have been connected by the Silk Road since ancient times, which has fostered philosophical and intellectual interchange.
- Islam and Sufism:** The origins of the Mughals may be linked to Central Asia (Babur was from the Fergana Valley), and many notable individuals, such as **Al Buruni**, **Amir Khusro**, and **Sufi saints**, played important roles in spreading Islamic culture in India.

AREA OF COOPERATION

TRADE AND CONNECTIVITY

- International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC):** INSTC is a multi-mode network that will connect India with Iran, Afghanistan, Armenia, Azerbaijan, Russia, Central Asia, and Europe for the transportation of freight.
- Ashgabat Agreement:** In order to facilitate the movement of commodities between Central Asia and the Persian Gulf, India, Iran, Kazakhstan, Oman, Turkmenistan, and Uzbekistan have entered into a multimodal transportation agreement.

DEFENCE AND SECURITY COOPERATION

- Issues of Afghanistan:** India and Central Asia have a shared interest in the stability of Afghanistan, hence cooperation in these areas is crucial.
- Defence Exercise:** High-level interactions with Central Asian nations have been prominent like 'DUSTLIK' with Uzbekistan, "Khanjar" with Kyrgyzstan, and "Kazind" with Kazakhstan.

CULTURAL TIE-UP:

- People-to-People Interaction:** India's Connect Central Asia Policy has been distinguished by its emphasis on "people- to-people" interactions.
- Learning centres:** For higher learning, many students from Central Asia travel to India, and vice versa.
- Soft power:** People in Central Asia enjoy Indian movies and listen to Hindi music.

ENERGY COOPERATION

- One-stop energy resource centre:** India is trying to diversify its imports, and Central Asia has the potential to be a significant source. Kazakhstan generates 43% of the uranium in the world, Uranium, and gold reserves are found in Uzbekistan.
- Deal with Uzbekistan:** In addition to helping to build liquid gas and oil facilities in Uzbekistan, India and Uzbekistan have signed agreements to jointly explore and develop Uzbek gas reserves.
- Turkmenistan & India:** Turkmenistan is the fourth-largest gas reserve in the world, which is a less carbon-intensive fuel. The TAPI gas line with Turkmenistan is in progress.
- Solar energy cooperation:** The Central Asian leaders showed interest in the Indian initiative of "One Sun, One World, One Grid".



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COOPERATION IN HEALTH SECTOR

- **Vaccine Diplomacy:** Recently, concluded summit focused on “extensive vaccination, vaccine supply, transfer of technology, development of local production capacities, promotion of supply chains for medical products, and ensuring price transparency.”
- The Central Asian leaders’ appreciation for the approach “**One Earth, One Health**”, presented by PM Modi.

IMPORTANCE OF REGION

- **Complex Geopolitics:**
 - **Global power intervention:** The complex geopolitical situation is the result of the interaction of both global and regional forces and their subsequent impact on the region.
 - **Taliban government:** The USA leaving from Afghanistan has brought changes in geopolitics and compelled these countries to revamp the policy.
 - **Rise of China:** China has made a prominent presence in the region through BRI-led infrastructure projects and financial aid.
- **Connectivity:**
 - **Connecting link:** CAR (Central Asian Region) provides a connecting link between West Asia, Eurasia and Indian Subcontinent. INSTC, Chahbahar Port can help to establish connectivity to Afghanistan and CAR.
- **Trade, Communication and Economy:**
 - **Mineral wealth:** The region is blessed with minerals like gold, iron, copper, and aluminium which can be imported for growing Indian demand.
 - **Digital Connectivity:** India is planning to establish a central Asian e-network linking all five nations and provide **tele-education and telemedicine connectivity**
 - **Trade Relations:** India has also acceded to the Customs Convention on International Transport of Goods under the cover of TIR and joined the **Ashgabat Agreement**.
- **Energy Security:**
 - **Resources:** The region has large oil, natural gas and uranium reserves. It is important from the point of view of **India’s energy security**.
 - **Energy Diplomacy:** Slowly and steadily, India also took steps to get a share in the energy sectors of Turkmenistan and Uzbekistan. Even in Tajikistan and Kyrgyzstan, India got a stake over the years in the hydroelectric projects.
 - **Ongoing Projects:** India is developing the TAPI pipeline with the help of Tajikistan, Afghanistan, Pakistan and India.
- **Security:**
 - **Peace and stability:** It is important for peace and stability for India because of **increasing terrorism** and its vicinity to **Golden Crescent**.
 - **Tackling terrorism:** Both Kazakhstan and Tajikistan signed agreements to fight against terrorism with India. **SCO – RAT initiative** helps member countries to fight extremism, terrorism and separatism.
- **Social & Health:**
 - **Social Capital:** To enhance people-to-people ties, India can provide assistance in augmenting the Social Capital. **E.g.** India can share experience in managing the **local-self-government** (Panchayat Raj system) with Central Asian countries where **mahalla culture** (local self-government) is widely prevalent.
 - **Healthcare services:** India can provide affordable healthcare services **E.g. Ayurveda and Siddha**.
- **Multilateral Cooperation:**
 - **Eurasian Economic Union:** It is an organisation for regional economic integration which provides free movement of goods, services and labour.
 - **Heart of Asia Conference:** It aims at ensuring peace, stability, security and prosperity in Afghanistan and nearby regions.

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- **Shanghai Cooperation Organization:** It aims at promoting cooperation in politics, economy, and technology and to ensure peace, security in the region.

India Central Asia Summit 2022

- Recently, the first India-Central Asia Summit was held.
- The summit was focused on the areas of defence and security, trade and connectivity, medical and healthcare, energy security, cultural ties and stable Afghanistan.
- The decision was taken to establish the “**India-Central Asia Centre**” in New Delhi to function as a Secretariat for the India-Central Asia biannual summit.
- Proposal to create an “**India-Central Asia Parliamentary Forum**” to enable robust deliberations between the legislatures of these countries.

CHALLENGES

- **Geoeconomics: Interests of China and the US** have altered the geopolitical narratives of Central Asia and competing India’s interests. **The OBOR initiatives of China** have increased the presence of China.
 - **India’s trade** with the region amounts less than US\$ 2 billion, due to constrained in connectivity and low economic engagement.
- **Connectivity:**
 - **Hostility of Pakistan and Destabilised Afghanistan** have closed the nearest land route to central Asia as well as insecure the reach via Chabahar port.
 - **Sluggish development of INSTC** projects has further stalled to enhance connectivity.
- **Security:**
 - **Growing radical Taliban** in Afghanistan, role of Pakistan, Saudi Arabia Turkey and Iran in spreading radicalisation in Central Asia.
 - **Vicinity to Golden crescent** and increasing terrorism is threat to peace and stability.
- **Geopolitics:**
- The Geopolitical region is fragile as the China-Russian convergence, the adverse impact of the Syrian crisis pushing India away.
- CAR have failed to associate as a strong regional group due to various internal conflicts over terrorism and ethnic issues preventing them to unite.

WAY FORWARD

- **Strengthen Connectivity:** Invest in infrastructure projects to enhance trade routes and connectivity.
- **Diversify Partnerships:** Seek new avenues for economic cooperation beyond energy dependence.
- **Collaborative Security Measures:** Work with Central Asian nations to address common security threats.
- **Engage Actively:** Increase diplomatic and cultural exchanges to foster closer ties and mutual understanding.

CONCLUSION

Enhancing connectivity, diversifying partnerships, and addressing security challenges are key for fostering robust and mutually beneficial relations between India and Central Asia, ensuring regional stability and prosperity.

Keywords: India’s extended neighbourhood, **International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC)**, **Ashgabat Agreement**, Connect Central Asia Policy, TAPI gas line, **Vaccine Diplomacy**, **One Earth-One Health**, Customs Convention on International Transport of Goods, **Energy Diplomacy**, **Golden Crescent**, **SCO – RAT initiative**, **Eurasian Economic Union**, **Heart of Asia Conference**.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	A number of outside powers have entrenched themselves in Central Asia, which is a zone of interest to India. Discuss the implications, in this context, of India’s joining the Ashgabat Agreement.	2018
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INDIA- LATIN AMERICA

BACKGROUND

- Latin America possesses abundant **reserves of minerals** including copper, lithium, iron ore, gold, and silver, which creates a chance for India to enhance its investments in their extraction and procure them at more affordable rates.
- Approximately 15% of **India's crude oil supply** is derived from countries in Latin America, which collectively possess a significant share of the world's crude oil reserves, estimated at around 20%.

FACT WISE

- **Trade volume:** Trade volume between India and Latin America hit an all-time high of \$50 billion in 2022. This is a 30% increase over 2021.
- **Exports:** In 2022, India exported items worth \$22.4 billion to Latin America. Pharmaceuticals, engineering goods, and textiles were the top three exports.
- **Imports:** Oil and gas, iron ore, and copper were the most important imports.
- **Indian investment:** In Latin America has increased in recent years. In 2022, Indian firms will have invested \$10 billion in Latin America.

SIGNIFICANCE OF LATIN AMERICA FOR INDIA

- **Exporting of generic medicines:** India has been **exporting generic medicines** worth a billion dollars to Latin America, which has played a significant role in reducing healthcare costs in those countries.
- **Investment In India:** **Latin American firms have invested** around a billion dollars in various sectors **in India**, including soft drinks, auto parts, multiplexes, and theme parks.
- **Development and delivery centres:** **Latin American software companies** have established development and delivery centres in India, employing more than a thousand Indian software engineers.
- **India's energy security:** It has also been strengthened by Latin America, as **India now imports 20% of its crude oil** from Brazil, Colombia, Mexico, and Venezuela.
- **Provider of IT services:** **India is also a major provider of IT services** to Latin America, with over 35,000 Latin American individuals being employed in Indian IT companies operating in the region.

AREA OF COOPERATION

- **People-to-people connect:**
 - The use of **cultural tools** such as language, food, and art can facilitate deeper **understanding and connection** between people from India and Latin America.
 - Over time, there has been an increase in **cultural exchanges** between the two regions, with **scholarships** offered by educational institutions for dance and music.
 - Latin American embassies in India also organize **music festivals and cultural programs** that have attracted large Indian audiences.
 - The **Spanish embassy's cultural centre** provides a platform for hosting Latin American film festivals, as well as offering classes in language and cuisine.
 - Despite the positive response to these efforts, they are still in their early stages and offer many opportunities for further exploration.
- **Political:**
 - India and Brazil have been collaborating on various platforms such as **BRICS and IBSA**, which offer developing countries an alternative forum and reduce their reliance on institutions currently dominated by Western powers.
 - Recently, India declared a grant of 14 million US dollars for community **development initiatives in CARICOM** (The Caribbean Community and Common Market) as well as a 150 million dollar line of credit to fund projects related to solar energy, renewable energy, and climate change.
 - India has been granted **observer status** at the annual summit of the **Pacific Alliance**, a trade bloc consisting of Chile, Colombia, Mexico, and Peru, all of which are countries located along the Pacific Ocean in Latin America.

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- **Economic:**

- India imports significant amounts of **hydrocarbons** from Venezuela, Mexico, Colombia, and Brazil, as well as edible oils and sugar from Argentina and Brazil, copper and precious metals from Peru and Chile, and wood from Ecuador.
- Additionally, India is a major provider of **IT services** to Latin America.
- In 2004, **India and MERCOSUR** signed a **Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA)** aimed at bolstering their existing relationship, promoting trade expansion, and granting mutual fixed tariff preferences.
 - **Mercosur** is a **regional organization comprising South American countries** that aims to facilitate the unrestricted exchange of goods, services, currency, and individuals by promoting free trade.

- **Security:**

- The Defense Research and Development Organization (DRDO) of India and Brazilian aircraft manufacturer Embraer have teamed up to create and **manufacture radar platforms** for use in aircraft
- India has been gradually increasing its engagement with Latin American nations in recent years, but its efforts are overshadowed by **China's massive presence in the region**.

ISSUES

- **Domestic and international priorities:** The development of relations between India and Latin America has been hindered primarily by the **significant geographical distance** separating the two regions, as well as differences in their respective domestic and international priorities.
 - Absence of cultural, linguistic, and diaspora: Historically, the absence of cultural, linguistic, and diaspora ties has contributed to a dearth of connections between India and Latin America.
- **Connectivity issues:** The digital divide is a significant issue in Latin America, with less than **half of the households (45.5 per cent) having access to broadband**. Additionally, there is a considerable gap in internet usage between the highest and lowest quintiles of earners.
- **Financial limitations:** The combination of **sluggish economic growth, elevated inflation, and worldwide unpredictability** implies that a lot of individuals in the area will likely experience a **reduction in their quality of life**.
- **Negotiations for a Free Trade Agreement (FTA):** With MERCOSUR have come to a **halt** because of disagreements among the members of the bloc.
- **Political rivalries:** India's relations with the region are being influenced by **political rivalries** between countries such as Brazil and Argentina, who are vying for regional dominance.

WAY FORWARD

- **Gain a deeper understanding:** To improve the relationship between India and Latin America, it is necessary for both sides to gain a deeper understanding of each other's political realities, resources, capabilities, and priorities beyond just relying on temporary diplomats.
- **Take the lead in identifying key actors:** Given Latin America's complex network of regional and sub-regional organizations, India should take the lead in identifying and engaging with key actors and forums to promote political initiatives, while also fostering economic and social interactions.
- **Protect investments:** To facilitate this, agreements should be made to protect investments, avoid double taxation, support extradition and immigration, provide lines of credit, eliminate regulatory obstacles, and more.
- **Increase its diplomatic presence:** India should also increase its diplomatic presence in the region, encourage the study of Latin American culture and affairs, invest in shipping industries, and **work towards signing PTAs and FTAs with various countries** and groups in the region as soon as possible.

CONCLUSION

India's commerce with Latin America pales in comparison to China's \$450 billion in the region. Historically, Indian enterprises in LAC have lagged. As a result, India must strengthen its economic diplomacy and join regional economic organisations such as the Inter-American Development Bank.

Keywords

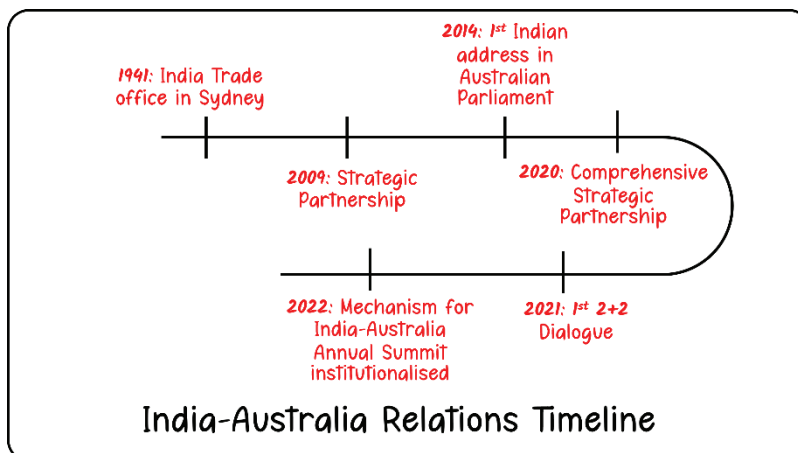
CARICOM (The Caribbean Community and Common Market), MERCOSUR, Preferential Trade Agreement (PTA),

20**INDIA AND AUSTRALIA**

- Recently, India and Australia held a 2+2 Ministerial Dialogue in New Delhi.
- About 2 + 2 meetings: The 2 + 2 is a unique ministerial dialogue involving the Defence and External Affairs Minister of participating countries.
 - India's 2+2 Dialogue Partners: Australia, the United States, Japan, Russia and the United Kingdom.

INDIA-AUSTRALIA BILATERAL RELATIONSHIP

- **Diplomatic Relations:** Diplomatic relations were established in the pre-independence period, when the Consulate General of India was first opened as a Trade Office in Sydney in 1941.
- **Shared Values:** Bilateral relationship is based on shared values of pluralistic democracy, expanding economic engagement, and high-level interaction.
- **Evolution to strategic ties and plurilateral cooperation:** In June 2020, at the India-Australia Leaders' Virtual Summit in June 2020, the bilateral relationship was elevated from the Strategic Partnership concluded in 2009 to a Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP).
- The two democracies have taken their cooperation to plurilateral formats, including the Quad (with the United States and Japan).

**AREA OF COOPERATION**

- **Geographical Proximity:** Australia is situated in India's extended neighborhood, fostering a unique geographical closeness.
- **Economic cooperation:** Australia is currently India's 17th largest trading partner and India is Australia's 9th largest trading partner.
- **People-to-people ties:** As per the 2021 Census, around 9.76 lakh people in Australia reported their ancestry as Indian origin, making them the second largest group of overseas-born residents in Australia.
- **Education:** Australia's Deakin University and the University of Wollongong Indian campuses are being opened in the GIFT City (Gandhinagar). These are the first two international universities to be approved to set up a campus in India.
- **Defense Cooperation:** Mutual Logistics Support Agreement (MLSA) was concluded during the Virtual Summit in June 2020 which allows the two countries to access military bases for refueling and logistics purposes, as well as to enhance military engagement and maritime domain awareness between the two countries.
 - **Defense Exercises:** Both countries participate in "Malabar" exercises and AUSINDEX
- **Clean Energy:** The countries signed a Letter of Intent on New and Renewable Energy in February 2022 which provides for cooperation towards bringing down the cost of renewable energy technologies.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA-AUSTRALIA RELATIONS

- **Visa issues:** In April 2023, at least five Australian universities placed restrictions on students from some Indian states, amidst a surge in fraudulent applications from South Asia seeking to work and not study in Australia.
- **Khalistan Movement Concerns:** The recent surge in 'khalistani' activities in Australia to the extent of the 'Kill India' rally and open threats to Indian diplomats is a grave concern that needs to be addressed.
- **Economic Relationship Limitations:** The economic relationship is narrow and primarily dominated by coal exports, with challenges in diversifying and expanding trade beyond this sector.
- **Free Trade Agreement Challenges:** India's reluctance to liberalize market access in agriculture and Australia's reservations about allowing significant labor mobility are obstacles to finalizing a comprehensive free trade agreement.

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- **Lack of Uranium Supply:** The progress on uranium supply has been very low, despite efforts from both sides.
 - In 2017, Australia had sent its first uranium shipment to India but that was cited as “a small sample of uranium” transferred “purely for testing purposes”.
- **Adani coal mine project in Australia:** The proposed Adani Carmichael coal mine project in Queensland, Australia, led by the Indian company Adani Group, has faced environmental and regulatory hurdles.

WAY FORWARD

- **Navigating Market Challenges:** Although the government has achieved a favorable trade deal, India faces hurdles entering the Australian market, given Australia's 16 operational FTAs.
 - The key to success lies in improving competitiveness, especially considering competition from nations like China, ASEAN, Chile, Japan, Korea, and New Zealand with established FTAs.
- **Amended tax laws:** Although Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement (ECTA) between India and Australia addresses taxation challenges faced by Indian IT companies. Australia should commit to amending tax laws, preventing taxation of offshore income from Indian firms providing technical services.
- **Economic Cooperation:** India and Australia are continuing the momentum over free trade negotiations, following the interim trade pact coming into force at the end of 2022.
 - Seeking to reap further dividends, the two countries should conclude Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement (CECA) by December 2023.
- **Open Indo-Pacific Cooperation:** Both countries reaffirmed their support for sovereignty and territorial integrity in the Indo-Pacific, democratic values, rule of law, freedom of navigation and overflight and the peaceful resolution of disputes.

Keywords: Comprehensive Strategic Partnership (CSP), GIFT City (Gandhinagar), Mutual Logistics Support Agreement (MLSA), Khalistan Movement, Economic Cooperation and Trade Agreement, Comprehensive Economic Cooperation Agreement.



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INDIA- AFRICA

"India and South Africa are two countries held so closely by bonds of sentiment, common values, and shared experience, by the affinity of cultures and traditions and by geography"- NELSON MANDELA

INTRODUCTION

The India-Africa partnership is rooted in historical connections, solidarity, and a shared vision for a prosperous and inclusive future. Over the years, both India and African countries have actively engaged in various areas, including trade, investment, capacity-building, infrastructure development, healthcare, education, and cultural exchanges, to strengthen their bilateral ties and foster mutual growth and development.

FACT-WISE

- India's trade volume with Africa for the year 2021–22 is significant, totalling US\$ 89.5 billion.
- India and SADC (Southern African Development Community):** Founded in the year 1980. There are 16 nations in this group. 35.4 percent of Africa's total land area, 28.4 percent of its total GDP, and 28.2 percent of its population are all accounted for by these countries.
- India and SADC have a solid and close relationship. In the middle of 2021, the two had total trade of \$30.8 billion USD. Additionally, during the past 26 years, India has invested US\$ 69.9 billion in the SADC.

WHY IS THE AFRICAN CONTINENT IMPORTANT

- Demography of Africa:** Africa's large working-age population, its growing middle class, and the significant share of services are all ingredients for value adding trade and investment relationships.
- Opportunity to Invest in Africa:** Consumer-driven goods related to agribusiness, apparel and clothing, pharmaceuticals, and automotive components are opportunities for India's foreign direct investment (FDI).
- Medical Tourism:** The number of African tourists visiting the country for medical treatment has increased almost threefold in the last decade, from 5.4 percent of the total tourist visits in 2010 to 15.4 percent in 2019.
- India as Educational Hub:** More than 25,000 African students are currently enrolled in various universities all around India, as per the Association for African Students in India.
- Natural Resources:** The continent is enriched in mines and minerals such as diamonds, gold, platinum, and a variety of other forestry products abound in the continent, which is vital to the rest of the globe.

TECHNICAL AND ECONOMIC COOPERATION (ITEC)

- The Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) project has been crucial in developing Africa's skills.
- ITEC, which was established in 1964, has played a significant role in India-Africa collaboration.
- In 2019, India introduced the first e-ITEC pilot programme for two African countries.
- Since the start of the pandemic, the e-ITEC has gained new prominence as the new standard.
- To address the demands of a changing time, new and innovative courses, such as big data analytics, urban infrastructure management, WTO-related issues, and solar technology, were organically launched.

AREA OF COOPERATION BETWEEN INDIA-AFRICA

- Trade and Investment:** Both sides aim to enhance economic ties by promoting trade diversification, facilitating investments, and exploring new business opportunities.
- Infrastructure Development:** India has actively supported infrastructure development projects in Africa, focusing on sectors like transportation, energy, and telecommunications.
- Capacity-Building and Skill Development:** Indian institutions like the Indian Technical and Economic Cooperation (ITEC) program and the Pan African e-Network project have contributed to skill development, education, and knowledge sharing.

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- **Agriculture and Food Security:** India shares its experience in agricultural practices, technology transfer, and irrigation systems. The India-Africa Agriculture Cooperation Plan and the India-Africa Food Processing Summit are initiatives that promote cooperation in this sector.
- **Healthcare and Pharmaceuticals:** Indian pharmaceutical companies have supplied generic medicines to address healthcare challenges, particularly in the areas of HIV/AIDS, malaria, and tuberculosis.
- **Renewable Energy and Climate Change:** India shares its expertise in solar energy, wind power, and other renewable energy sources. The International Solar Alliance (ISA), launched by India and France, has attracted participation from several African countries to promote solar energy adoption.
- **Education and Cultural Exchanges:** Indian universities offer scholarships to African students, and cultural festivals and exchange programs foster a deeper understanding of each other's cultures.

CHINESE ENGAGEMENTS IN AFRICA

- **Economic Competition:** China's economic presence in Africa has intensified competition for markets and resources. Chinese companies, backed by state support, often secure infrastructure projects and investments, potentially overshadowing Indian businesses in the region.
- **Debt Sustainability:** China's financing of infrastructure projects in Africa, often through loans, has raised concerns about debt sustainability for African countries.
- **Geopolitical Influence:** Chinese military presence, access to naval bases, and involvement in peacekeeping operations in Africa have implications for regional security dynamics and India's strategic partnerships with African countries.
- **Natural Resource Acquisition:** China's appetite for Africa's natural resources, such as oil, minerals, and timber, has led to concerns about resource exploitation and environmental degradation.
- **Human Rights and Governance Concerns:** Chinese investments and aid are often not conditional on improvements in governance, human rights, or environmental standards, which can be a cause of concern for India, which emphasizes shared values in its engagements with Africa.

ISSUES AND CHALLENGES

- **Geographical Distance:** The geographical distance between India and Africa poses logistical challenges in terms of connectivity, trade, and people-to-people exchanges.
- **Competing Priorities:** African countries often have multiple partners and engagements, including with major powers like China, the European Union, and the United States.
- **Infrastructure Deficits:** Many African countries face infrastructure deficits, including inadequate transportation networks, power shortages, and digital connectivity gaps.
- **Security Concerns:** Security challenges, including terrorism, piracy, and conflicts in some African regions, can impact stability and hinder economic development.
- **Cultural and Linguistic Diversity:** Africa is a diverse continent with multiple languages, cultures, and traditions. Understanding and navigating this diversity requires effective communication, cultural sensitivity, and tailored approaches to engage with different African countries and communities.

WAY FORWARD

- **Developing Capacity:** Limited human resources, skill gaps, and weak institutional frameworks can hinder effective implementation of joint initiatives and cooperation. India can address these issues on priority.
- **Market Access and Trade Barriers:** Addressing trade barriers and enhancing market access is crucial for expanding India-Africa trade. Tariff and non-tariff barriers, regulatory challenges, and differences in standards and certifications can pose hurdles to bilateral trade and economic cooperation.
- **Removing Development Imbalance:** African countries exhibit significant development disparities, with some countries experiencing high levels of poverty, underdevelopment, and socio-economic challenge.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Increasing interest of India in Africa has its pros and cons. Critically examine.	2015
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SOUTH ASIAN ASSOCIATION FOR REGIONAL COOPERATION (SAARC)

INTRODUCTION

- The South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation (SAARC) is South Asia's regional intergovernmental organization and geopolitical union. The SAARC was established in December 1985 in Dhaka. Its headquarters are in Kathmandu, Nepal.
- Afghanistan, Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, the Maldives, Nepal, Pakistan, and Sri Lanka are its members. The SAARC region covers 3% of the global land area, 21% of the global population, and 4.21% of the worldwide GDP.

THE OBJECTIVES OF THE SAARC

- **Cultural and social:** To establish better cultural and social ties amongst the member states to promote peace in the region.
- **To promote trade:** among its members in order to enhance its members' economic situation.
- **Social well-being:** To accelerate the pace of social and economic development of the countries and raise it from a region of poverty to a region of economic and social wellbeing.
- **Establish peace & stability:** Further the cause of peace, progress and stability in the region.

SIGNIFICANCE OF SAARC FOR INDIA

- **Regional Integration:** Regional initiatives are the "Goldilocks option" between globalisation and hyper-nationalism, providing a balance between globalisation and hyper-nationalism.
- **Socio-Economic development in the region:** SAARC promotes trade and development to improve the standard of life and poverty alleviation.
- **Countering Terrorism:** Cooperation with member countries to strengthen security and defence cooperation.
- **Containing China and its OBOR project:** by engaging with regional countries in the developmental process and economic cooperation.
- **Indi-Pacific and Act East Policy:** SAARC can prove to be a game-changer to link South Asia with south-east Asia economically, socially as well as politically.
- **India's Soft Power:** SAARC provides an important platform to build a regional architecture for encouraging cultural, religious as well as spiritual contacts and providing developmental assistance to member countries.
- **India's global ambitions:** M.K. Narayanan argues that if India is not actively involved in ensuring the region is peaceful and functioning in accordance with its worldview, global leadership will be limited. SAARC is important for India to build regional security architecture.

ACHIEVEMENTS OF SAARC

- **SAPTA and SAFTA:** To boost regional trade among countries of the region.
- **South Asian Identity:** SAARC aims to bring states together to share a common heritage, culture, clothing, and political systems.
- **South Asian University:** The University aims to create a centre of excellence and produce leaders with a common vision of success for both their home country and the neighbours.
- **SAARC Development Fund:** The Fund is an umbrella financial institution for SAARC projects and programs to improve the welfare of the South Asian region.
- **SAARC Arbitration Council:** The Inter-Governmental Body is an inter-governmental body authorized to provide a legal framework for fair and effective settlement of industrial, commercial, trade, and other disputes.

SAARC AND COVID-19

- India's proposal to launch a COVID-19 Emergency Fund was received positively, with all countries contributing voluntarily.
- India proposed a shared electronic platform for all SAARC nations to exchange information, knowledge, expertise and best practices.

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- It has accepted requests and provided support for medical equipment, medicines and other supplies.
- It has also provided vaccines to its neighbours through the Vaccine Maitri programme.

FAILURES OF SAARC

- **Indo-Pak Relations:** The escalation of tension and violence between India and Pakistan has significantly damaged SAARC's prospects.
- **No regular meetings:** After the terrorist attacks on Uri, SAARC meetings could not be held due to India-Pakistan tensions. The year 2021 marked 7th year since the last summit where SAARC leaders met.
- **Weak Cultural Identities:** This limits the prospects of cooperation among the countries due to **trust deficit** among members.
- **Unresolved issues:** The region still faces many unresolved border and maritime issues. Further, Fear of India's Big Brotherly attitude among small neighbours has reduced the scope of cooperation at SAARC.
- **India's apprehension:** Such an organization might be used by her smaller neighbours to extract undue concessions by expressing their fear of being bullied by India.
- **Limitation in SAFTA:** Due to this South Asia remains the least integrated region in the world with trade among members being less than 5% of their overall trade.
- **Decision Making:** As per the SAARC charter, all decisions are taken by consensus. This has enabled Pakistan to oppose every initiative of India on connectivity and trade.
- **Bilateral issues:** like Bangladesh's concerns over CAA-NRC, the Madhesi issue and the Kalapani Border issue between India and Nepal etc.
- **Rising Chinese footprint:** South Asian nations are increasingly relying on China for imports, with Pakistan, Nepal, Bangladesh, and Sri Lanka all moving closer to China for ideational and material reasons. China is also offering tariff exemptions to Bangladesh and Sri Lanka.

WAY FORWARD

- **Reviving SAARC to deal with China:** India's strategic dealing with China must begin with South Asia, reinvigorating SAARC, which has been in decline since 2014.
- **Increasing people-to-people contact:** Social media and citizens can strengthen people-to-people contact and bring about regional integration through active participation from the fifth estate and citizens.
- **Economic Integration:** Social media and citizens can foster regional integration through active participation.
- **Greater resources and focus on SAARC instead of BIMSTEC:** BIMSTEC is an inappropriate forum to engage all South Asian nations due to its focus on the Bay of Bengal region.
- **Ease of doing business:** Technology can be used to facilitate freer transit trade, develop supply and logistic chains, use trade lines of credit, increase connectivity, and reduce transaction costs.

CONCLUSION

India needs to find its own prism to view its South Asian neighbourhood as a unit with a common future and as a force multiplier for India's ambitions on the global stage. Reviving SAARC is essential to achieve this goal.

Keywords: Regional Integration, Goldilocks option, regional security architecture, **SAPTA, SAFTA**, Vaccine Maitri programme, Big Brotherly attitude.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	"Increasing cross-border terrorist attacks in India and growing interference in the internal affairs of several member- states by Pakistan are not conducive for the future of SAARC (South Asian Association for Regional Cooperation)." Explain with suitable examples.	(2016)
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BRICS

INTRODUCTION

BRICS is an association of five major and emerging economies consisting of Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa. The term was coined in 2001 by Jim O'Neill, an economist at Goldman Sachs. The BRICS countries represent diverse regions and continents and are characterized by their significant populations, economic potential, and growing global influence. The formation of BRICS aims to promote economic cooperation, political dialogue, and strategic partnerships among its member countries.

FACT-WISE

- Representing around 41% of the global population, 30% of the global tertiary, around 24% of the global GDP, and around 16% of global trade.
- As per the data given by the U.K.-based economic research firm Acorn Macro Consulting the BRICS members comprise 31.5% share of world GDP (PPP) in comparison to 30.7% of G7
- India's total trade with the BRICS countries was \$110 billion in 2019-20 and it rose to \$113.3 billion in 2020-21.

ISSUES AND CHALLENGES OF BRICS

- **Chinese Approach of Unilateralism:** China's effort to dominate group and also admit members who support China's agenda is cause of concern for other member nations.
- **Changing Geopolitical Environment:** since 2017 when the U.S.-China trade war began China has taken anti-West stances but on the other hand India has amicable relations with the West as compared to China and Russia and does not stand to benefit by taking a stance against the West.
- **Trade:** In the grouping, India and China remain the two countries with relatively high growth rates, but trade between the two is marred by several challenges ranging from lack of equal market access in China to non-tariff barriers against Indian products.
- **Lack of Coordination:** Beyond the creation of the NDB, the BRICS have had very little policy coordination to foster their own collective economic growth efforts.
- **Political Differences:** The BRICS countries have different political systems, ideologies, and foreign policy priorities. These differences can sometimes hinder consensus-building and limit the group's ability to take unified positions on global issues.
- **Expanding Membership:** There have been formal and informal membership applications of at least 20 countries. Increased membership may pose a challenge in consensus building.

14TH BRICS SUMMIT

- The 14th BRICS summit was held virtually on June 23, 2022, hosted by China under the theme of "Foster High-quality BRICS Partnership, Usher in a New Era for Global Development".
- **Issues Discussed:**
 - **Global Issues:** The leaders discussed important global issues, such as the reform of the multilateral system, the COVID-19 pandemic, and the global economic recovery, among others.
 - **Strengthening BRICS:** The Prime Minister advocated for the BRICS Identity to be strengthened and proposed the creation of an online database for BRICS papers, a BRICS Railways Research Network, and improved MSMEs cooperation.
 - **'Beijing Declaration':** The coalition is prepared to support the International Committee of the Red Cross's (ICRC) and the UN's initiatives to provide humanitarian relief to Ukraine.

SIGNIFICANCE OF BRICS FOR INDIA

- **Economic Opportunities:** BRICS provides India with a platform to enhance economic cooperation and tap into the vast markets of member countries.

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- **Geopolitical Influence:** Being a member of BRICS enhances India's geopolitical standing on the global stage. It provides India with a platform to voice its concerns, interests, and viewpoints on important global issues, allowing it to shape international agendas.
- **Developmental Cooperation:** BRICS initiatives like the New Development Bank (NDB) provide India with access to financial resources for infrastructure development and sustainable projects.
 - **Example:** NDB has approved 70 infrastructure and sustainable development projects worth USD 25.07 billion (including loans under NDB Emergency Assistance Facility) across all the member countries in the years between 2015-2020. This includes 18 projects in India worth USD 6.9 billion. (As of 2021)
- **Diplomatic Engagement:** BRICS allows India to engage in regular diplomatic dialogues and exchanges with member countries. This engagement strengthens bilateral and multilateral relationships, fostering political and strategic cooperation.
- **Knowledge Sharing And Best Practices:** BRICS offers a platform for knowledge sharing, exchange of best practices, and cooperation in various sectors such as healthcare, education, science, and technology. This collaboration enables India to learn from the experiences of other member countries and implement successful strategies.

WAY FORWARD

- **Enhancing the people-to-people exchanges:** Cultural ties and **people-to-people contact** among BRICS can foster mutual understanding and trust among the members. India can contribute to this aspect by facilitating academic exchanges, tourism, sports, media, arts, etc., among BRICS countries.
- **Diplomatic Engagement:** India can use its diplomatic skills and leadership to coordinate with other BRICS members on various multilateral forums, such as the UN, the G20, the WTO, etc., to protect and promote their common interests.
- **Multisectoral Engagement:** Expanding the scope and depth of cooperation among BRICS in various sectors, such as health, education, science and technology, agriculture, environment, energy, labour, disaster management, anti-corruption, anti-drugs, etc.
- **Enhance Infrastructure Connectivity:** India should actively participate in initiatives aimed at enhancing infrastructure connectivity within the BRICS region. Collaborating on transportation networks, digital connectivity, and energy infrastructure projects can bolster regional integration and trade facilitation.

NEW DEVELOPMENT BANK (NDB)

The New Development Bank (NDB) is a multilateral financial institution established by the BRICS countries (Brazil, Russia, India, China, and South Africa) to support infrastructure and sustainable development projects in emerging economies. It aims to provide an alternative source of funding for infrastructure development and promote economic cooperation among its member nations.

ISSUES ASSOCIATED

- **Capitalization and Resources:** Ensuring sufficient capital contributions from member countries and attracting other investors are ongoing challenges for the NDB, affecting its ability to finance projects effectively.
- **Project Pipeline and Implementation:** The NDB needs to identify and prioritize a robust pipeline of projects, conduct rigorous due diligence, and ensure efficient project implementation to avoid delays and cost overruns.
- **Governance and Decision-making:** Balancing decision-making processes among diverse member countries, ensuring transparency, and effective governance mechanisms are key challenges for the NDB.
- **Coordination with Other Institutions:** Ensuring effective coordination with other multilateral development banks and financial institutions to avoid duplication of efforts and leverage complementary strengths is essential for the NDB.

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RECENT EXPANSION OF THE GROUPING

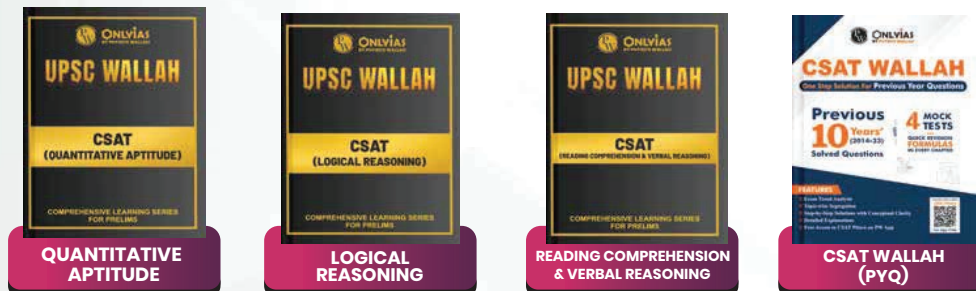
The 15th BRICS summit held in Johannesburg has been concluded. The most significant outcome of this summit has been the expansion of BRICS, making it BRICS-Plus. 6 new countries have been added to the grouping, i.e., Argentina, Egypt, Ethiopia, Saudi Arabia, Iran and UAE.

CONCLUSION

Strengthening ties with BRICS nations can provide India with increased market access, investment opportunities, and diplomatic leverage. It is crucial for India to actively participate in BRICS initiatives, foster collaboration in key areas such as infrastructure development, and contribute to sustainable and inclusive growth within the association.

Keywords: Unilateralism, emerging economies, non-tariff barriers, 'Beijing Declaration, New Development Bank, Emergency Assistance Facility.

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BAY OF BENGAL INITIATIVE FOR MULTI-SECTORAL TECHNICAL AND ECONOMIC COOPERATION

BIMSTEC, short for Bay of Bengal Initiative for Multi-Sectoral Technical and Economic Cooperation, is a regional organisation comprising seven member countries located in the Bay of Bengal region. The member countries are Bangladesh, Bhutan, India, Myanmar, Nepal, Sri Lanka, and Thailand. BIMSTEC was established in 1997.

PRINCIPLES OF BIMSTEC

Cooperation within the BIMSTEC will be based on respect for the principle of sovereign equality, territorial integrity, political independence, non-interference in internal affairs, non-aggression, peaceful co-existence, mutual respect and mutual benefit.

FACT-WISE

The BIMSTEC region hosts 22% of the world population or 1.68 billion people; and the member states have a combined GDP of US\$3.697 trillion/year.

IMPORTANCE OF BIMSTEC FOR INDIA

- **In Align with 'Act East' Policy:** For India, BIMSTEC plays a major role to fulfil 'Act East' policy for greater regional cooperation in southeast Asia.
- **Environment and Disaster Management:**
 - **Sharing data:** India has also set up a link between BIMSTEC countries through Tsunami Early Warning Centre and has been sharing data from the Tsunami Early Warning Centre since 2006.
- **Strategic Location:** India's north eastern states share borders with BIMSTEC member countries, making it a key player in the regional dynamics.
- **Connectivity and Infrastructure Development:** Improved transport networks, cross-border connectivity, and energy cooperation can facilitate smoother movement of goods, services, and people between India and other member countries.
 - Examples of Connectivity Projects:
 - Kaladan Multimodal Project – links India and Myanmar.
 - Asian Trilateral Highway - connecting India and Thailand through Myanmar.
 - Bangladesh-Bhutan-India-Nepal (BBIN) Motor Vehicles Agreement - for seamless flow of passenger and cargo traffic.
- **Counterterrorism and Security Cooperation:** BIMSTEC provides an avenue for member countries to address common security challenges, including terrorism and transnational crime.
- **Maritime Security and Blue Economy:** BIMSTEC provides a platform for member countries to collaborate on maritime issues, including maritime security, disaster management, and sustainable development of the blue economy.
- **Regional Integration and Influence:** BIMSTEC offers India an opportunity to contribute to regional integration efforts in the Bay of Bengal region. By actively engaging with other member countries, India can play a leadership role in shaping the organization's agenda, promoting regional cooperation, and exerting its influence in the region.

ISSUES

- **Slow Progress:** A lack of efficiency and "sluggish" pace of BIMSTEC's progress.
- **Inadequate Funds:** BIMSTEC secretariat faces the issue of inadequate financial and manpower assistance for its operational works.
- **No Coastal Shipment:** BIMSTEC members have still not built a lucrative and shared coastal shipment ecosystem and also face detention of fishermen frequently who cross territorial borders.
- **Low Trade:** India's percentage of annual trade with BIMSTEC countries as a percentage of its total foreign trade was in the double digits in the 1950s, but was just 4% as of 2020.

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- **Lack of Mutual Cooperation and Trust:** it was also seen that a lot of the time, BIMSTEC member countries don't import goods that are manufactured and exported by other members, instead importing from other non-member countries.
- **Inconsistency In Summits:** Only five summits have been taken place in 25 years. Meanwhile, 18 ministerial meets have taken place so far; and between 2014 and 2017, the Senior Officials' meeting was postponed seven times.

WAY FORWARD

- **Finalizing the BIMSTEC Free Trade Agreement (FTA)**, which has been under negotiation since 2004. The FTA can boost the intra-regional trade and investment among the members and provide a big market for Indian companies.
- **Implementing the BIMSTEC Master Plan on Transport Connectivity (BMPTC)**, which was adopted in 2020. The BMPTC can improve the physical and digital connectivity among the members and facilitate the movement of goods and people.
- **Strengthening the cooperation** in the energy sector, especially in the field of renewable energy and natural gas. BIMSTEC has great potential in this sector as it has abundant resources such as solar, wind, hydro and biomass energy.
- **Enhancing the cooperation** in the security sector, especially in combating terrorism, extremism, drug trafficking and cybercrime. BIMSTEC has established a security dialogue mechanism and a counter-terrorism center to address these issues.
- **Promoting the people-to-people exchanges and cultural ties** among BIMSTEC countries, which can foster mutual understanding and trust among the members

CONCLUSION

India's active engagement with BIMSTEC can foster trade and investment, enhance connectivity, promote cultural exchanges, and address common security challenges. By strengthening its ties with BIMSTEC member countries, India can play a crucial role in shaping the organization's agenda, contributing to regional stability, and fostering sustainable development in the Bay of Bengal region.

Keywords: Territorial integrity, peaceful co-existence, Act East' policy, cross-border connectivity, **Maritime Security, Blue Economy.**

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Do you think that BIMSTEC is a parallel organisation like the SAARC? What are the similarities and dissimilarities between the two? How are Indian foreign policy objectives realized by forming this new organisation?	2022
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SHANGHAI COOPERATION ORGANIZATION (SCO)

- The Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) is a permanent intergovernmental organization established by the SCO Charter, signed in June 2002 and entering into force in September 2003.
- The SCO currently comprises nine member states: China, India, Kazakhstan, the Kyrgyz Republic, Pakistan, Russia, Tajikistan, Uzbekistan and Iran.

OBJECTIVES AND PRINCIPLES

- To deal with extremism, radicalism, drug trafficking and counter terrorism.
- **Promote economic security** by trade, connectivity and financial inclusion.
- Its aim was to counter the USA and **showcase eastern values** of mutual respect and plurality.
- SCO consist almost One third of the global GDP and 40 percent of the global population.
- It is based on the **SHANGHAI SPIRIT** of good neighbourliness which include non-interference, consensus, harmony, respect for culture and non-alignment.

INDIA'S STRATEGIC GAINS FROM THE SCO

- **Enhanced Standing:** India's SCO membership signifies its status as a major power with interests beyond the Asian continent. This elevates India's profile in Eurasian affairs.
- **Countering Alliances:** The SCO allows India to leverage its ties with Russia, Iran, and Central Asian Republics (CARs) to counter the China-Pakistan alliance.
- **Connectivity Boost:** Participation in SCO initiatives like the Eurasian Economic Union (EEU) and the International North-South Transport Corridor (INSTC) fosters regional connectivity and improves India's access to trade routes.
- **Security Collaboration:** The SCO offers a platform for international and regional counterterrorism initiatives. It also facilitates measures to combat drug trafficking through intelligence sharing via the Regional Anti-Terrorist Structure (RATS).
- **Geopolitical Engagement:** The SCO provides India with a forum to engage with major regional powers like China and Russia on various geopolitical issues. This strengthens India's position as a champion of a multilateral global order.

India's membership in the SCO brings strategic advantages, enhancing its standing, fostering regional cooperation, and bolstering its security posture.

SCO Summit 2022: Key Outcomes

The 22nd Meeting of the Shanghai Cooperation Organisation (SCO) Council of Heads of State convened in Samarkand, Uzbekistan. Here's a summary of the key developments:

- **Leadership Transition:** India assumed the SCO presidency and hosted the 2023 summit.
- **Expanded Membership:** Iran gained acceptance as a permanent member.
- **Cultural Spotlight:** Varanasi was designated as the SCO Tourism and Cultural Capital for 2022-2023.
- **Samarkand Declaration:** Member states adopted a joint declaration outlining their cooperation goals.

India's Initiatives:

- **Food Security:** India championed promoting millets to address global food security concerns.
- **Traditional Medicine:** India proposed a new SCO working group to focus on traditional medicine.

KEY TERMS: Counter terrorism, extremism, promote economic security, Shanghai Spirit - geopolitical engagement, Samarkand Declaration, India's initiatives

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	'Virus of Conflict is affecting the functioning of the SCO'. In the light of the above statement point out the role of India in mitigating problems. (10 Marks)	2023
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INDIA AND QUAD

INTRODUCTION

The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue, or Quad, is a strategic forum uniting four democracies in the Indo-Pacific: the United States, Japan, Australia, and India. Initially formed in 2007, the Quad has seen a resurgence in recent years, emerging as a platform for dialogue and collaboration on shared concerns.

IMPORTANCE OF QUAD

The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD) offers a range of benefits for its member countries:

- **Free and Open Indo-Pacific:** Upholding international law, respecting sovereignty, ensuring freedom of navigation, and promoting peaceful dispute resolution are core principles the QUAD champions in the region.
- **Economic Prosperity:** The QUAD fosters economic cooperation by aligning trade and investment policies, promoting infrastructure development, and facilitating connectivity, ultimately driving regional growth and opportunities.
- **Collective Security:** Through information sharing, joint military exercises, and coordinated strategies, the QUAD tackles shared security threats like maritime security, terrorism, and weapons proliferation.
- **Disaster Resilience:** Combining resources and expertise enables the QUAD to provide effective humanitarian assistance and disaster response in the Indo-Pacific.
- **Promoting Democracy:** Shared democratic values, human rights, and the rule of law bind the QUAD members, who work together to strengthen these principles in the region.

The Quad: A Counterweight to China's Influence?

The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) emerges as a potential counterbalance to China's growing assertiveness in the Indo-Pacific region.

- **Security Cooperation:** Joint military exercises and patrols by Quad members signal their commitment to upholding international law and freedom of navigation in the region, potentially deterring Chinese attempts to restrict access to key waterways.
- **Economic Resilience:** Recognizing the need for a less China-centric economic landscape, the Quad countries aim to build stronger, more diversified supply chains, particularly in critical sectors like technology and pharmaceuticals.

ISSUES

The Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (Quad) faces several hurdles in solidifying its position as a regional counterbalance to China.

- **Dependency on China:** All Quad members, particularly Australia with 38% of its exports going to China, have significant economic ties with China, creating a complex dynamic.
- **Uneven Strength:** The four members possess varying military and economic capabilities, potentially leading to imbalances and differing expectations regarding contributions.
- **Divergent Focus:** India prioritises security concerns in the Indian Ocean Region, while the other three members lean towards the Pacific. This lack of a unified geographical focus can hinder cooperation.
- **China Taboo:** The Quad hesitates to explicitly name China as its primary strategic concern due to economic interdependence.

WAY FORWARD

Despite these challenges, the Quad can strengthen its position through the following strategies:

- **Diversifying Trade:** Efforts to reduce economic reliance on China and forge stronger trade partnerships with other countries would lessen vulnerability.
- **Focus on Shared Interests:** Prioritizing areas of mutual concern, such as maritime security, humanitarian assistance, and counter-terrorism, can foster a sense of common purpose.

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- **Interoperability and Joint Exercises:** Regular military exercises and increased interoperability between Quad forces can enhance collective defense capabilities.
- **Open Communication:** Addressing concerns about burden-sharing and openly discussing China's assertiveness can build trust and transparency within the Quad.
- **Quad Plus:**
 - The membership can be increased to include countries like Vietnam, New Zealand, South Korea etc, who share similar interests.
 - European countries UK and France who have naval bases in the region can also be incorporated in expanded QUAD.
- **Address Non-Traditional Security Challenges:** The Quad should actively collaborate on addressing non-traditional security challenges, such as climate change, maritime security, cyber threats, and public health crises.

KEY TERMS: Indo-Pacific Region, Collective Security, Counterweight to China's Influence, Uneven Strength, Diversifying Trade, Quad Plus.

ISSUES IN NEWS

THE 2023 QUAD SUMMIT

Context: The recent Quad Summit in Hiroshima yielded significant outcomes aimed at boosting regional infrastructure and connectivity.

Key Initiatives:

- **Infrastructure Expertise:** The "Quad Infrastructure Fellowships Programme" will empower policymakers in designing and managing sustainable infrastructure projects.
- **Undersea Cable Partnership:** The "Partnership for Cable Connectivity and Resilience" leverages combined expertise for building and maintaining undersea cables, vital for communication and internet access.
- **OpenRAN Deployment:** Quad support for a pilot Open Radio Access Network (ORAN) project in Palau paves the way for innovative and secure communication solutions in the Pacific.

India's hosting of the next Quad Summit in 2024 underscores the group's growing importance for regional cooperation and development.

STRENGTHENING THE QUAD ACT

The U.S. House of Representatives recently passed the "Strengthening the Quad Act," signaling a commitment to closer cooperation between the United States, Australia, India, and Japan (Quad).

Key Provisions of the Act:

- **Enhanced Collaboration:** The Act establishes a Quad Intra-Parliamentary Working Group to facilitate closer ties on issues of mutual interest in the Indo-Pacific region.
- **Regular Engagement:** Guidelines for annual meetings and group leadership ensure consistent communication and collaboration.
- **Focus Areas:** The Act directs the U.S. Secretary of State to develop a strategy for bolstering cooperation in critical areas like pandemic preparedness, technological innovation, and economic integration.

CONCLUSION

Through their collaboration within the Quad, these countries aim to shape regional developments, safeguard their interests, and contribute to a peaceful, stable, and prosperous Indo-Pacific region.

KEY TERMS: 2023 Quad Summit, Infrastructure Expertise, Undersea Cable Partnership, OpenRAN Deployment, Enhanced Collaboration, Regular Engagement

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Quadrilateral Security Dialogue (QUAD)' is the transforming itself into a trade bloc from a military alliance, in present times – Discuss.	2020
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NORTH ATLANTIC TREATY ORGANIZATION (NATO)

INTRODUCTION

- NATO is a military alliance founded in 1949 by the US, Canada, and Western European states to offer collective protection against the Soviet Union. Currently, there are 32 member countries. Since its founding, Greece, Turkey, West Germany, Spain, and several eastern European nations have joined the alliance.

THE OBJECTIVES OF NATO

- **Guiding Principle:**
 - **Collective Defense:** NATO's central purpose is to safeguard the freedom and security of its members through a collective defense approach.
- **Dual Track Strategy:**
 - **Political Collaboration:** NATO promotes democratic values and fosters communication among members on security threats. This collaborative approach aims to prevent conflict through diplomacy and trust-building.
 - **Military Capability:** NATO maintains a strong military force for crisis management operations. Intervention can occur under Article 5 (collective defense) or under UN mandates, working independently or alongside other international partners. NATO has only used Article 5 once, on September 12, 2001, in response to the 9/11 attacks on the World Trade Center in New York.

CONCERNS REGARDING NATO EXPANSION

- **Weakened Alliance?** Critics argue that expanding NATO could:
 - **Strain Unity:** A larger alliance might struggle to reach consensus and weaken its commitment to collective defense (Article V).
 - **Leave Some Exposed:** Continual expansion might leave some hopeful members, like Ukraine, feeling insecure without full membership.
- **Financial Burden:** The costs of expansion are significant, with estimates reaching \$35 billion by 2010. The US shoulders a substantial portion of these expenses.
- **Diverted Focus:** Some argue that resources devoted to expansion could be better directed towards NATO's core objectives or strengthening existing partnerships like the Partnership for Peace.
- **Potential for Conflict:** Expanding NATO eastward might heighten tensions with Russia, potentially leading to new conflicts

INDIA AND NATO: A SHIFTING RELATIONSHIP

HISTORICAL RELUCTANCE

- **Strategic Blindspot:** India hasn't prioritized strategic engagement with Europe, focusing more on its relationship with Russia.
- **Post-Cold War Inertia:** Following the Soviet collapse, India failed to adapt its European policy to the new landscape.
- **Russia-Centric Approach:** India's European policy remained heavily influenced by its ties with Russia.

TOWARDS ENGAGEMENT

- **De-hyphenating Relationships:** India has begun to independently develop relations with European nations, moving beyond its Russia-centric approach.
- **Countering Neglect:** Increased engagement is evident in initiatives like maritime cooperation with France and summits with Nordic and Visegrad Four nations.

WHY ENGAGE NOW?

- **Cold War Legacy:** India's non-alignment policy during the Cold War is no longer a relevant reason to avoid NATO.
- **Dialogue, Not Alliance:** Engagement with NATO doesn't necessitate formal membership, but rather fosters cooperation with key European security partners.
- **Strategic Convergence:** Both India and NATO share concerns about China's rise, making cooperation beneficial.
- **Russia's Shifting Alliances:** India's concerns about Russia's growing ties with China can be balanced by a stronger European partnership

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RUSSIA'S ROLE

- **Opposition Expected:** Russia's disapproval of India's growing ties with the West is well-known.
- **Hedging Bets:** India recognizes the need to maintain its relationship with Russia while engaging with other partners.
- **Converging Interests:** Both India and Russia understand the importance of safeguarding their bilateral ties amidst global shifts.
- **Europe's Need:** Europe requires partners like India to play a meaningful role in the Indo-Pacific.

NATO'S RELEVANCE IN A CHANGING WORLD

- **Adapting to New Threats:** NATO actively confronts emerging security threats:
 - Condemning Russia's aggression in Ukraine and supporting Ukrainian sovereignty.
 - Countering terrorism through operations in Afghanistan and support for the anti-ISIS coalition.
 - NATO's longevity and expanding membership demonstrate its continued importance.
- **Beyond Military Means:** NATO displayed agility in responding to the COVID-19 pandemic by protecting personnel, delivering medical supplies, and fostering innovative solutions.
- **Shifting Focus: The Indo-Pacific:** Recent decisions signal NATO's potential eastward expansion, aiming to establish peace and stability in the Asia-Pacific region. China's inclusion in NATO documents acknowledges its growing influence. Engaging with Indo-Pacific nations like Australia, Japan, New Zealand, and South Korea highlights NATO's evolving role in addressing global challenges.

ISSUES IN NEWS

75 YEARS OF NATO AND SWEDEN'S ACCESSION

- **Context:** The North Atlantic Treaty Organization (NATO) recently celebrated its 75th anniversary. Marking this milestone, Sweden formally joined the alliance as its 32nd member.

RECENT NATO SUMMIT 2023

- **Context:** The latest 2023 NATO summit held in Vilnius, Lithuania underscored the new reason for strengthening and expanding the alliance.

Key Outcomes of the Summit:

- **Bolstering Ukraine:** The launch of the NATO-Ukraine Council signifies a commitment to cooperation and support for Ukraine in the face of ongoing challenges.
- **Expanded Alliance:** Finland and Sweden's accession to NATO underscores the alliance's resolve to expand its membership and deter potential threats, particularly from Russia.
- **U.S. Recommitment:** President Biden's firm stance on NATO and Ukraine contrasts with the previous administration's approach, solidifying American support for the alliance.
- **China's Ascending Threat:** The summit acknowledged China's growing influence, including its malicious cyber activities, aggressive rhetoric, and disinformation campaigns, recognizing them as threats to Euro-Atlantic security.
- **Persistent Tensions:** Russia's drone attack on Kyiv during the summit underscores the ongoing security concerns in Eurasia, despite discussions of NATO's potential expansion.

CONCLUSION

India's approach to NATO is evolving. While historical factors shaped its initial stance, the strategic landscape is changing. Engaging with NATO offers opportunities for dialogue and cooperation without compromising India's core interest.

KEY TERMS: Collective Defense, Political Collaboration & Diplomacy, Military Capability & Crisis Management, Potential Conflict with Russia.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	'The expansion and strengthening of NATO and a stronger US-Europe strategic partnership works well in India.' What is your opinion about this statement? Give reasons and examples to support your answer. (15 Marks)	(2023)
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INDIA AND G-20

INTRODUCTION

- The G20, or Group of 20, is a key international forum for cooperation on major issues affecting the global economy. It brings together the world's largest economies which includes, 19 countries plus the European Union, to discuss and formulate policies on matters like financial stability, climate change, and sustainable development.

G20'S ROLE AND FOCUS

- **Shaping Global Governance:** The G20 plays a critical role in **shaping and fortifying** global economic structures and governance across major international economic issues.
- **Broadened Agenda:** The G20 has expanded its focus to encompass a wider range of issues, including trade, sustainable development, health, agriculture, energy, environment, climate change, and anti-corruption.
- **Promoting Gender Equality:** The G20 has a specific focus on closing the gender gap in the workforce, aiming for a 25% reduction in the disparity by 2025.
- **Strengthening Diplomacy:** G20 summits provide a platform for bilateral meetings between leaders, fostering international cooperation and agreements.
- **Steering the Agenda:** The G20 Presidency guides the group's agenda for one year and hosts the Summit. This leadership is supported by the Troika, consisting of the previous, current, and incoming presidencies. During India's term, the Troika was Indonesia, India, and Brazil.

G20'S CHALLENGES

- **Divided Vision:** Differing priorities and interests among member countries can hinder consensus on critical issues and create roadblocks to unified action.
- **Limited Authority:** Lacking legal enforcement power, the G20 relies on member cooperation, making it vulnerable to geopolitical tensions and conflicting agendas.
- **Falling Short:** The G20 has been criticized for its perceived ineffectiveness in tackling major global challenges like climate change and economic inequality.
- **Transparency Deficit:** The G20 operates with limited public oversight and accountability, raising concerns about its decision-making processes.
- **Protectionist Pressures:** The rise of protectionism and trade conflicts between major economies further complicates the G20's ability to achieve global solutions.

WAY FORWARD

- **Embrace Inclusivity:** Actively engage non-member countries and diverse stakeholders to ensure a more representative and responsive forum.
- **Focus on Collaboration:** Transcend traditional alliances and encourage collective action on a range of issues.
- **Deliver on Commitments:** Leaders must translate their promises into concrete actions to solidify the G20's credibility.
- **Ensure Continuity:** Maintain focus on long-term goals and prioritize sustained action on critical issues across presidencies.

KEY TERMS: Global Economic Cooperation (G20), Diplomacy & International Cooperation
G20 Presidency & Troika, Protectionist Pressures, Collaboration & Collective Action,

INDIA AND G20

India recently held the presidency of the G20 forum from December 2022 to November 2023. This was a significant moment, marking India's role as a major player in the global economy. During its presidency, India focused on areas like sustainable development, climate change, and inclusive growth, reflecting its priorities for the future, manifesting the true spirit of '**Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam**' or the 'World is One Family'.

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PRIORITIES SET BY INDIA'S PRESIDENCY

India's G20 presidency prioritised several key areas to promote global well-being:

- **Green Development & Sustainability:** India champions the implementation of the UN's Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) through a dedicated G20 Action Plan.
- **LiFE & Climate Finance:** The "Lifestyle for Environment" (LiFE) initiative, coupled with the G20 High-Level Principles on Sustainable Development, aims to transform our approach to climate change and environmental challenges.
- **Inclusive & Resilient Growth:** India advocates for economic growth that benefits all, ensuring inclusivity and fostering resilience in a rapidly changing world.
- **Digital Transformation & Infrastructure:** Investment in digital solutions and public digital infrastructure is crucial for progress in the 21st century.
- **Revitalizing Multilateralism:** India calls for reforms in international institutions like the WTO and WHO to strengthen global cooperation.
- **Empowering Women:** India's G20 agenda shifts the focus from development for women to women-led development, promoting their leadership in shaping a better future.

India Pushes for Global Crypto Regulation under G20 Presidency

- **India's Stance:** India's Finance Minister, leading the G20 presidency, advocates for a **coordinated global regulatory framework** for cryptocurrencies and similar assets. This approach is supported by the US Treasury Secretary.
- **RBI's Concerns:** However, the Reserve Bank of India (RBI) favors a **complete ban** on cryptocurrencies due to potential risks to financial stability.
- **Collaboration for a Solution:** To facilitate a unified global approach, the RBI and the Financial Stability Board are working on a **technical paper**.

India's leadership role within the G20 presents an opportunity to establish a collaborative international framework for addressing the challenges and opportunities presented by cryptocurrencies.

SIGNIFICANCE OF THE PRESIDENCY

- **Promoting Peace and Security:** India's G20 presidency is seen as a potential forum for mediating peace between Russia and Ukraine, solidifying its position as a global peacemaker.
- **Championing the Global South:** As part of a G20 troika led by developing nations, India has a unique platform to address the concerns of the Global South, fostering development and promoting a more equitable world order.
- **Fostering North-South Collaboration:** India and the EU can utilize the G20 as a platform to showcase successful North-South collaboration on issues like reformed multilateralism, climate action, and the Ukraine conflict.
- **Leading in a Time of Crisis:** India's G20 presidency takes place at a critical juncture. The world grapples with the aftermath of the pandemic and the ongoing war in Ukraine. India's leadership offers a much-needed opportunity for global cooperation.
- **Strengthening Global Health:** India's presidency presents an opportunity to tackle global health challenges. Sharing its digital health infrastructure, like CoWIN, can help other nations.
- **Addressing Development Needs:** India can advocate for the pressing needs of developing countries, small island nations, and those facing economic hardship.
- **Boosting Regional Cooperation:** India's G20 presidency holds economic significance for BIMSTEC nations, strengthening regional ties and aligning with India's "Neighbourhood First" and "Act East" policies.

KEY ACHIEVEMENTS OF INDIA'S PRESIDENCY

- **Championing Africa:** India highlighted the specific development challenges faced by African nations within the G20 forum.
- **Inclusive Engagement:** Following the principle of "Jan Bhagidari" (citizen participation), India actively engaged youth, women, businesses, and civil society in G20 discussions.
- **Global Collaboration:** Guided by the concept of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" (the world is one family), India emphasized global cooperation for a sustainable future.

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- **Kashmir Showcase:** The G20 meeting's location in Kashmir highlighted the region's tourism potential while upholding India's position on the issue.
- **Voice for the Global South:** India advocated for the needs of developing nations, promoting equal access to resources and a just world order.

ISSUES IN NEWS

INCLUSION OF AFRICAN UNION (AU) IN G20

The African Union (AU) has become a permanent member of the G20, marking a significant shift in global governance.

Benefits for the G20:

- **Harnessing Africa's Potential:** The AU brings Africa's vast renewable energy resources and critical minerals to the table, aiding in climate change mitigation.
- **Enhanced Credibility:** The AU's inclusion broadens the G20's reach, fostering more inclusive and globally impactful solutions.
- **A More Representative Body:** The G20 is now more reflective of the global community, strengthening its image as a champion for a fairer and more sustainable world.

Benefits for Africa:

- **Greater Influence:** The AU gains a stronger voice in shaping global discussions on issues like tax, debt, and climate change.
- **Shifting the Narrative:** This inclusion signifies Africa's growing economic and political importance, moving beyond a perception of a continent solely facing challenges.
- **Active Participation:** The AU can now actively participate in discussions that directly impact Africa's future, becoming a key contributor rather than a passive recipient.

Benefits for India:

- **Champion of the Global South:** India's advocacy for the AU solidifies its position as a leader for developing nations.
- **Alignment with Global Goals:** This move aligns with India's vision for a multipolar world and a more equitable international order.
- **Potential for Support:** India's backing for the AU could translate into AU support for India's aspirations for a permanent UN Security Council seat.

The AU's inclusion in the G20 represents a new era of collaboration. It offers a platform for Africa to contribute more actively to shaping its own future and for the G20 to address global challenges with a more inclusive perspective.

CONCLUSION

India's G20 Presidency focused on promoting global good, fostering inclusive engagement, and advocating for the Global South. By prioritising collaboration and highlighting critical issues, India aimed to shape a more equitable and sustainable future for all.

KEY TERMS: Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam, LiFE Initiative, Multilateralism Reform (WTO, WHO), North-South Collaboration (EU), Regional Cooperation (Neighbourhood First), Inclusive Engagement (Jan Bhagidari), Voice for the Global South (Equal Access & Just World Order)

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G-7

The G7 is a group of seven major advanced economies: Canada, France, Germany, Italy, Japan, the United Kingdom, and the United States. They meet annually to discuss and coordinate policies on global issues like trade, security, climate change, and economic development.

ROLE OF G7

The Group of Seven (G7) plays a pivotal role in addressing critical issues facing the world. Here's a breakdown of its key functions:

- **Global Leadership:** The G7 sets the stage for tackling major global challenges with its combined economic and political influence.
- **Collective Action:** It acts as a catalyst, influencing discussions and fostering collaboration on pressing issues like climate change and security threats.
- **Broadening Participation:** The G7 paves the way for broader international action by initiating discussions that are later addressed by more inclusive forums.
- **Addressing Emergent Crises:** The group is adept at responding to emerging global crises, as evidenced by its recent efforts regarding the COVID-19 pandemic and the war in Ukraine.

**G7 in numbers**

7 member countries
1975 first meeting of the group of six
40% of global GDP
1/10 of world's population
2014 Russia suspended over annexation of Crimea

INDIA AND G7

India and the G7 are engaging in a closer relationship. While not a member, India has been invited to recent summits as a guest due to its economic rise and growing importance on the world stage. This cooperation offers mutual benefits: India can learn from G7 expertise, and the G7 can tap into India's vast market and influence.

IMPORTANCE OF G7 FOR INDIA

- **Global Voice:** Participation allows India to contribute to solutions for global challenges on behalf of the developing world.
- **Global Problem-Solving:** G7 discussions tackle critical global issues where India's expertise can be valuable.
- **Democratic Leadership:** India's presence showcases its commitment to democratic values, contrasting with authoritarian powers.
- **Bridging the Gap:** India acts as a vital link between developed nations and developing countries, fostering collaboration.
- **Strategic Insight:** India gains valuable insights into the perspectives of major powers on critical global issues.

WHY INDIA MATTERS TO THE G7

- **Global Player:** India's economic and military strength positions it as a key player on the world stage.
- **Responsible Leadership:** India offers a counterpoint to China, promoting a rules-based international order.
- **Economic Powerhouse:** India's sizable GDP rivals established G7 economies.
- **Balancing the Global Order:** The G7 sees India as a potential counterweight to China's growing influence.
- **Economic Powerhouse:** India's booming economy makes it an attractive partner for trade and investment.
- **Indo-Pacific Anchor:** India's strategic importance in the Indo-Pacific region aligns with G7 interests.
- **Global South Voice:** India's inclusion strengthens the G7's connection to developing nations.

CONCLUSION

- The G7 and India offer a mutually beneficial partnership. India's contributions and growing influence are valued by the G7, while India gains a platform to shape global discourse and build strategic alliances. This collaboration can contribute to a more stable and prosperous future.

KEY TERMS: India-G7 Relationship, Guest Participation, Global Influence, Global Voice, Global Player, Responsible Leadership, Economic Power, Security Concerns, Geopolitical Alignment.

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WORLD BANK GROUP AND INDIA

INTRODUCTION

- The World Bank is a large international financial institution that works to fight poverty by offering loans and grants to developing countries.
- It's part of a five-institution group called the World Bank Group, which also focuses on private sector development, investment guarantees, and settling investment disputes.
- The World Bank plays a major role in global development efforts through its financing, advice, and research.
- It has **189 member countries**.

STRUCTURE OF WORLD BANK

Name Of The Institution	Mandate	Is India A Member Or Not
The International Bank for Reconstruction and Development (IBRD)	Provides debt financing to governments of middle-income and low-income but credit-worthy countries.	Yes.
The International Development Association (IDA)	Provides interest-free loans called credits and grants to governments of the poorest countries.	Yes.
The International Finance Corporation (IFC)	It is the largest global development institution focused exclusively on the private sector.	Yes.
The Multilateral Investment Guarantee Agency (MIGA)	Promotes foreign direct investment into developing countries to support economic growth, reduce poverty, and improve people's lives.	Yes.
The International Centre for Settlement of Investment Disputes (ICSID)	Provides international facilities for conciliation and arbitration of investment disputes.	No. India isn't a member.

MAIN FUNCTIONS OF THE WORLD BANK

- **Financial Support:** Provides member countries with low-cost loans, grants, and even interest-free credits to fuel their economic development.
- **Sustainable Development Champion:** Played a significant role in formulating the Sustainable Development Goals (SDGs) and actively works towards achieving them, aligning with its own goals of ending poverty and promoting shared prosperity.
- **Knowledge Sharing:** Collaborates with public and private entities by offering policy advice, research analysis, and technical assistance. This expertise and training benefit both public and private sectors.

WORLD BANK AND INDIA

- **Foundational Ties:** India played a key role in establishing the World Bank, participating in the Bretton Woods Conference and even proposing its original name.
- **Supporting India's Growth:** The World Bank has consistently supported India's development journey since its inception.
- **Responding to Crisis:** In the face of the COVID-19 pandemic, the World Bank partnered with the Indian government and other stakeholders to:
 - Address critical needs across healthcare, social programs, and the economy.
 - Provide emergency funding of \$2.75 billion to aid India's COVID-19 response.

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RECENT DEVELOPMENT BETWEEN THE WORLD BANK AND INDIA

The World Bank and India have a strong partnership focused on development across various sectors. Here are some facets of their recent collaborations:

- **Education:** Improved access to quality primary and secondary education, particularly for girls. Additionally, supported skill development initiatives.
- **Social Sector:** Provided financial aid to mitigate the impact of COVID-19 and empowered women through skill development programs.
- **Health:** Proposed significant funding to strengthen healthcare infrastructure and fight pandemics. Notably, contributed to a significant reduction in new HIV infections and supported tuberculosis treatment programs.
- **Nutrition:** Reached millions of pregnant and lactating women with vital support since 2015.
- **Energy:** Collaborated on setting up large-scale solar power projects in Madhya Pradesh.
- **Infrastructure:** Contributed significantly to rural water supply and sanitation projects.
- **Logistics:** India's ranking in the World Bank's Logistics Performance Index has improved.

CHALLENGES AND OPPORTUNITIES

The World Bank's report on Indian cities highlighted the need for increased investment in urban infrastructure to accommodate rapid population growth. Challenges include attracting private finance and improving municipal revenue collection. The report recommends strengthening city finances and creditworthiness.

CHALLENGES WITH WBG

The World Bank (WBG) faces criticism for several shortcomings:

- **Unbalanced Representation:** Developing nations have less say in decision-making due to voting structures.
- **Loan Conditionalities:** Loan terms can compromise borrower nations' sovereignty by imposing economic policies and practices.
- **Implementation Gap:** The WBG struggles to implement recommendations for improvement from its own evaluation bodies.
- **Unsustainable Growth Model:** The WBG's focus on economic growth without considering environmental or social impact can be detrimental in the long run.
- **Large Project Bias:** Large-scale projects attract investors but often lack alignment with climate goals and can displace communities.

WAY FORWARD

To address these challenges, the WBG can consider several reforms:

- **Revamping Representation:** Ensure a more equitable voice for developing nations in decision-making processes.
- **Flexible Loan Conditions:** Design loan terms that prioritize borrower countries' needs while maintaining financial responsibility.
- **Prioritizing Sustainability:** Integrate environmental and social impact assessments into project evaluations to promote sustainable development.
- **Supporting Smaller Projects:** Allocate resources to smaller-scale initiatives that can have a significant impact at the local level.
- **Building Partnerships:** Collaborate with other institutions and NGOs to leverage expertise and resources for a more holistic approach to development.

By implementing these changes, the WBG can become a more effective and responsible actor in fostering global development.

KEY TERMS: Financial support, Loan Conditionalities, Global Challenges, Collective Solutions, Sustainable Development, Peacekeeping, Human Rights, Global Health

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WORLD TRADE ORGANIZATION AND INDIA

- The World Trade Organization (WTO) is the world's **central organization for international trade**.
- Established in **1995**, it represents the culmination of previous agreements like the **General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT)**.
- With **164 member countries**, encompassing over 98% of global trade, the WTO serves as a forum for negotiating and enforcing trade agreements.
- Its core **objective** is to ensure smooth, predictable, and free-flowing international trade.

GENERAL AGREEMENT ON TRADE AND TARIFFS (GATT)

The General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) played a pivotal role in shaping international trade after World War II. Established in 1948, it became the primary framework for trade regulations until the World Trade Organization (WTO) assumed its responsibilities in 1995.

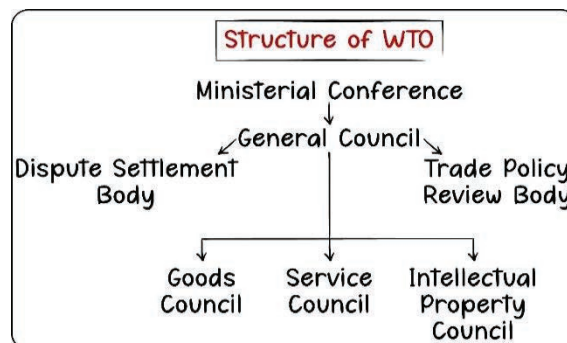
- **Limitations of GATT:** Despite its contributions, GATT had limitations:
 - **Limited Scope:** GATT primarily focused on reducing tariffs and quotas on goods, lacking the authority to address trade in services or intellectual property.
 - **Institutional Shortcomings:** GATT operated as a set of agreements without a formal institutional structure, hindering enforcement and dispute resolution.

The Rise of the WTO: The WTO addressed these shortcomings by establishing a comprehensive legal framework governing trade in goods, services, and intellectual property. It also created a permanent institutional structure to oversee trade agreements and resolve disputes between member countries.

FUNCTIONS OF WTO

The WTO serves as a central hub for promoting international trade through various functions:

- **Enforcing Trade Agreements:** The WTO ensures member countries follow their commitments under trade deals. This includes preventing unfair practices like preferential treatment for specific countries.
- **Negotiating Trade Deals:** It provides a framework for countries to negotiate trade agreements and establish dispute resolution mechanisms. (e.g., agreements on agriculture and intellectual property)
- **Resolving Trade Disputes:** The WTO offers a forum for settling trade disputes between member states through formal hearings. (e.g., disputes over agricultural subsidies)
- **Promoting Trade Flow:** It establishes a legal framework for the smooth exchange of goods and services across borders.
- **Building Trade Capacity:** The WTO supports developing countries in participating effectively in international trade. This includes technical assistance programs to help them navigate trade negotiations and agreements.

**GOVERNANCE OF WTO**

- **Ministerial Conference:** The topmost decision-making body of the WTO and it usually meets every two years.
- **General Council:** It is WTO's highest-level decision-making body situated in Geneva, and holds meetings regularly.
- **The Trade Policy Review Body (TPRB):** The WTO General Council meets as the TPRB to undertake trade policy reviews and to consider the Director-General's regular reports on trade policy development.
- **Dispute Settlement Body (DSU):** The General Council convenes as the Dispute Settlement Body (DSB) to deal with disputes between WTO members.

ACHIEVEMENT OF WTO

The World Trade Organization (WTO) has played a significant role in shaping global trade:

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- **Streamlined Trade Rules:** The WTO established a framework of binding rules for trade in goods and services, reducing complexities and encouraging trade flows.
- **Supporting Development:** The WTO recognizes the need for developed countries to lower barriers for exports from least-developed countries, promoting their economic growth.
- **Boosted Trade Volumes:** Average tariffs have significantly decreased, leading to a near quadrupling of global trade value and a substantial increase in trade volume since 1995.
- **Global Value Chains:** The WTO facilitated the rise of global value chains, where businesses can source materials and production across borders, boosting efficiency.
- **Poverty Reduction:** The WTO era has coincided with the fastest decline in global poverty ever recorded, suggesting a potential link between trade and poverty reduction.
- **Focus on Services and Sustainability:** The WTO has liberalized trade in information technology products and eliminated harmful farm export subsidies, promoting a more sustainable trading environment.

ISSUES RELATED TO WTO

- **Institutional Dysfunction:** The inoperable Appellate Body, responsible for settling trade disputes, weakens the WTO's enforcement capacity.
- **Outdated Framework:** The WTO struggles to address modern issues like e-commerce and digital trade, hindering adaptability.
- **Unfair Practices:** China's state-directed economic model and the US-China trade war disrupt the free-market principles of the WTO system.
- **Development Divide:** The unclear definition of "developed" and "developing" countries creates friction in negotiations.
- **Deadlocks and Impasse:** Frequent stalemates in negotiations and the Appellate Body appointments block progress.
- **Competing Agreements:** The rise of regional trade agreements like NAFTA and ASEAN undermines the WTO's multilateral approach.
- **Erosion of Benefits:** Developed countries' tariff reductions weaken preferential treatment for developing nations.

KEY TERMS: Trade Framework, Trade Agreements & Disputes, Trade Facilitation & Development, Trade Rule Streamlining, Dispute Settlement Dysfunction, Outdated Framework (E-commerce), Unfair Trade Practices, Regional Trade Agreements

WTO AND INDIA

India has been a key player in the World Trade Organization (WTO) since its inception in 1995, having previously participated in the WTO's forerunner, the General Agreement on Tariffs and Trade (GATT) since 1948. India has actively used the WTO to:

- **Boost Exports:** Lower trade barriers through WTO agreements helped India become a major exporter of goods and services.
- **Develop Economy:** Access to global markets and technology transfer have contributed to India's economic growth.
- **Raise Concerns:** India advocates for the interests of developing countries within the WTO, pushing for fairer trade practices.

INDIA'S STANCE ON FOOD SECURITY

India frequently invokes the WTO's "peace clause" to justify exceeding subsidy limits on rice production. This prioritises domestic food security needs over strict adherence to WTO rules.

- **Subsidy Levels:** India provides rice subsidies exceeding the 10% limit set by the WTO, citing the need to support its large, vulnerable population.
- **Public Stockholding Programs:** These programs, allowed under the peace clause, involve procuring and distributing essential grains like rice at subsidised rates to ensure food security for the poor.
- **Defence of Export Ban:** India defends temporary export bans on wheat and broken rice (used in animal feed) as necessary measures to safeguard its own food security.
- **Challenges and Considerations:** While India prioritises its population's food security, this approach raises concerns from other WTO members:

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- **Market Distortion:** Excessive subsidies can distort global agricultural markets.
- **Trade Certainty:** Other countries seek predictability in food trade and may view export bans as disruptive.

HIGHLIGHTS OF INDIA'S 7TH TRADE POLICY REVIEW (2021)

- **Digitalization:** India's Customs Electronic Gateway (ICEGATE) offers online filing services, simplifying trade processes.
- **Reduced Bureaucracy:** The Single Window Interface for Trade (SWIFT) minimizes interactions with government agencies, saving time and costs.
- **Faster Clearance:** Direct Port Delivery (DPD) allows select importers to clear cargo within 48 hours, reducing congestion and costs.
- **Improved Logistics:** Direct Port Entry (DPE) enables efficient 24/7 movement of containers from factories to ports.
- **GST Implementation:** The Goods and Services Tax (GST) is a major structural reform streamlining domestic trade.
- **Trade Facilitation:** Proactive efforts to implement the WTO's Trade Facilitation Agreement (TFA) promote faster and cheaper trade. This has led to significant improvement in India's "Trading across Borders" ranking.
- **FDI & IPR:** Liberalization of the Foreign Direct Investment (FDI) regime and the National Intellectual Property Rights Policy (2016) demonstrate India's commitment to a more open economy.

CONCERNS & RESPONSES

- **Unchanged Trade Policy:** Trading partners raised concerns about the lack of significant changes in India's trade policy since 2015, including continued reliance on tariffs and other trade controls.
- **India's Response:** India justified its approach by highlighting the need to manage domestic demand and supply fluctuations that could impact traders. They also requested a permanent WTO solution for Public Stockholding (PSH) to ensure food security.

India and WTO disputes	
India's IT Tariffs	Case: In 2019, the European Union (EU) challenged India's imposition of import duties on various IT products, including mobile phones, components, and integrated circuits. These duties ranged from 7.5% to 20%. The EU argued that these tariffs exceeded the maximum permitted rate under World Trade Organization (WTO) agreements. Similar complaints were filed by Japan and Taiwan in the same year. Ruling: The WTO panel ruled against India, finding its import duties to be inconsistent with WTO regulations. In simpler terms, the WTO determined that India's tariffs violated global trade rules.
India Contests WTO Panel Ruling on ICT Duties	Dispute: India challenged a World Trade Organization (WTO) panel ruling that accused them of violating global trade regulations by raising import duties on information and communication technology (ICT) products. India's Action: India has filed an appeal seeking to overturn or nullify the panel's decision.

DISPUTE SETTLEMENT PROCESS AT WTO

- **Bilateral Consultations:** The first step involves discussions between the concerned WTO members (India and the country/countries that raised the complaint).
- **WTO Panel Review:** If talks fail, the matter goes to a WTO dispute settlement panel for a ruling.
- **Appellate Body Appeal (Currently On Hold):** Dissatisfied parties can typically appeal the panel's decision to the WTO Appellate Body for further review. However, the Appellate Body is currently not functioning due to the US blocking new member appointments.

13TH MINISTERIAL CONFERENCE OF WTO (ABU DHABI 2024)

Context: The World Trade Organization (WTO) held its 13th Ministerial Conference (MC13) in Abu Dhabi from February 26th to 29th, 2024.

KEY HIGHLIGHTS

- **New Members:** Comoros and Timor-Leste joined the WTO, bringing the total membership to 166.

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- **Service Domestic Regulations:** New rules on domestic regulations for services were announced. These "most-favored-nation" principles will benefit all WTO members.
- **Economic Impact:** The new regulations are expected to:
 - Lower trade costs by over USD 125 billion globally.
 - Increase global real income by at least 0.3% (USD 301 billion) by 2032.
 - Boost global service exports by 0.8% (USD 206 billion) by 2032.

INDIA'S STANCE

- **Multilateral Trading System:** India emphasized the importance of maintaining a focused WTO agenda, free from non-trade issues.
- **Sustainable Practices:** India highlighted its "LiFE" (Life Style for Environment) movement promoting sustainable living as a key tool against climate change.
- **Non-Trade Issues:** India argued that non-trade issues can lead to trade distortions and barriers. Bringing topics like gender and MSMEs into the WTO's realm was deemed impractical due to existing discussions in other organizations.
- **Inclusion:** India believes issues of inclusion are better addressed through national measures rather than international trade regulations.
- **Appellate Body:** India stressed the need to revive the Appellate Body, inactive since December 2019.
- **Investment Facilitation for Development (IFD):** India and South Africa opposed this China-led proposal.

WAY FORWARD

- **Safeguarding Local Markets:** Introducing provisions to protect domestic markets of developing countries from foreign goods can bolster their confidence in the WTO system.
- **Digital Trade Rules:** Modernizing the WTO requires establishing a new framework of rules to address digital trade and e-commerce effectively.
- **Trade & Sustainability:** To counter climate change and revitalize the WTO, increased efforts are needed to align trade policies with environmental sustainability goals.
- **Building Trust:** Rebuilding trust among member nations is crucial. The WTO needs active participation from all countries to establish fair trade rules for the collective benefit and to counter unfair practices.

KEY TERMS: GATT Membership (1948), WTO Founding Member (1995), Advocacy for Developing Countries, Peace Clause Invocation, Public Stockholding Programs, GST Implementation, National IPR Policy (2016), Dispute Settlement Process

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	What are the key areas of reform if the WTO has to survive in the present context of Trade War', especially keeping in mind the interest of India?	(2018)
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INTERNATIONAL MONETARY FUND AND INDIA

INTRODUCTION

- The International Monetary Fund (IMF), established in 1944 after the Bretton Woods Conference, is a global organisation with 190 member countries.
- It emerged from the shadows of the Great Depression, aiming to foster international monetary cooperation, promote global trade, and achieve financial stability that fuels economic growth and poverty reduction.
- It strives to achieve sustainable growth and prosperity for all its member countries by supporting economic policies that promote financial stability and monetary cooperation.

FUNCTIONS OF IMF

The IMF serves a critical role in maintaining a stable and prosperous global financial system through several key functions:

- **Cooperation and Coordination:** Fosters collaboration among member countries on economic and financial policies to ensure a coordinated approach.
- **Exchange Rate Stability:** Promotes stable exchange rates, which are essential for smooth international trade and investment.
- **Multilateral Payments System:** Supports the development of a well-functioning system for international payments, minimising disruptions.
- **Financial Assistance:** Provides temporary financial assistance to member countries facing balance of payment problems, helping them stabilise their economies.

FUNDING OF THE IMF

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) relies on a three-pronged approach to secure its financial resources:

- **Member Quotas:** This is the primary source of funding. Each member country contributes a set amount based on its economic standing.
- **Multilateral Borrowings:** The IMF has a borrowing arrangement (NAB) with a group of member countries and institutions to supplement quota resources.
- **Bilateral Borrowing Agreements:** The IMF can also enter into borrowing agreements with individual member countries.

CRITICISM OF IMF

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) faces criticism regarding its structure and practices:

- **Voting Disparity:** The quota system grants more voting rights and borrowing power to developed nations, creating an uneven playing field.
- **Loan Conditionality:** Critics argue that the IMF's loan conditions are overly intrusive and infringe upon borrowing countries' economic and political autonomy.
- **One-Size-Fits-All Approach:** The IMF has been accused of imposing identical policy prescriptions on all countries, regardless of their specific circumstances.
- **Dominant Power Structure:** Reforming the IMF requires an 85% majority vote, heavily concentrated with a small group of developed nations, particularly the US.

REFORMS NEEDED

The International Monetary Fund (IMF) faces calls for reform to reflect the changing global economic landscape. Here are key areas requiring attention:

- **Quota Fairness:** The quota system, which determines voting rights and financial contributions, needs an overhaul. Removing the biased "openness" measure and increasing quotas for emerging economies like China and BRICS nations are crucial. Additionally, a 50% increase in total IMF funds is necessary to facilitate this redistribution.
- **Enhanced Representation:** The 2010 reforms establishing an all-elected Executive Board are a positive step, but further progress is needed. The ongoing 15th General Quota Review presents an opportunity to continue this process and create a more representative governance structure.

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- **Modernizing Article IV:** The current bilateral discussions under Article IV lack transparency and can negatively impact developing nations' borrowing ability. The IMF should utilize new technologies and publicly available data to make these assessments more objective and relevant.
- **Leadership Selection:** The informal tradition of an American leading the World Bank and a European leading the IMF needs to be replaced with a merit-based selection process.

INDIA AND IMF

India has been a member of the IMF since its inception in 1945. It actively participates, holding a significant quota and plays a role in shaping the IMF's policies. The IMF projects India to become the world's 4th largest economy by 2025.

DEVELOPMENTS IN IMF AND INDIA'S RELATIONSHIP

- **Shifting Dynamic:** India's relationship with the IMF has evolved significantly. India was a founding member in 1945, but initially viewed the IMF with some skepticism due to its association with the capitalist bloc.
- **From Borrower to Contributor:** Following an economic crisis in 1991, India turned to the IMF for assistance. The IMF-backed reforms are credited with paving the way for India's impressive economic growth in the following decades. India has since transitioned from a borrower to a creditor nation within the IMF.
- **Focus on Growth and Stability:** India continues to collaborate with the IMF on promoting economic growth and financial stability. The IMF provides technical assistance and policy advice to India on various economic issues.
- **India's Growing Influence:** As India's economic power has grown, so has its influence within the IMF. India advocates for reforms that better reflect the changing global economic landscape and the needs of developing countries.

INDIA'S BALANCE OF PAYMENTS CRISIS IN THE 1990

- **The Challenge:** In the early 1990s, India faced a severe balance of payments deficit, particularly with the US and other countries using hard currencies. This meant India was spending more foreign currency on imports than it was earning through exports. The country's foreign exchange reserves dwindled to dangerously low levels.
- **The IMF's Role:** To address the crisis, India sought assistance from the International Monetary Fund (IMF). The IMF offered a loan of SDR 3.6 billion (Special Drawing Rights, an IMF unit of exchange) on the condition that India implemented significant economic reforms.
- **The Reform Agenda:** The IMF's conditions for the loan centered on structural reforms. These included:
 - **Devaluation of the Indian Rupee:** Making the rupee cheaper to encourage exports and discourage imports.
 - **Fiscal Consolidation:** Reducing government spending and budget deficits to improve financial stability.

IMF QUOTA REFORMS

- The International Monetary Fund (IMF) assigns **quotas** to member countries based on their **economic strength**. These quotas **determine voting rights and access** to IMF resources.
- Developing nations, including India (**currently the 8th largest quota holder**), argue for a greater share of the quota pie. This would give them more influence in IMF decisions and potentially greater access to financial assistance.
- IMF quota reform is an ongoing debate, with **developing countries seeking a more equitable distribution of power and resources** within the organisation.

India is likely to continue its collaborative relationship with the IMF, seeking technical expertise and advocating for reforms that benefit its own economic development and global financial stability.

CONCLUSION

The IMF plays a vital role in global financial stability. Implementing these reforms will ensure the institution remains relevant, effective, and truly representative of the 21st-century world economy.

KEY TERMS: Borrower to Contributor, Economic Growth & Stability, Balance of Payments, IMF Loan, IMF Quota, Reform Debate, Digital Transformation, Building Block Approach

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WORLD HEALTH ORGANISATION (WHO) AND INDIA

INTRODUCTION

- The World Health Organization (WHO), established in 1948, is a specialized agency of the United Nations. It spearheads global health efforts, working to keep the world safe, promote health equity, and combat diseases. With a presence in over 150 countries, WHO plays a vital role in shaping research agendas, setting global health norms, and providing technical support to countries.

MANDATE AND FUNCTIONS

WHO's primary goal is to ensure that all people have the right to the highest attainable standard of health.

- **Providing Leadership:** WHO sets the global health agenda, shapes research directions, and proposes evidence-based policy options.
- **Shaping Research Agenda:** WHO plays a key role in stimulating and guiding health research around the world.
- **Setting Standards:** WHO develops and promotes international health standards and guidelines.
- **Technical Support:** WHO provides technical support to countries to help them strengthen their health systems and improve health outcomes.
- **Monitoring Health Trends:** WHO monitors and assesses global health trends and disseminates critical health information.

INDIA AND WHO

- India has a long-standing partnership with the World Health Organization (WHO), dating back to India's membership since 1948.
- WHO works closely with the Indian government to strengthen healthcare systems, achieve universal health coverage, and address public health challenges.
- Their collaboration extends to areas like controlling infectious diseases, promoting primary healthcare, and improving maternal and child health.

FOUR STRATEGIC PRIORITIES OF WHO IN INDIA

The World Health Organization (WHO) has outlined four key strategic priorities to support India's healthcare goals:

1. Universal Health Coverage (UHC):

- Expanding access to essential healthcare services through initiatives like Ayushman Bharat.
- Monitoring health sector performance to ensure effectiveness.
- Utilizing digital health tools for improved service delivery.
- Addressing neglected and preventable diseases.

2. Promoting Health and Well-being:

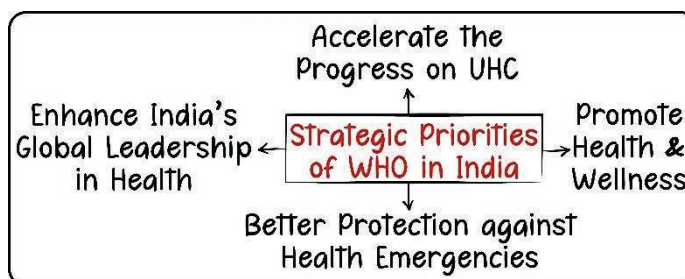
- Tackling non-communicable diseases (NCDs) through targeted programs.
- Addressing environmental health concerns, particularly air pollution.
- Promoting mental health awareness and suicide prevention.
- Ensuring food safety and proper nutrition.

3. Strengthening Health Emergency Preparedness:

- Enhancing disease surveillance and outbreak response systems.
- Utilizing real-time health information platforms for faster response.
- Preparing for and responding effectively to all health emergencies.
- Combating antimicrobial resistance.

4. Elevating India's Global Health Leadership:

- Promoting access to high-quality medical products manufactured in India.
- Encouraging innovation and knowledge sharing in healthcare practices and technologies.
- Strengthening India's role as a leader in digital health solutions.



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THE WHO INDIA COUNTRY COOPERATION STRATEGY 2019 –2023: A TIME OF TRANSITION

The World Health Organization (WHO) and the Indian government have partnered on a strategic plan (CCS) to improve India's health sector. This plan focuses on:

- **Supporting Government Initiatives:** The WHO will collaborate with India's Ministry of Health and Family Welfare (MoHFW) and other relevant ministries to achieve national health goals.
- **Building on Existing Policies:** The CCS aligns with India's National Health Policy 2017 and other key health initiatives.
- **Addressing Pressing Challenges:** The strategy tackles complex issues like Non-Communicable Diseases (NCDs), antimicrobial resistance, air pollution, and mental health

RECENT DEVELOPMENTS

- **India's Role in the WHO :** India secured a seat on the World Health Organization's Executive Board for 2020-21. This position allows India to play a vital role in shaping global health policies and addressing health challenges.
- **Fostering Collaboration and Equity:** India emphasized the need for greater international cooperation and health equity, particularly in the wake of the COVID-19 pandemic. This aligns with India's G20 presidency focus on creating a global network for accessible production of medical resources.
- **Supporting Equal Access:** As a GAVI board member nominated by the alliance itself, India actively promotes equal access to vaccines for developing countries. This aligns with the WHO's expected focus on ensuring equitable access to healthcare resources in the coming years.

CRITICISM OF WHO

The World Health Organization (WHO) has faced criticism for its handling of recent health crises.

- **Funding pattern:** WHO relies heavily on donations from wealthy nations, raising concerns about its autonomy and ability to respond effectively during emergencies.
- **Past Performance:** The organization's response to the 2014 West Africa Ebola outbreak was deemed inadequate, casting doubt on its overall effectiveness.
- **COVID-19 Response:** Critics point to the WHO's delay in declaring the pandemic and perceived lack of decisive action in advising governments on control measures.
- **Political Influence:** Some nations believe the WHO's approach has been swayed by political considerations.
- **Limited Authority:** The WHO's recommendations are not binding, hindering its ability to enforce effective responses.

WAY FORWARD

- **Sustainable Funding:** A shift towards a more stable and diversified funding model, potentially with increased contributions from all member states, could reduce dependence on individual donors.
- **Strengthened Early Warning Systems:** Investing in robust surveillance and early warning systems would allow for faster and more effective responses to outbreaks.
- **Transparency and Communication:** Clear and timely communication of risks and recommendations is crucial for building trust and ensuring global cooperation.
- **Empowering National Governments:** The WHO can support national governments in developing strong public health infrastructures and preparedness plans.
- **Independent Review and Reform:** An independent review and potential reforms could address concerns about political influence and strengthen the WHO's authority.

By addressing these challenges, the WHO can regain trust and become a more effective leader in global health security.

KEY TERMS: World Health Assembly, Universal Health Coverage, Strategic Partnership, Public Health Challenges, Health Emergency Preparedness, Digital Health, Global Health Policy, Vaccine Access, Funding Dependence, Sustainable Funding.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Critically examine the role of WHO in providing global health security during the Covid-19 pandemic.	2020
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UNITED NATIONS (UN) ORGANISATION AND ASSOCIATED ISSUES

INTRODUCTION

- The United Nations (UN) was established in 1945 after the devastation of World War II. It serves as a global platform for fostering international cooperation and maintaining peace and security.
- It brings together all member states, currently numbering 193, to work towards a collective future based on shared principles like human rights, sustainable development, and upholding international law.
- The UN plays a multifaceted role, facilitating dialogue and negotiation on critical issues, providing humanitarian assistance, and promoting international cooperation across various sectors like health, education, and environmental protection.

ISSUES IN UNITED NATIONS

- **Funding Shortfalls:** The UN relies on voluntary contributions, creating financial constraints that limit its ability to address global issues effectively (e.g., peacekeeping). Major funding issues involves:
 - **Resource Strain:** The peacekeeping budget of \$6 billion struggles to support 95,000 peacekeepers globally, and troop-contributing nations often lack a say in mission mandates.
 - **Unreliable Funding:** With outstanding member state contributions and a heavy reliance on voluntary funding for development work, the UN's financial stability is compromised.
 - **Climate Change Burden:** Developed nations haven't fulfilled their pledges of \$100 billion in annual climate finance to developing countries most affected by climate change, a problem largely caused by historical emissions from developed nations.
- **Security Council Gridlock:** The veto power of a select few in the Security Council can stall swift responses to crises, raising concerns about fairness and effectiveness.
- **Divided Voice:** With 193 members, differing national interests and political priorities often lead to disagreements and hinder unified action.
- **Duplication of Efforts:** The UN's numerous agencies can lead to coordination issues and wasted resources.
- **Conflict Resolution Hurdles:** Complex conflicts, limited resources, and competing interests often impede lasting solutions and sustainable peace.
- **Human Rights Struggles:** Though committed to human rights, the UN faces challenges in enforcing them due to limited mechanisms, political considerations, and differing interpretations.
- **Adapting to Change:** The UN's pace of reform is seen as slow, hindering its ability to address emerging challenges like climate change and technological advancements.

REFORMS NEEDED

- **Charter Amendments:** Reforms beyond the Secretariat necessitate revisions to the UN Charter, which is very difficult to amend. (e.g., Article 108).
- **UN Charter Review:** The Charter itself needs updates. Obsolete references, like "enemy states" (former Axis powers), and limitations on intervention (Article 2(7)) require revisiting.
- **General Assembly:** While structural reform isn't urgent, improved coordination with the Security Council is crucial.
- **Security Council Reform:** This is a major discussion point (addressed separately).
- **ECOSOC (Economic and Social Council):** Streamlining is essential due to excessive overlap among its numerous agencies.
- **Trusteeship Council:** With its original purpose fulfilled, this body either needs abolishment or a new mandate.
- **UN Secretariat:** Red tape reduction, bureaucracy optimization, increased representation from developing nations, and staff training are key priorities.
- **Financial Reforms:** Increased funding, timely member contributions, and exploring independent revenue streams (e.g., Tobin Tax) are vital. Addressing financial mismanagement is also crucial.

Modernising the UN requires a multi-faceted approach. Updating the Charter, streamlining structures, and ensuring strong finances are essential steps to ensure the organization's continued relevance and effectiveness in a changing world.

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INDIA AND UN

India, as a founding member of the United Nations (UN), has been actively engaged with the organization since its inception. India's relationship with the UN is characterized by a commitment to the principles of multilateralism, peace, and international cooperation. Despite this positive relationship, India has certain issues with UN.

INDIA'S KEY CONCERNS AT THE UN

- **Permanent Membership in the UN Security Council:** India advocates for a permanent seat on the UN Security Council, reflecting its growing global influence and ensuring a more balanced world body.
- **Combating Terrorism:** India pushes for stronger global cooperation to fight terrorism, including tackling financing, dismantling networks, and pursuing justice for perpetrators.
- **Peacekeeping Leader:** As a major contributor of troops to UN peacekeeping missions (over 275,000 Indian troops deployed), India seeks continued support for these efforts.
- **Sustainable Development:** India, a populous developing nation, calls for international assistance with climate change by way of finance, technology transfer, and capacity building for a low-carbon future.
- **Nuclear Disarmament:** India advocates for a fair and inclusive global nuclear disarmament process that addresses security concerns while preventing proliferation.
- **Development and Aid:** Despite its developing status, India faces challenges acquiring sufficient development assistance. It urges the international community to provide more targeted aid to support its development goals.

India actively engages in UN diplomacy, builds alliances, and promotes consensus on critical global issues. By securing a more prominent role within the UN, India aims to better represent its interests and contribute significantly to global peace, security, and sustainable development.

INDIA'S APPREHENSIONS ABOUT OTHER UN BODIES

India actively participates in the UN system but has raised concerns with specific organizations:

- **UN Security Council (UNSC):** India advocates for reform, including a permanent seat for itself, to reflect contemporary global realities.
- **UN Human Rights Council (UNHRC):** India criticises the UNHRC's perceived bias and selective focus on human rights violations.
- **UN Conference on Trade and Development (UNCTAD):** India pushes for a more balanced approach to trade and development issues that favours developing countries.
- **United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO):** India opposes the politicisation of cultural issues and advocates for impartiality within UNESCO.
- **World Health Organization (WHO):** The COVID-19 pandemic highlighted India's call for reform in global health governance, emphasising transparency and accountability within the WHO.

Despite these areas of friction, India remains an active participant in the broader United Nations system and continues to work collaboratively on various global issues. India engages in multilateral diplomacy, seeks to address its concerns through dialogue and negotiation, and contributes to the overall objectives and efforts of the United Nations.

UNITED NATIONS SECURITY COUNCIL (UNSC)

The United Nations Security Council (UNSC) is one of the principal organs of the United Nations (UN) and holds primary responsibility for maintaining international peace and security. Composed of 15 member states, including five permanent members with veto power (China, France, Russia, the United Kingdom, and the United States), the UNSC has the authority to make decisions that bind all UN member states.

ISSUES WITH UNSC

- **Representation and Reform:** The current structure, with permanent members wielding veto power, is seen as outdated and undemocratic.
- **Veto Power:** Critics argue that vetoes by permanent members can obstruct resolutions with widespread support, hindering effective action.
- **Regional Imbalance:** Africa, for example, feels underrepresented on the Council, hindering its ability to address regional issues.
- **Decision-Making Process:** Concerns exist about the transparency and inclusivity of the UNSC's decision-making, dominated by the permanent members.
- **Responding to Crises:** The Council's effectiveness in addressing global crises and emergencies is hampered by its slow and cumbersome processes.

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- **Enforcement:** Incomplete compliance with UNSC resolutions by member states weakens the Council's authority and undermines its ability to maintain peace.

INDIA AND UNSC

India has had longstanding issues and concerns regarding its representation and role in the United Nations Security Council (UNSC). Some of the key issues are:

- **Lack of Permanent Seat:** India argues its growing global stature justifies permanent membership, ensuring a more balanced representation in the Council.
- **Limited Influence:** The current structure concentrates power with the five permanent members, leaving non-permanent members like India with minimal say in decision-making.
- **Insufficient Voice:** India feels its perspectives on pressing issues like peacekeeping, counterterrorism, and sustainable development are not adequately considered. For example, combating terrorism, a major concern for India, is hindered by a lack of international consensus on definitions and tackling cross-border threats.

India advocates for UNSC reform, including adding permanent seats for developing regions like Africa, Asia, and Latin America, to create a more inclusive and representative body. Ultimately, India strives for a UNSC that reflects the current global landscape and addresses the needs of all member states. Its pursuit of reform reflects its commitment to shaping global governance for the benefit of developing nations.

THE PATH TO A PERMANENT SEAT

India's quest for a permanent UN Security Council seat requires a strategic and multifaceted approach:

- **Demonstrating Leadership:** Active participation in peacekeeping missions, counterterrorism efforts, and sustainable development initiatives showcases India's global commitment.
- **Diplomatic Advocacy:** Continued lobbying of member states, especially permanent members, is essential.
- **Building Consensus:** Negotiation and bridge-building diplomacy are crucial to address concerns and achieve common ground for reform.
- **Promoting Inclusivity:** Encouraging participation by non-permanent members and ensuring equal voice in shaping UN resolutions fosters transparency.
- **Strengthening Regional Ties:** Bolstering initiatives like IORA and SAARC can solidify India's regional leadership.
- **Engaging Stakeholders:** Collaboration with civil society and non-state actors broadens support and strengthens India's position.
- **Active Multilateralism:** Continued engagement with BRICS, G20, and regional organisations keeps India at the forefront of global discourse.

By pursuing these strategies, India can increase its influence and pave the way for a well-deserved permanent seat at the UN Security Council table.

UNITED NATIONS HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL (UN HRC)

- The United Nations Human Rights Council (UNHRC) was established in 2006.
- It acts as a forum for discussing human rights concerns and violations. It has the power to make recommendations and initiate investigations into human rights abuses.
- The council plays a vital role in holding countries accountable for their human rights records and advocating for those who have had their rights violated.
- It Composed of 47 elected member states.
- **UN Human Rights Council and India:** India was elected to the Council for three years. As part of the third Universal Periodic Review (UPR) cycle, India's National Human Rights Commission delivered its midterm report to the Council in 2020.

CRITICISMS OF UNHRC

The Human Rights Council (HRC) faces criticism on several fronts:

- **Selectivity and Bias:** The focus on Israel and declining country-specific resolutions raise concerns about political targeting, particularly of developing nations.
- **Unequal Representation:** Countries with questionable human rights records hold seats on the council, hindering effective scrutiny. The suspension of such members is rare.
- **Limited Accessibility:** High costs associated with attending HRC sessions restrict participation from the Global South, including human rights defenders and vulnerable groups like child victims.

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- **Ineffective Implementation:** Non-binding recommendations from the Universal Periodic Review (UPR) and bloc voting weaken the Council's ability to hold violators accountable and address specific human rights issues.

WAY FORWARD

- **Stricter Membership Criteria:** Rigorous scrutiny of human rights records should be implemented for both candidacy and throughout membership.
- **Timely Action:** The Council should react more swiftly to unfolding human rights crises through expedited briefings and urgent debates.
- **Independent NGO Accreditation:** Shifting accreditation from diplomats to qualified experts can ensure a more objective process.
- **Proactive Approach:** Regular country visits and timely report presentations are crucial for early detection of potential violations.

KEY TERMS: Human Rights Body (UNHRC), Universal Periodic Review (UPR), Selectivity & Bias, Unequal Representation, Limited Accessibility, Ineffective Implementation, Civil Society Participation

INDIA AND UNHRC

India has been actively engaged with the UNHRC, advocating for human rights while also facing scrutiny on various fronts. While India has been elected as a member of the council in the past, there have also been disagreements.

INDIA'S DEVELOPMENT MODEL PRAISED AT THE UN HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL

Highlights of India's Approach:

- **Uplifting Dalits:** India emphasizes its affirmative action policies and educational opportunities that have improved the lives of Dalits compared to minorities in neighboring countries.
- **Promoting Human Rights:** India highlights its constitution guaranteeing fundamental rights, progress made in empowering women, Dalits, and other marginalized groups.
- **Breaking Barriers:** India showcases the rise of Droupadi Murmu (tribal woman president) and Narendra Modi (OBC Prime Minister) as examples of equal opportunity.
- **Advancing Gender Equality:** India points to recent legislation criminalizing marital rape and protecting women from workplace harassment.
- **Alignment with UN Values:** India emphasizes its adherence to Mahatma Gandhi's core principles, which align with the UN Charter and Universal Declaration of Human Rights.

INDIA RE-ELECTED TO UN HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL FOR 2022-24 TERM

Significance of the membership:

- **Global Recognition:** India's overwhelming majority vote reflects its strong standing in the international community.
- **Human Rights Commitment:** This re-election acknowledges India's dedication to human rights protection.
- **Addressing Concerns:** It offers India a platform to address past concerns raised by the UNHRC regarding human rights in Jammu and Kashmir.
- **Soft Power Boost:** This leadership role strengthens India's soft power diplomacy, promoting its image as a champion of human rights.

UN Human Rights Concerns Regarding India

The UN Human Rights Council (UNHRC) has raised concerns about several issues in India:

- **Jammu and Kashmir:** The UNHRC expressed alarm over human rights abuses in Jammu and Kashmir, citing the detention of political leaders and activists.
- **Citizenship Amendment Act (CAA):** The UNHRC challenged the CAA in the Supreme Court, arguing it violates human rights principles.
- **Environmental Impact Assessment (EIA):** A group of UNHRC Special Rapporteurs sent a letter to the Indian government expressing concern about the recent weakening of environmental regulations in the EIA draft.

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A GLOBAL AGENCY AFFILIATED WITH THE UNITED NATIONS (UN) DEFERRED THE RE -ACCREDITATION OF INDIA'S HUMAN RIGHTS BODY FOR A YEAR

- **Reason for deferment:** Appointment of political representatives and a lack of gender balance and pluralism among NHRC staff.
- **Recommendation to NHRC:** Enhance compliance with Paris Principles by urging lawmakers and the government for specific legislative changes.
- **Implication upon deferment:** The NHRC can no longer represent India at the UN Human Rights Council upon final decision. Degrades India's credibility to protect and uphold human rights.

UKRAINE WAR: RUSSIA SUSPENDED FROM UN HUMAN RIGHTS COUNCIL; INDIA ABSTAINS FROM VOTING

Why did India abstain from voting?

- **Bilateral ties with Russia:** India sees Russia as a longstanding and time-tested friend that has played a significant role in its economic development and security.
- **India's stand at the UN:** If India has chosen any side, it is the side of peace and it is for an immediate end to violence.
- India's needs are connected to both Russia and Ukraine.
- India's then permanent representative to the UN, T.S. Tirumurti, stated that India had abstained on the resolution "for reasons of both substance and process".

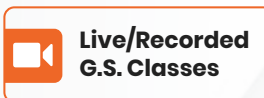
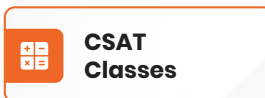
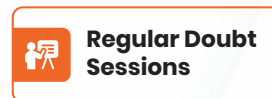
CONCLUSION

- Thus, India has a complex relationship with the UN Human Rights Council (UNHRC). The UNHRC has raised concerns about human rights issues in India, such as restrictions on civil society and treatment of minorities. India, on the other hand, has defended its record and emphasized its own National Human Rights Commission. Despite these differences, India participates in the UNHRC with the goal of improving global human rights while also addressing concerns raised about its own domestic situation.

KEY TERMS: India's Engagement, Human Rights Advocacy, Scrutiny on Human Rights Record, Alignment with UN Values, Paris Principles, Balancing Relations with Russia and Ukraine

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UNESCO

CURRENT CONTEXT

The United States (US) has formally rejoined the United Nations Educational, Scientific and Cultural Organization (UNESCO) after a five-year absence. This return comes with a commitment to pay over \$600 million in outstanding dues.

A HISTORY OF USA WITHDRAWALS

- The US has a history of withdrawing from UNESCO. In 2011, funding was halted in response to Palestine's membership. Citing alleged bias and naming disputes related to historical sites, the US formally withdrew again in 2018.
- Notably, this wasn't the first US withdrawal. They previously left in 1984 over concerns about mismanagement and Soviet influence but rejoined in 2003.

MOTIVATIONS FOR REJOINING

- **Countering China's Rise:** China's increased financial contributions have positioned them as a major player in UNESCO. Rejoining allows the US to counter this growing influence.
- **Soft Power Reassertion:** The US likely sees UNESCO as a platform to reassert its global influence and leadership in areas like education and science.
- **Shaping Standards:** UNESCO plays a vital role in shaping ethical standards related to science and technology. The US likely seeks to have a greater say in this process.

ABOUT UNESCO

- Founded in 1945, UNESCO is a specialized UN agency promoting international cooperation in education, science, and culture to foster peace and security.
- Led by a Director-General, it serves as a platform for collaboration on global challenges.

ISSUES WITH UNESCO

- **Financial Strain:** The US withdrawal led to a significant funding gap, hindering program execution.
- **Shifting Focus:** The recent decline in funding for education, a core area, raises concerns about UNESCO's priorities.
- **Divergent Priorities:** Member states have varying foreign policy goals, impacting the organization's direction.
- **China's Influence:** China's growing presence raises concerns about potential influence on UNESCO's agenda.
- **World Heritage Protection:** The destruction of the Bamiyan Buddhas highlights the need for stronger site protection measures.
- **Selection Process:** The current nomination process for World Heritage Sites lacks transparency and clear criteria.

THE ROAD AHEAD

Strengthening UNESCO requires a multi-pronged approach:

- **Increased Funding:** Developed nations must contribute more to ensure financial stability.
- **Robust Governance:** Enhanced accountability and efficiency in decision-making will strengthen UNESCO's effectiveness.
- **Collaboration:** Stronger partnerships with other UN agencies, international organizations, and civil society can leverage combined expertise and resources.
- **Transparent Selection Process:** A revamped system for selecting World Heritage Sites, with a dedicated committee to identify significant locations globally, is crucial.

The US's return to UNESCO signifies a renewed commitment to international cooperation on critical issues. While strategic considerations likely played a role, it also suggests a recognition of the value in working with other nations for a more peaceful and sustainable future. Further, by addressing above challenges and fostering collaboration, UNESCO can resume its vital role in promoting global education, scientific cooperation, and cultural preservation.

KEY TERMS: UNRWA (United Nations Relief and Works Agency), Palestinian Refugees, Humanitarian Aid, India's Support, Refugee Well-being

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INTERNATIONAL LABOUR ORGANIZATION

INTRODUCTION

- The International Labour Organization (ILO) is a unique agency within the United Nations system, established in 1919 after the Treaty of Versailles. It stands apart due to its tripartite structure, bringing together governments, worker organizations, and employer organizations from its 187 member states. This unique structure fosters dialogue and collaboration on key issues related to the world of work.
- The ILO's core mission is to promote "decent work for all." This translates to striving for fair working conditions, safety and health protections, social security, and opportunities for decent wages and employment for everyone.

ISSUES WITH ILO

- **Limited Enforcement Power:** The ILO lacks strong enforcement mechanisms to ensure member states comply with its core labor standards. It primarily relies on moral persuasion and public pressure.
- **Focus on Formal Sector:** The ILO's standards and programs might not adequately address the challenges faced by informal workers, a significant portion of the global workforce, particularly in developing countries.
- **Relevance in Changing World of Work:** The rapidly evolving nature of work, with increasing automation and the gig economy, might necessitate the ILO to adapt its approach to remain relevant.
- **Representation and Governance:** Some criticize the ILO's structure for not giving enough weight to the voices of workers and employers compared to governments.

WAY FORWARD

- **Strengthening Enforcement:** Explore ways to create a more robust enforcement mechanism, perhaps through collaboration with regional or international bodies.
- **Addressing Informal Work:** Develop targeted programs and standards that cater to the specific needs and vulnerabilities of informal workers.
- **Adapting to Changing Work:** The ILO needs to actively research and address the challenges and opportunities presented by the evolving nature of work, including automation and the gig economy.
- **Enhancing Representation:** Consider reforms to increase the participation and influence of worker and employer organisations within the ILO's decision-making processes.
- **Focusing on Development:** The ILO can play a crucial role in promoting decent work as a key driver of sustainable development, particularly in developing countries.
- **Collaboration:** Strengthen partnerships with governments, NGOs, and other international organisations to achieve its goals more effectively.

KEY TERMS: Tripartite Structure, Labour Standards, protecting Workers' Rights, Limited Enforcement, Informal Work Challenges, Stronger Enforcement Mechanisms, Adapting to Changing Work, Gig Economy

INDIA AND ILO

India was a founding member of the ILO in 1919, recognizing the importance of fair labor practices on the global stage. India plays a prominent role within the ILO, holding a permanent seat on its Governing Body since 1922.

8 CORE ILO CONVENTIONS

India has ratified six out of the eight core/fundamental ILO Conventions: These are-

- Forced Labour Convention, 1930 (No. 29)
- Abolition of Forced Labour Convention, 1957 (No. 105)
- Equal Remuneration Convention, 1951 (No. 100)
- Discrimination (Employment and Occupation) Convention, 1958 (No. 111)
- Minimum Age Convention, 1973 (No. 138)
- Worst Forms of Child Labour Convention, 1999 (No. 182).

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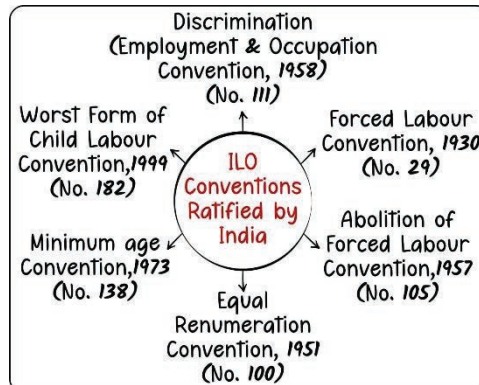
India has not ratified two of the eight core/fundamental ILO Conventions: These are

- Freedom of Association and Protection of the Right to Organise Convention, 1948 (No. 87)
- Right to Organise and Collective Bargaining Convention, 1949 (No. 98)

Why Has India Not Ratified ILO Conventions 87 & 98?

India has not ratified these conventions due to concerns regarding:

- **Employee Rights:** Granting certain rights to government employees, such as the right to strike or criticize government policies, conflicts with existing statutory rules.
- **Legal Inconsistencies:** Current national laws may not fully align with the provisions outlined in the conventions.



THE DECENT WORK COUNTRY PROGRAMME FOR INDIA (2023-2027)

The International Labour Organization (ILO) launched the DWCP to support India's goals for its workforce:

- **Job Creation:** Promote the creation of a sufficient number of high-quality jobs with opportunities for growth.
- **Sustainable Livelihoods:** Empower citizens with long-term, reliable sources of income.
- **Social Protection Expansion:** Strengthen social safety nets, particularly for informal sector workers.
- **Women's Empowerment:** Foster an environment that encourages greater female participation in the workforce.
- **Skills Development:** Build a robust skills training system to equip workers for the evolving job market.
- **Entrepreneurial Spirit:** Nurture a culture that fosters innovation and entrepreneurship.

By addressing these key areas, the DWCP aims to create a more prosperous and inclusive future for India's workforce.

111TH SESSION OF THE INTERNATIONAL LABOUR CONFERENCE

The 111th session of the International Labour Organization (ILO) conference, held in June 2023 in Geneva focused on key issues related to the future of work:

- **Social Justice:** The conference emphasized the need for greater social justice in the global workforce, aiming for a more equitable and inclusive work environment.
- **Just Transition:** Discussions centered on facilitating a "just transition" towards sustainable and inclusive economies. This involves ensuring workers benefit from the shift to a greener economy.
- **Quality Apprenticeships:** A key theme was establishing high-quality apprenticeship programs to equip workers with the skills needed in the evolving job market.
- **Labor Protection:** Delegates addressed the importance of upholding labor protection standards to ensure decent work conditions for all.

These points highlight the ILO's commitment to promoting a future of work that prioritizes social justice, skills development, and fair treatment for workers in a changing economic landscape.

The ILO Singapore Declaration 2022

The ILO Singapore Declaration stating **"To promote freedom of association and do not curb worker's rights"** outlines key commitments to promote a fair and inclusive work environment:

- **Strengthening Labour Protections:** Upholding freedom of association and collective bargaining rights are crucial for ensuring universal labour protection.
- **Closing the Gender Gap:** Measures promoting women's workforce participation, equal pay, work-life balance, and leadership opportunities are essential.
- **Supporting Transitions:** Inclusive labour policies should address challenges arising from life transitions and demographic shifts.
- **Expanding Social Protection:** Extending social security benefits to all workers strengthens social and employment resilience.

CONCLUSION

By addressing the above issues and pursuing suitable steps, the ILO can maintain its relevance and effectiveness in promoting social justice and fair labour practices in the globalised world.

KEY TERMS: Founding Member, Core Conventions, Unratified Conventions, Freedom of Association, Collective Bargaining, Decent Work Country Programme, India's workforce goals, Future of Work, Transition to green jobs, ILO Singapore Declaration, Commitment to worker rights.

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INTERNATIONAL CRIMINAL COURT (ICC)

INTRODUCTION

- ICC is an intergovernmental tribunal that prosecutes individuals for the most serious crimes of concern to the international community: genocide, crimes against humanity, war crimes, and the crime of aggression. (Examples: trial of Muammar Gaddafi)
- It was **established in 2002 by the Rome Statute**
- Currently, **123 countries** are members of the ICC. Some major powers, including **India, China, and the US, are not parties to the Rome Statute.**
- It is not a UN body but still has a cooperation agreement with it.

ROLE AND FUNCTIONS

The International Criminal Court (ICC) plays a vital role in the international justice system:

- **Accountability for Crimes:** The ICC establishes a framework to hold individuals accountable for the most serious international crimes.
- **Ending Impunity:** It works to prevent perpetrators of genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity from escaping justice.
- **UN Security Council Cooperation:** The Court acknowledges the role of the UN Security Council in referring situations to the ICC.
- **Addressing Core Crimes:** It focuses on prosecuting the gravest international crimes, including genocide, war crimes, and crimes against humanity, with the addition of the crime of aggression.

LIMITATIONS OF ICC

- **Legitimacy Concerns:** Some countries question the ICC's legitimacy, while others may attempt to manipulate it for their own political agendas. Additionally, the lack of a dedicated investigative body can limit its ability to pursue cases effectively.
- **UN Security Council Influence:** The power of permanent UN Security Council members to veto ICC actions significantly impacts its ability to make arrests in non-member states. This creates a dependence on these powerful nations.
- **Allegations of Bias:** The ICC has been criticized for being biased against developing nations, with a disproportionate number of prosecutions coming from poorer countries.
- **Procedural Delays:** Complex procedures can lead to lengthy investigations and trials, raising questions about the efficiency of the court.
- **Enforcement Challenges:** The ICC lacks its own enforcement arm, relying on member states to arrest and imprison convicted individuals. This dependence can be problematic, especially in politically charged cases.
- **Geopolitical Tensions:** The issuance of arrest warrants against prominent figures, like the one for President Putin, can escalate international tensions and hinder diplomatic efforts. Similarly, investigations into conflicts involving regional allies can create friction.
- **Limited Scope:** The ICC can only prosecute individuals, not organizations or states. This can leave some perpetrators of serious crimes unaccountable.

WAY FORWARD TO ADDRESS THESE CONCERNS

Despite these challenges, the ICC remains a crucial institution for international justice. Here are some ways to address these concerns:

- **Universal Membership and Cooperation:** Encouraging all nations to join the ICC and cooperate with its investigations and prosecutions is crucial. This would strengthen the court's legitimacy and enforcement power.
- **Prioritizing Peace:** The ICC should strive to balance justice with the pursuit of peace. Careful consideration of the potential impact on ongoing peace negotiations is essential.
- **Addressing Bias:** The ICC needs to demonstrate impartiality in its investigations and prosecutions. Distributing cases more geographically and ensuring a diverse court staff can help address concerns about bias.

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- **Streamlining Procedures:** Efforts to streamline legal procedures without compromising due process can expedite cases and improve the ICC's effectiveness.
- **Expanding Jurisdiction:** Considering ways to hold organizations and states accountable, potentially through cooperation with other international bodies, could broaden the ICC's reach and impact.

INDIA AND ICC

India has chosen not to join the International Criminal Court (ICC). Here are the key reasons for their abstention:

- **Concerns about Impartiality:** India fears political influence on ICC prosecutors, particularly due to the power wielded by member states.
- **Impact on Sovereignty:** India views ICC involvement as a potential infringement on national sovereignty, particularly regarding jurisdiction over crimes committed within its borders.
- **Evidentiary Challenges:** Gathering evidence for international crimes can be complex, and India is concerned about the difficulties involved in ICC investigations.
- **Limited Scope of Crimes:** The ICC's exclusion of cross-border terrorism and nuclear weapons offences from its jurisdiction is a point of contention for India.
- **Selective Application:** India questions the ICC's commitment to universal justice, citing concerns about the selection of cases.
- **Power of the Prosecutor:** India is wary of the broad investigative powers granted to the ICC prosecutor, fearing potential political motivations.

India's stance on the ICC reflects a desire to maintain control over national security issues and ensure fair trials. While acknowledging the importance of international justice, India seeks a more comprehensive and balanced approach.

DIFFERENCE BETWEEN ICC AND ICJ

Aspect	International Criminal Court (ICC)	International Court of Justice (ICJ)
Establishment	2002	1945
Governing Treaty	Rome Statute	UN Charter
Jurisdiction	Individuals for international crimes	States in disputes
Crimes Addressed	Genocide, war crimes, crimes against humanity, aggression	Legal disputes, advisory opinions
Membership	States parties to the Rome Statute	UN member states
Location	The Hague, Netherlands	The Hague, Netherlands
Judges	18 judges elected for 9-year terms	15 judges elected for 9-year terms
Prosecution	Office of the Prosecutor, independent from UN	No prosecution, only adjudication
Enforcement	Relies on state cooperation	Relies on state compliance, UN Security Council can enforce
Example Cases	Prosecuting war criminals like those in Darfur and Uganda	Border disputes, maritime boundaries, diplomatic relations

CONCLUSION

The ICC's limitations can undermine its ability to deliver impartial justice and deter future atrocities. Addressing these challenges with suitable measures is crucial for strengthening the Court's credibility and ensuring its role in upholding international law.

KEY TERMS: International Crimes (Genocide, Crimes Against Humanity, War Crimes), Accountability, Legitimacy Concerns, UN Security Council Influence, Enforcement Challenges, Geopolitical Tensions, Universal Membership, Expanding Jurisdiction

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INDIAN DIASPORA

INTRODUCTION

- The Indian diaspora refers to a vast network of people with Indian heritage who now live around the world. This community encompasses:
 - **Non-Resident Indians (NRIs):** Indian citizens residing outside India.
 - **Overseas Citizens of India (OCI):** Individuals with Indian ancestry who are not Indian citizens but hold an OCI card (previously PIO cardholders were merged into this category in 2015).
- With over 32 million strong, this global community is spread across various regions, including North America, Europe, Southeast Asia, Africa, and the Middle East.
- Indian diaspora members contribute significantly to diverse fields like business, technology, academia, arts, and culture. They act as a bridge between India and their adopted countries, fostering connections and collaboration.

FACT-WISE

Description	Statistics
Indian diaspora population (MoEA)	32 million (most significant in the world)
Annual remittances to India (World Bank)	Over USD 100 billion
Top destinations of the Indian diaspora	USA, West Asia
Indian diaspora's contribution to the USA population	1.3%
Indian Diaspora's Contribution to UK GDP	6%

INDIA'S EVOLVING DIASPORA POLICY: KEY MILESTONES

- **Early Indifference:** Following independence, Prime Minister Nehru focused on integrating Indians abroad into their host nations. This limited engagement with the diaspora reflected India's foreign policy priorities at the time.
- **Shifting Strategies:** Under Rajiv Gandhi's leadership, India's foreign policy shifted towards inter-third world cooperation. This led to a slight change in diaspora policy. Recognizing their potential, India began inviting skilled diaspora members like Sam Pitroda to contribute to national development. The establishment of the Indian Overseas Affairs Department in 1984 marked this shift.
- **Economic Reforms and Opportunity:** Post-liberalization reforms in the 1990s opened India's economy, enabling the diaspora to actively participate. Their investments and remittances provided crucial support during foreign currency crises, prompting a further review of India's diaspora policy.
- **Vajpayee's Focus on Engagement:** Atal Bihari Vajpayee's government actively fostered connections with the diaspora. This era saw the Ministry for Overseas Indian Affairs established, along with initiatives like PIO cards, Overseas Citizen of India cards, Pravasi Bharatiya Divas celebrations, and NRI funds. Notably, voting rights were extended to Indian citizens abroad.
- **Continued Engagement:** The current government prioritizes the diaspora with initiatives like the 2015 e-migrate system streamlining overseas employment procedures and a database for registering foreign employers. The "Know India Program" (KIP) launched in 2016 aims to connect young people (18-30 years old) with their Indian heritage and contemporary India, further strengthening diaspora engagement.

SIGNIFICANCE OF INDIAN DIASPORA

The Indian diaspora, one of the world's largest, contributes significantly to India's growth and global standing.

- **Economic Powerhouse:** India is the world's largest recipient of remittances, with a significant portion coming from the Middle East. Additionally, lower-skilled labor migration, particularly to West Asia, has helped reduce unemployment in India. Diaspora investments were also instrumental in resolving India's Balance of Payments crisis following economic reforms.

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- **Political Clout:** Individuals of Indian origin hold prominent political positions globally, including in the US, UK, and Pacific island nations like Fiji. Prime Minister Narendra Modi has rightly called them "Rashtrdoot" (ambassadors) for their role in India's foreign policy.
- **Entrepreneurship:** The entrepreneurial spirit of the diaspora is evident in Silicon Valley, where a significant number of Indian-origin CEOs have established successful tech companies.
- **Bridge Builders:** Diaspora communities play a vital role in backchannel diplomacy or Track II diplomacy, acting as intermediaries between India and their adopted nations. For instance, Indian Americans lobbied for the successful Indo-US Civil Nuclear Deal.
- **Cultural Ambassadors:** The diaspora plays a key role in promoting Indian culture, cuisine, traditions, and values worldwide. This enhances India's soft power and attracts tourism.
- **Philanthropy:** Many in the diaspora contribute generously to philanthropic causes in India, supporting education, healthcare, and social development initiatives.
- **Knowledge Transfer:** Diaspora professionals bring valuable knowledge and expertise back to India, fostering innovation and development. For example, Indian-American scientists play a key role in India's space research.



ISSUES OF INDIAN DIASPORA

The Indian diaspora, a vibrant global community, faces a complex web of issues:

- **Economic Concerns:** Reverse migration due to various factors has led to a decline in remittances, impacting families back home. Additionally, global slowdowns and protectionist policies limit job opportunities for Indian professionals abroad (e.g., H-1B visa restrictions in the US).
- **Limited Political Participation:** Navigating complex voting procedures and residency requirements can hinder political participation in their host countries.
- **Brain Drain:** India loses valuable talent when skilled professionals settle abroad, hindering domestic innovation and growth.
- **Safety and Security:** Rising anti-globalization sentiments have fueled hate crimes against Indian communities in some countries. Moreover, political instability in regions like West Asia (e.g., Bahrain, Yemen) poses security threats to Indian workers.
- **Exploitative Labour Practices:** Certain host countries enforce unfair labour laws (e.g., Kafala and Nitaqat in West Asia) that restrict workers' movement and exploit their rights.
- **Second Generation Issues:** Children born and raised overseas may struggle to connect with their Indian heritage, creating a cultural identity crisis.
- **Diaspora Disunity:** The vast diaspora, spread across nations, has diverse needs and priorities. This heterogeneity makes it challenging to formulate a unified policy that addresses all concerns effectively (e.g., some sections in Canada might support separatist movements like Khalistan, which is a major concern for the Indian government).

GOVERNMENT STEPS

- **Social Security Agreements (SSAs):** Bilateral Social Security Agreements (SSAs) safeguard the interests of Indian professionals working overseas, enhancing competitiveness for Indian companies.
- **Simplified Processes:** Initiatives are underway to simplify administrative procedures for the diaspora, such as streamlining passport and visa services, OCI card applications, and other consular services.
- **Streamlined Support:** Merging the Ministry of Overseas Indian Affairs with the Ministry of External Affairs (2016) fosters a more unified approach to diaspora policy and strengthens support services for Indians abroad.
- **Dedicated Assistance:** The Ministry of External Affairs offers dedicated helpline services and welfare cells to address concerns and grievances for the diaspora, providing assistance on various issues.
- **Pandemic Relief:** Financial support programs and relief measures were introduced during the COVID-19 pandemic to aid the diaspora, including assistance for emergencies and welfare schemes for overseas Indians.
- **Preserving Heritage:** Cultural and educational exchange programs promote connections with the diaspora and preserve Indian heritage abroad, fostering cultural ties and knowledge sharing.

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ENGAGING THE DIASPORA: RECENT INITIATIVES

- **Madad Portal:** A one-stop grievance redressal platform for the Indian diaspora. It handles consular issues like compensation claims, legal cases, repatriation assistance, and more.
- **Vande Bharat Mission (2020):** A large-scale repatriation effort during the COVID-19 pandemic. The mission facilitated the return of thousands of stranded Indian citizens from abroad.
- **Vaibhav Summit:** This global summit connects overseas and resident Indian scientists and academics. It focuses on collaboration in crucial areas like AI and aerospace technologies.
- **Diaspora Outreach Events:** Events like Pravasi Bharatiya Divas strengthen ties with the diaspora. They offer opportunities for networking, dialogue, and addressing community concerns.
- **Rescue & Repatriation Missions:** Operations like Rahat and Vande Bharat ensured the safe return of Indians caught in crises abroad, demonstrating the government's commitment to their well-being. (Combined "Rahat, Sankat Mochan, Vande Bharat, and Samudra Setu" for brevity)

WAY FORWARD

- **Addressing Concerns:** Enhance user-friendly platforms like the Madad portal and establish dedicated helplines to provide prompt assistance and address grievances faced by the diaspora.
- **Skilling Up:** Promote skill development programs tailored to the needs of the diaspora. Encourage entrepreneurial ventures and participation in sectors like technology and innovation.
- **Building Bridges:** Strengthen partnerships with host countries through well-defined agreements and regular dialogue. This collaborative approach will ensure the welfare and well-being of Indian citizens abroad.
- **Connecting Roots:** Organize cultural events and exchange programs to strengthen cultural ties and foster a lasting connection with India.
- **Comprehensive Support:** Develop programs to offer financial aid, facilitate access to quality healthcare, and provide repatriation assistance when needed.
- **Streamlined Services:** Improve the efficiency of passport, visa, and OCI card processes for a smoother and less time-consuming experience.
- **Engaging Expertise:** Foster open communication channels and actively seek the diaspora's valuable input in policy-making processes to leverage their knowledge and global perspective.

CONCLUSION

- By implementing above proactive measures, India can strengthen its connection with the vibrant Indian diaspora, fostering a mutually beneficial relationship that leverages the talent, resources, and expertise of its global citizens. This empowered diaspora can then play a vital role in India's continued growth and development.

KEY TERMS: Indian Diaspora, Remittances (USD 100 billion+), Pravasi Bharatiya Divas, PIO/OCI Cards, NRI Funds, e-migrate System, Know India Program (KIP), Economic Powerhouse, Rashtradoot, Bridge Builders, Track II Diplomacy, Cultural Ambassadors, Knowledge Transfer

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Indian diaspora has scaled new heights in the West. Describe its economic and political benefits for India. (10 Marks)	2023
2.	'Indian diaspora has a decisive role to play in the politics and economy of America and European Countries'. Comment with examples.	2020
3.	Indian Diaspora has an important role to play in South-East Asian countries' economy and society. Appraise the role of Indian Diaspora in South- East Asia in this context.	2017

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INDIA AND GEOPOLITICS OF TECHNOLOGY

India is a nation with a booming population, growing economy, and ambitious tech goals. Hence, it finds itself at the center of the complex game of geopolitics of technology. The country strives for self-reliance in critical technologies to lessen dependence on other nations. At the same time, it navigates partnerships for advancements while competing with global powers. Data security and ethical considerations are also crucial aspects as India shapes its technological future.

INDIA'S RISE IN THE GEOPOLITICS OF INFORMATION TECHNOLOGY

Geopolitics of Information and Technology refers to the intersection of technology, information, and global power dynamics. It involves the strategic use of technology, control over information flows, and competition for influence and dominance in the digital realm. India is emerging as a major player in this geopolitics at global level.

- **A Tech Powerhouse:** India is a major player in the IT sector, holding a significant share in the global IT services and e-commerce market (around \$227 billion in 2022). This dominance offers immense potential for further growth.
- **Semiconductor Focus:** The Indian semiconductor market is poised for significant expansion, aiming to reach \$300 billion by 2026. Attracting foreign investment and fostering chip design capabilities are key strategies in this critical technology area.
- **Supercomputing Ambitions:** While India currently ranks 13th in supercomputing with a limited number of indigenous machines, the National Supercomputing Mission aims to increase domestic production.
- **Boosting Manufacturing:** The Production Linked Incentive Scheme aims to stimulate domestic manufacturing of IT products like mobile phones and computer hardware. However, initial results suggest challenges remain, as locally produced PCs haven't yet captured a significant market share.

OBSTACLES FOR INDIA IN TECHNOLOGICAL GEOPOLITICS

- **Digital Divide:** The vast gap in internet access and technology ownership between urban and rural areas creates a significant barrier to inclusion. (E.g., Limited connectivity in villages like Sundarbans, West Bengal)
- **Data Concerns:** Privacy breaches (e.g., Cambridge Analytica scandal) and cybersecurity threats (e.g., attacks on State Bank of India) raise concerns about data security and user trust.
- **Misinformation Epidemic:** The rampant spread of fake news on social media (e.g., false COVID-19 information) creates confusion and disrupts social harmony.
- **Digital Literacy Deficit:** Lack of skills in using technology for online services and transactions hinders wider participation in the digital economy.
- **E-commerce Challenges:** Ensuring fair competition and consumer protection in the e-commerce sector remains a work in progress (e.g., Flipkart-Amazon case).
- **Ethical Dilemmas:** Emerging technologies like facial recognition (e.g., Clearview AI case) raise ethical concerns about bias, discrimination, and privacy.
- **Infrastructure Issues:** Deficient internet infrastructure, particularly in remote areas (e.g., Northeastern states), restricts digital access for a significant portion of the population.

WAY FORWARD

- **Bridging the Gap:** Invest in infrastructure development to ensure nationwide internet access and bridge the digital divide.
- **Tech Access in Diplomacy:** Make access to technology a central aspect of India's diplomatic relations, especially considering its large and growing technological needs.
- **Boost Tech Diplomacy:** Expand on the new, emerging, and strategic technologies (NEST) division by appointing dedicated technology ambassadors to strengthen India's international tech influence.
- **Strengthen Data Governance:** Enact the Digital Personal Data Protection Law (DPDPL) to regulate data privacy, movement, and use.
- **Building a Fair Ecosystem:** Develop regulations that promote healthy competition and protect consumer rights in the e-commerce sector.

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INDIA'S SOFT POWER

Joseph Nye on Soft Power

"A country's ability to influence the preferences and behaviours of various actors in the international arena (states, corporations, communities, publics etc.) through attraction or persuasion rather than coercion."

INTRODUCTION

- The Ministry of External Affairs defines soft power as a nation's ability to influence others through attraction and persuasion, without resorting to force or economic pressure. This stands in contrast to "hard power," which relies on tangible resources like military strength or economic influence.
- India currently holds the 28th position in the 2023 Global Soft Power Index.

PM MODI HAS NOTED 5 IMPORTANT PILLARS OF INDIA'S SOFT POWER

1. Samman (dignity)
2. Samvaad (dialogue)
3. Samriddhi (shared prosperity)
4. Suruksha (regional and global security)
5. Sanskriti evam Sabhayata (Cultural and civilizational links).

INDIA'S SOFT POWER INSTRUMENTS

- **Indian Diaspora:** India's vast diaspora, exceeding 31 million strong, acts as a bridge between India and other nations. This includes Non-Resident Indians (NRIs) with economic clout and Persons of Indian Origin (PIOs) who maintain cultural connections.
- **Parliamentary Goodwill:** Regular exchange visits by Indian parliamentarians foster positive relationships with foreign counterparts, promoting mutual understanding and cooperation.
- **Multilateral Engagement:** India's active participation in international forums like BRICS, G-20, and ASEAN allows it to shape global discourse and collaborate on issues of common interest.
- **Touring the Past:** India's vibrant tourism industry, bolstered by initiatives like Buddhist circuit tours, allows foreigners to experience the country's rich history and cultural tapestry firsthand.
- **Cultural Legacy:** Government initiatives promoting India's magnificent historical sites, museums, and art forms further enhance the country's cultural prestige.
- **Wellness Exports:** The global popularity of Ayurveda, Yoga, and traditional Indian medicine showcases India's holistic approach to health and well-being.
- **Bollywood Boom:** The phenomenal rise of Bollywood as a global entertainment phenomenon projects Indian culture, music, and dance to international audiences.

WHY SOFT POWER MATTERS FOR INDIA?

- **Boosting Foreign Policy:** India's cultural influence, for example, through its strong presence in Middle East, can foster cooperation and goodwill, ultimately aiding foreign policy objectives.
- **Global Leadership:** Soft power allows India to project a positive image and earn respect from other nations, elevating its standing in the international community.
- **Complementing Hard Power:** While military and economic might (hard power) are important, effective diplomacy requires a strong foundation of soft power. Ignoring soft power can lead to isolation and hinder India's strategic goals.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA'S SOFT POWER

- **Coordination Gap:** Disjointed efforts between various government and private entities involved in cultural diplomacy can dilute the impact. Improved collaboration and consultation are essential.
- **Religious Tourism Lag:** Compared to Southeast Asian nations like Thailand and Indonesia, India has underperformed in attracting religious tourists. Capitalizing on its rich spiritual heritage can be a potential growth area.

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- **Limited Resources:** India's soft power efforts are often hampered by a lack of dedicated funding. Timely and adequate budget allocation is crucial for effective promotion.
- **ICCR Ambiguity:** The unclear mandate of the Indian Council for Cultural Relations (ICCR), the primary body for cultural diplomacy, hinders its effectiveness.
- **Negative Image Concerns:** Negative media portrayals of issues like pollution, child labor, and violence against women can deter potential visitors and undermine India's soft power projection.

MEASURES TO OVERCOME CHALLENGES

- **Engaging the Diaspora:** Proactive engagement with the Indian diaspora can leverage their networks to promote Indian culture and achievements abroad. Events celebrating Indian festivals or supporting Indian classical arts performances overseas are examples of such engagement.
- **Measuring Impact:** Developing a "Soft Power Matrix" with objective metrics can help evaluate the effectiveness of initiatives. This could track aspects like international media mentions of Indian culture or tourist arrivals from targeted regions.
- **Learning from Leaders:** A comprehensive study of successful soft power strategies employed by other countries can provide valuable insights. For example, South Korea's global K-Pop phenomenon demonstrates the power of cultural exports.
- **Unified Approach:** Enhanced coordination between the Ministry of External Affairs (MEA) and other relevant bodies like tourism ministries can create a more cohesive national soft power strategy.
- **Global Tourism Focus:** Expanding India's network of tourism offices abroad allows for targeted promotion tailored to specific countries' interests. Highlighting diverse tourist destinations beyond the Taj Mahal can broaden appeal.

By adopting these strategies, India can strategically leverage its soft power to enhance its global standing and forge stronger international relationships.

KEY TERMS: Global Soft Power Index, Indian Diaspora, Parliamentary Goodwill, Multilateral Engagement, Cultural Legacy, Wellness Exports, Religious Tourism Lag, Negative Image Concerns,

CULTURE AS A TOOL OF SOFT POWER

INDIA'S CULTURAL SOFT POWER

- **Ancient Ideal:** The concept of "Vasudhaiva Kutumbakam" (universal kinship) from the Upanishads reflects India's longstanding tradition of religious inclusivity.
- **Historical Legacy:** India's Look East Policy leverages its Buddhist heritage, echoing Emperor Ashoka's emphasis on "dharma-vijaya" (righteous conquest) through Buddhist teachings.
- **Cultural diplomacy:** Cultural diplomacy plays a critical role in shaping India's international image. "Unity in diversity," a core value, reflects the vibrant tapestry of cultures and civilizations that continues to fascinate the world.
- **Rich Diversity:** India boasts a unique religious diversity, with Hinduism, Buddhism, Jainism, and Sikhism originating within its borders, and Zoroastrianism, Judaism, Christianity, and Islam finding a home there.
- **Language and Education:** Initiatives like "Destination India" and "Know India" showcase India's rich heritage and position it as a knowledge hub. The ICCR actively promotes India's educational strengths to attract international students.
- **Media and Communication:** Efforts are underway to strengthen platforms like DD India, expanding its global reach and effectively communicating India's narrative.
- **Beyond Culture:** India's soft power extends further. The GSAT-9 satellite, providing space-based services to South Asia, reflects India's growing space diplomacy. Similarly, "Namaste diplomacy" and advancements in healthcare have positioned India as a reliable partner offering medical expertise and low-cost solutions.

INDIA'S SOFT POWER IN ACTION

India leverages its rich religious heritage to cultivate positive international relations through various initiatives:

- **Promoting Religious Tourism:** The Ministry of Tourism promotes transnational religious tourist circuits, like the Buddhist circuit encompassing sites in India and Nepal, fostering cultural exchange and tourism revenue.
- **Hosting Religious Events:** India plays host to major religious conferences, like the 2011 Global Buddhist Congregation, showcasing its deep connection to these faiths.
- **Strengthen cultural ties.**
- **Engaging the Islamic World:** India's pursuit of membership in the Organisation of Islamic Cooperation (OIC) highlights its commitment to its large Muslim population and seeks to build bridges with Islamic nations.

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- **Leader Engagement:** High-profile visits by foreign leaders to religious sites, like the Japanese Prime Minister's visit to Varanasi (Hinduism and Buddhism) and the Indian Prime Minister's visit to Singapore's Mariamman Temple (Hindu) and Buddha Tooth Relic Temple (Buddhism).
- **Project Mausam:** This initiative aims to strengthen ties and communication within the Indian Ocean region. By enhancing cultural exchange, it fosters mutual understanding and appreciation of diverse values and traditions.

CHALLENGES IN CULTURE AS SOFT POWER

- **Missed Tourism Potential:** India, despite its rich Buddhist heritage, lags behind Southeast Asian nations in attracting Buddhist tourists.
- **Domestic Tensions:** Policies like CAA and NRC have generated religious friction, undermining India's image of tolerance.
- **Emerging Competition:** China's growing focus on Buddhism, with initiatives like the Lumbini project, presents a challenge.
- **Lacklustre Cultural Promotion:** Efforts by bodies like ICCR haven't been entirely effective in promoting India's religious heritage.

STRENGTHENING OUR APPROACH

- **Boosting Religious Tourism:** A multi-faceted strategy involving improved infrastructure, product development, and targeted marketing can attract more visitors. Collaboration between national and local entities is crucial.
- **Neutral Soft Power:** Cultural and religious promotion should emphasise India's rich heritage without political overtones.
- **Revitalising Buddhist Scholarship:** Renewed focus on universities like Nalanda and Buddhist studies programs can solidify India's position as a centre of Buddhist learning.
- **Engaging Civil Society:** Local communities play a vital role in preserving heritage. Public awareness programs can foster a sense of ownership and encourage responsible tourism practices.

By addressing these challenges and implementing effective measures, India can leverage its religious heritage as a powerful tool for soft power, promoting cultural understanding and strengthening its global standing.

PP Chaudhary-led Panel Recommendations

- **Promote India's soft power:** The panel requested that the government lay out a PR plan for promoting India's soft power and cultural diplomacy.
- **Expand Tourism:** MEA was asked to expand its network of tourism offices abroad and use a nation-specific strategy for marketing initiatives.
- **Medicine Diplomacy:** The parliamentary panel urged the government to work diligently to adopt the Indian pharmacopoeia and get recognition for Ayurveda as a medical system.

CONCLUSION

Soft power is a valuable tool in today's world, but it requires a strong foundation of hard power capabilities to be truly effective. India's growing economic and military strength will be crucial in amplifying its soft power initiatives on the global stage. Achieving higher economic growth unlocks resources to invest in soft power initiatives like education, technology, and cultural diplomacy. This creates a virtuous cycle where a strong economy fuels soft power, and a positive global image attracts further economic opportunities.

KEY TERMS: Cultural Diplomacy, Cultural Magnetism, Cross-Cultural Understanding, Cultural Exchange Programs, Cultural Ambassadors, Space Diplomacy (GSAT-9), Namaste Diplomacy.

PREVIOUS YEAR QUESTIONS

1.	Terrorist activities and mutual distrust have clouded India-Pakistan relations. To what extent the use of soft power like sports and cultural exchange could help generate goodwill between the two countries? Discuss with suitable examples.	2015
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ENERGY DIPLOMACY

Energy diplomacy involves government actions abroad that aim to secure a nation's energy needs while creating business opportunities in the energy sector. It has two key goals:

- **Ensuring Energy Security:** This involves securing reliable and sustainable energy sources to fuel both societal needs and economic growth.
- **Leveraging Energy:** This involves using energy resources as a tool to influence foreign policy and develop strategic partnerships.

INDIA'S ENERGY DIPLOMACY IN ACTION

India actively pursues energy diplomacy through several initiatives:

- **Renewable Energy Cooperation:** India champions renewable energy through the **International Solar Alliance and its "One Sun One World One Grid (OSOWOG)" initiative**. This ambitious project aims to connect regional grids, enabling the transfer of clean energy across borders.
- **Power Transmission:** India is a key player in regional power transmission. As part of the 2014 SAARC agreement, India exports electricity to neighbouring countries like Bangladesh, Nepal, and Bhutan.
- **Hydroelectric Power:** India imports hydropower from Bhutan through plants like Tala, Chukha, Kurichu, and Mangdechhu. Additionally, India is involved in hydropower projects in Nepal, such as the Mahakali Treaty, the Upper Karnali Project, and the Arun projects.
- **Pipeline Connectivity:** India is involved in pipeline projects like the Turkmenistan-Afghanistan-Pakistan-India (TAPI) pipeline, which will transport natural gas from Turkmenistan to participating countries.
- **Nuclear Energy Partnerships:** Strategic partnerships, like the Indo-US Nuclear Deal and the India-Japan Civil Nuclear Deal, allow India access to nuclear technologies for peaceful purposes.

CHALLENGES IN INDIA'S ENERGY DIPLOMACY

- **Tech Reliance and Security:** The energy sector's high dependence on technology creates challenges. Without a strong international framework for cybersecurity, the growing digitalization and interconnectedness of the energy sector can raise security and privacy concerns.
- **Coal Dominance vs. Renewables:** Coal still accounts for nearly half of India's power generation, overshadowing renewable sources like wind, solar, and biomass, which contribute only around 26%.
- **Infrastructure Hurdles:** Developing and maintaining cross-border pipelines and electricity transmission grids presents significant challenges.
- **Limited Import Sources:** India relies heavily on the Persian Gulf region for over 60% of its oil and gas imports, making it vulnerable to geopolitical disruptions.
- **Pricing Challenges:** Determining fair transmission charges for electricity traded across interconnected regional networks can be complex.

WAY FORWARD FOR ENERGY SECURITY

- **Collaboration on Grid Governance:** Developing robust international cooperation and appropriate frameworks can ensure effective management of cross-border electricity grids.
- **Investment and Funding:** India's commitment to invest US \$2 billion in international solar finance by 2025 demonstrates a move towards cleaner energy sources.
- **Diversifying Imports:** India needs to strategically diversify its import sources to avoid dependence on specific regions or countries.
- **Leveraging Location:** India's geographical proximity to energy-rich areas presents a strategic advantage that can be utilized to secure resources.

Despite above challenges, India has the potential to overcome them through strategic planning and international collaboration. Diversifying energy imports, leveraging its geographical advantage, and investing in renewable energy sources are crucial steps. Furthermore, fostering international cooperation on infrastructure development and cybersecurity frameworks can pave the way for a more secure and sustainable energy future for India.

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DEFENCE DIPLOMACY

India's defence diplomacy focuses on building strategic partnerships and fostering cooperation among armed forces. This collaborative approach aims to advance shared interests and achieve foreign policy goals. Here are some key aspects of it:

- **Cooperation and Collaboration:** India has defence cooperation agreements with over 53 countries, promoting joint military exercises (e.g., Malabar Exercise) and participation in international forums (e.g., RATS-SCO). This collaborative approach fosters regional stability and strengthens relations.
- **Confidence Building:** Defence cooperation signals a commitment to peaceful coexistence and promotes military transparency, fostering trust and shared interests.
- **Economic Benefits:** The Defence Production and Export Promotion Policy 2020 promotes the export of aerospace and defence goods and services, boosting India's defence industry. Additionally, co-production of weapons systems and technology transfer fosters research and development.
- **Boosting Capabilities:** Defence cooperation allows Indian forces to gain exposure to advanced technologies, doctrines, and combat experience of partner nations, leading to capacity building.

CHALLENGES IN DEFENCE DIPLOMACY

- **Geopolitical Concerns:** China's assertive actions in the region pose a significant challenge.
- **Structural Limitations:** A lack of dedicated defence wings in many embassies compared to major powers hinders effective cooperation.
- **Inconsistent Implementation:** Defence cooperation currently operates on a country-by-country basis, lacking a unified strategy.
- **Coordination Issues:** Disjointed communication between ministries involved in defence cooperation can hinder efficient implementation.
- **Resource Constraints:** Limited defence spending (2% of GDP in 2022-23) can restrict capabilities and partnerships.

RECOMMENDATIONS FOR STRENGTHENING DEFENCE DIPLOMACY

- **Policy Framework:** Developing clear policy guidelines can ensure defence cooperation activities align with foreign policy objectives.
- **Integrated Planning:** Expanding defence cooperation and establishing a strategic military presence globally can safeguard national interests.
- **Specialized Personnel:** Dedicated and experienced officers specializing in defence cooperation can oversee its various aspects.
- **Regional Focus:** Strengthening relations with neighboring countries can counter China's influence and promote regional stability.
- **Evaluation and Improvement:** Regular audits of activities are crucial to assess cost-effectiveness and ensure focus on key areas.

By addressing these challenges and implementing the proposed measures, India can strengthen its defence diplomacy and further its security and cooperation goals.

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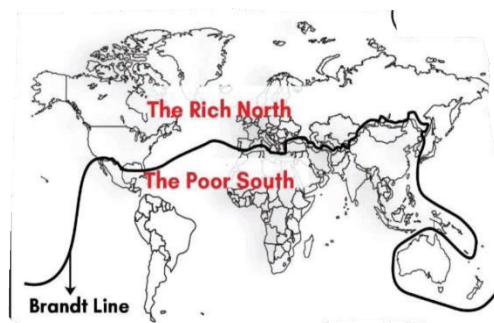
INDIA AND THE GLOBAL SOUTH

INTRODUCTION

- **Recent Context:** Recently, India hosted the **Second Voice of the Global South Summit (VOGSS)**. The summit aimed to maintain the positive momentum established towards a world order that is more inclusive, representative, and progressive.
- PM Modi unveiled **DAKSHIN**, a centre dedicated to excellence within the Global South. He also emphasised the importance of **five key principles for the Global South**: Consultation, Cooperation, Communication, Creativity, and Capacity Building.
- India had previously hosted the **inaugural VOGSS**, which brought together 125 countries from the Global South under the theme "**Unity of Voice, Unity of Purpose.**"

THE GLOBAL SOUTH:

- In **1980**, **Brandt line** geographically divided the world into northern richer and southern poor nations.
- Based on this, the **global south** refers to countries in Asia, Africa, and Latin America that are generally less economically developed than the industrialised nations of the Global North. These countries often share common experiences of colonialism and a desire for a more equitable international order.
- **India's Position:** India, with its large population and emerging economy, is a significant player in the Global South. It advocates for the interests of developing countries on issues like trade, climate change, and global governance.



SIGNIFICANCE OF GLOBAL SOUTH

- **Climate Change Vulnerability:** Rising sea levels, extreme weather events, and disrupted agriculture threaten the Global South. They require international support to adapt.
- **South-South Cooperation:** Collaboration among developing nations allows them to share experiences and best practices in tackling poverty and inequality.
- **Natural Resource Wealth:** The Global South is rich in natural resources, but sustainable management is essential to fuel development without environmental harm.
- **Energy Transition:** Financing is crucial for developing clean energy sources and transitioning away from fossil fuels, ensuring energy security and justice.

INDIA'S STRATEGY TOWARDS THE GLOBAL SOUTH

- **Championing Common Issues:** India works with other developing countries to address shared challenges like poverty, hunger, and access to healthcare.
- **Building Strategic Alliances:** India strengthens its ties with other developing countries, particularly in Africa, to enhance its influence on the global stage.
- **Focus on South-South Cooperation:** India promotes cooperation among developing countries through initiatives like sharing expertise, technology transfer, and capacity building.
- **Countering Neo-Colonialism:** India resists dominance by wealthier nations and pushes for a more multipolar world order where the voices of the South are heard.

CHALLENGES

- **Past Ineffectiveness:** Existing organizations like the Non-Aligned Movement haven't been highly successful in advocating for developing countries.
- **Domestic Priorities:** India's own development challenges, like limited resources, can limit its ability to support others.
- **Diversity and Disunity:** The vast economic differences and political disagreements among developing nations make it difficult to form a unified voice.

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- **Western Influence:** The financial dominance of Western nations limits India's ability to provide significant financial aid.

ENHANCING ENGAGEMENT

- **Development Partnerships:** Collaboration with like-minded countries on projects like the Asia-Africa Growth Corridor can benefit the Global South.
- **Regular Cooperation:** Frequent summits can foster collaboration and shared solutions.
- **Building Trust:** Cultural exchange programs and confidence-building measures can strengthen relationships.
- **Championing Interests:** India can leverage its positions in forums like the G-20 to prioritise the needs and aspirations of developing nations.

CONCLUSION

The Global South is both at risk and holds the key to a sustainable future. Further, India's successful engagement with the Global South requires navigating challenges of diversity and past limitations. By fostering strong partnerships, prioritizing shared interests, and promoting development projects, India can play a key role in empowering developing nations.

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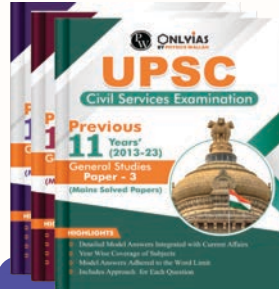
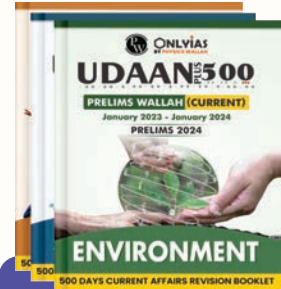
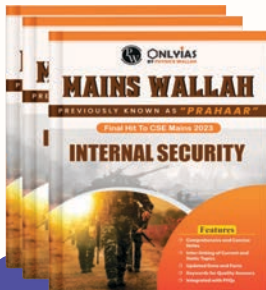
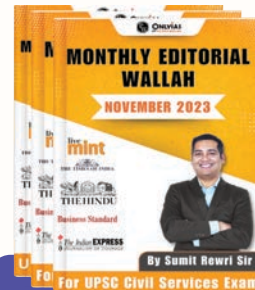
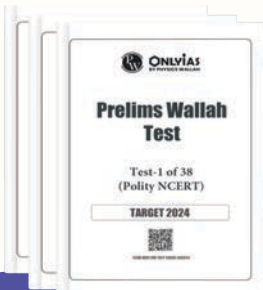
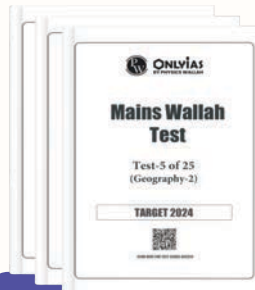
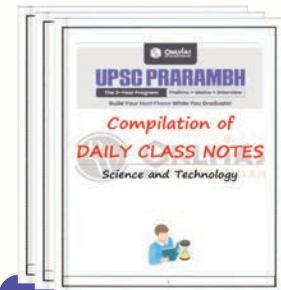
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